

1 Factors affecting inferences on natural mortality and
2 associated environmental effects in state-space
3 age-structured assessment models

4 Timothy J. Miller^{1,2} Gregory L. Britten³ Elizabeth N. Brooks²

5 Gavin Fay⁴ Alexander C. Hansell² Christopher M. Legault²

6 Brandon Muffley⁵ John Wiedenmann⁶

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8 ¹corresponding author: timothy.j.miller@noaa.gov

9 ²Northeast Fisheries Science Center, Woods Hole Laboratory, 166 Water Street, Woods
10 Hole, MA 02543 USA

11 ³Biology Department, Woods Hole Oceanographic Institution, 266 Woods Hole Rd. Woods
12 Hole, MA, USA

13 ⁴Department of Fisheries Oceanography, School for Marine Science and Technology,
14 University of Massachusetts Dartmouth, 836 S Rodney French Boulevard, New Bedford,
15 MA 02744, USA

16 ⁵Mid-Atlantic Fishery Management Council, 800 North State Street, Suite 201, Dover, DE
17 19901 USA

¹⁸ ⁶Department of Ecology, Evolution, and Natural Resources. Rutgers University

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Abstract

Treatment of natural mortality is a major consideration in assessment models and state-space approaches allow estimation of temporal variation in this mortality rate as well as effects of specific covariates. However, there has been no investigation of the reliability of inferences made from state-space assessment models when there is process error or covariate effects on natural mortality. We conducted a large-scale simulation study with operating models simulating data assuming alternative levels of observation error, types and magnitude of process error, and magnitude of covariate effects on natural mortality. We fit estimating models to the simulated data with alternative assumptions regarding the inclusion of covariate effects, estimation of the median natural mortality rate, and type of process error. We found estimating covariate effects on natural mortality required ideal scenarios with lower observation uncertainty, contrast in fishing pressure, and higher covariate variability, but the source of process error could be mis-specified. Estimation of spawning stock biomass and fishing mortality was also reliable in a wider range of scenarios even when estimating the median natural mortality rate.

keywords: state-space assessment models, time-varying natural mortality, bias, AIC

Introduction

State-space population models are now used widely for fisheries stock assessment in Europe, the United States, and Canada (Nielsen and Berg, 2014; Cadigan, 2016; Pedersen and Berg, 2017; Stock and Miller, 2021). Because application of these methods are considered best practice and recommended for the next generation of stock assessment models (Hoyle et al., 2022; Punt, 2023), it is expected their use will only grow globally. An appeal of state-space models lies in their separation of sources of biological and measurement variability by treating temporal variation in population characteristics as latent stochastic processes with periodic observations measured with error. Through advances in computational capacity, we can use sophisticated numerical approaches to estimate parameters of these models as a combination of fixed and random effects (Thorson and Minto, 2015; Kristensen et al., 2016).

State-space stock assessment models with non-linear functions of latent processes and numerous observation types with different probability distributions, represent one of the most complex classes of state-space models. Our understanding of the effects of various factors on reliability of inferences from state-space assessment models is growing (Li et al., 2024; Miller et al., In reviewa). The importance of temporal contrast in population size and fishing mortality (F) and quality of data used to fit both traditional and state-space assessment models is known (Magnusson and Hilborn, 2007; Miller et al., In reviewa). Furthermore, estimation of natural mortality (M), and even temporal variability in M , is possible in many scenarios (Lee et al., 2011; Cadigan, 2016; Miller and Hyun, 2018; Miller et al., In reviewa).

The effects of temporal variation in recruitment via undefined or explicit environmental factors have been extensively investigated in both traditional assessment models and state-space models (Myers, 1998; Haltuch and Punt, 2011; Johnson et al., 2016; Miller et al., 2016). Reliability of estimating environmental and spawning biomass effects on recruitment in state-space assessment models requires a combination of strong effects, informative age composition data, contrast in the environmental covariate, and low variability of recruitment

deviations (Britten et al., 2026; Miller et al., In reviewa).

A critical aspect of fisheries assessment models and their use in management is short-term projections that are used to determine catch advice. While understanding drivers of recruitment is important, particularly for subsequent effects on reference points, recruitment in short-term projections typically has little impact on the exploitable biomass in the first few projection years. However, assumptions for M have immediate and larger effects on projected biomass because they affect the abundances at older age classes at the end of the data time series that constitute spawning biomass and catch (Brodziak et al., 2008; Stock et al., 2021).

Because of the effects of M on both biological reference points and short-term projections, better understanding sources of variation in M would provide more accurate estimation of abundance and productivity and, therefore, improved management. Temporal variation in M is less studied than recruitment, but its importance for explaining variability in observations has been demonstrated in state-space assessment models for Atlantic cod and yellowtail flounder (Cadigan, 2016; Stock et al., 2021). Deriso et al. (2008) also demonstrated the importance of several factors affecting M for Pacific herring.

Assessment models could include temporal variation in many aspects of population dynamics or how observations are related to the population. For example, the Woods Hole Assessment Model (WHAM) can include process errors treated as random effects for annual changes in cohort abundance (hereafter referred to as apparent survival), catchability for indices of abundance, selectivity of fishing fleets or indices, movement between regions, or in M (Stock and Miller, 2021; Miller et al., 2025). However, mis-specifying the type of temporal variation could lead to biased estimation of population size and stock status and, therefore, poor fisheries management decisions (Legault and Palmer, 2016; Szuwalski et al., 2018). Studies of the reliability of identifying temporal variability in M are limited. Miller et al. (In reviewa) found AIC could accurately distinguish process errors in apparent survival but not

for those specifically due to M except when uncertainty in population observations (indices, catch, and age composition) was low and there was greater temporal variation in M . Li et al. (2024) found that including more sources of process error than existed in the operating model (OM) was a better model-building approach than excluding them *a priori*.

Here, we present results from a simulation study with OMs varying by degree of observation-error uncertainty, sources of process error, fishing history, temporal variation in environmental covariates, and magnitude of the covariate effect on M . We fit the simulated observations from these OMs with estimating models (EMs) that make alternative assumptions for sources of process error and whether median M and covariate effects were estimated. We evaluated the effects of these factors on 1) convergence of fitted models; 2) whether Akaike’s information criterion (AIC) can determine the correct source of process error and correct assumption about covariate effects on M ; 3) estimation bias for median M and covariate effects; and 4) the accuracy for estimators of important terminal year M and spawning stock biomass (SSB).

Methods

Our analyses used WHAM to construct both OMs and EMs (Miller and Stock, 2020; Stock and Miller, 2021; Miller et al., 2025). WHAM has been used extensively to configure OMs and EMs for several other simulation studies (Stock et al., 2021; Legault et al., 2023; Li et al., 2024; Britten et al., 2026; Li et al., 2026a) and is used to assess many commercially important stocks in the Northeast U.S. (e.g., NEFSC, 2022a,b, 2024). We used version 1.0.6.9000 (commit 77bbd94) to generate all results.

We completed a simulation study with 288 OMs. The factors defining the configuration of each OM, described in detail in subsequent sections, include source of process error (3 levels), index and catch observation uncertainty (2 levels), environmental covariate uncertainty (2 levels), temporal variation in the latent environmental covariate (4 levels), size of the

113 covariate effect on M (3 levels), and fishing history (2 levels). We simulated 100 data sets
 114 for each OM that included simulations of process errors.

115 For each simulated data set we fit a set of 12 EMs. The factors that distinguish the EMs, also
 116 described in detail below, include source of population process error type (3 levels) whether
 117 median M was estimated or assumed known (2 levels), and whether the environmental
 118 covariate effect on M was estimated or not (2 levels).

119 The sources of population process error that were used in the OMs or assumed in the EMs
 120 were on recruitment only (R), recruitment and apparent survival (R+S), or recruitment and
 121 M (R+M). We did not use the log-normal bias-correction feature for process errors or obser-
 122 vations described by Stock and Miller (2021) for OMs and EMs. Using this correction with
 123 random effects and estimation of fixed effects via marginal likelihood can result in substan-
 124 tial bias in assessment output such as recruitment and SSB (Li et al., 2026b). Simulations
 125 were all carried out on the University of Massachusetts Green High-Performance Comput-
 126 ing Cluster. Code for completing the simulations and summarizing results can be found at
 127 https://github.com/timjmiller/SSRTWG/ecov_study/mortality.

128 **Operating models**

129 **Environmental covariate**

130 In WHAM, environmental covariates are modeled as state-space processes with annual ob-
 131 servations of the true latent covariate (Miller et al., 2016; Stock and Miller, 2021). In our
 132 simulations, we assumed the latent covariate to be a stationary first order autoregressive
 133 (AR1) process,

$$X_y|X_{y-1} \sim N\left(\mu_E(1 - \rho_E) + \rho_EX_{y-1}, (1 - \rho_E^2)\sigma_E^2\right),$$

134 with marginal mean $\mu_E = 0$ and variance σ_E^2 . The four configurations of the latent environ-
 135 mental covariate in the OMs assume one of two values for the marginal standard deviation

136 $\sigma_E \in \{0.1, 0.5\}$ and for the autocorrelation parameter $\rho_E \in \{0, 0.5\}$.

137 WHAM treats the observations of the latent environmental covariate (x_y) as unbiased and
138 normal conditional on the true covariate X_y ,

$$x_y|X_y \sim N(X_y, \sigma_e^2).$$

139 The standard deviation of the environmental observations in the OMs was one of two val-
140 ues $\sigma_e \in \{0.1, 0.5\}$. Figure S1 provides example simulations of the latent covariate and
141 observations under the alternative configurations.

142 **Population**

143 Many of the characteristics of the population biology and structure including the age classes
144 (10 age classes: 1 to 10+), time span (40 years), maturity (Figure S2, top left), growth
145 (Figure S2, top right), time of spawning (1/4 of the year), and recruitment (Figure S2,
146 bottom right) were identical to Miller et al. (In reviewa). The maturity at age was a logistic
147 function with age at 50% maturity (a_{50}) = 2.89 and slope = 0.88 and weight at age was
148 derived from a von Bertalanffy growth function where $t_0 = 0$, $L_\infty = 85$, and $k = 0.3$, and a
149 length–weight relationship

$$W_a = \theta_1 L_a^{\theta_2},$$

150 where $\theta_1 = e^{-12.1}$ and $\theta_2 = 3.2$.

151 In WHAM, the general model for M in year y is a log-linear function of both covariate effects
152 X_y and process errors $\varepsilon_{M,y}$ and a parameter β_M that defines median M ,

$$\log M_y = \beta_M + \beta_E X_y + \varepsilon_{M,y},$$

153 where the process errors are modeled as random effects that may, in general, be autocorre-

lated Gaussian random variables,

$$\varepsilon_{M,y}|\varepsilon_{M,y-1} \sim N\left(\varepsilon_{M,y-1}, (1 - \rho_M^2)\sigma_M^2\right)$$

(Stock and Miller, 2021), but we assumed $\rho_M = 0$ in our R+M OMs. We assumed the median M , $e^{\beta_M} = 0.2$, was constant across ages. For R and R+S OMs and EMs, $\varepsilon_{M,y} = 0$. For all R+M OMs, we assumed the standard deviation $\sigma_M = 0.3$, which was estimated in the R+M EMs. The covariate effect was one of 3 alternative values in the OMs, $\beta_E \in \{0, 0.25, 0.5\}$. The parameters defining the simulated covariate time series, size of the covariate effect, and any M random effects resulted in a range of different levels of variation in annual M values (Figure S3).

We assumed expected recruitment each year was from a Beverton–Holt stock-recruit relationship (SRR)

$$R_y = \frac{aSSB_{y-1}}{1 + bSSB_{y-1}}.$$

All biological inputs to calculations of SSB per recruit (i.e., weight, maturity, and M at age) were constant in the R and R+S OMs without covariate effects on M . Therefore, steepness and equilibrium unfished recruitment were also constant over the time period for those OMs (Miller and Brooks, 2021). As in Miller et al. (In reviewa), our assumed biological inputs and selectivity (defined below) with constant M resulted in the equilibrium F that reduces SSB per recruit to 40% of the unfished level being $F_{40\%} = 0.348$. With an assumed unfished recruitment of $R_0 = e^{10}$, setting $F_{MSY} = F_{40\%}$ results in a steepness of 0.69 and $a = 0.60$ and $b = 2.4 \times 10^{-5}$. For R+M OMs and all OMs with covariate effects on M , steepness was not constant but we used the same a and b parameters as other OMs which equates to a steepness and R_0 at the median (or mean on log-scale) of the time series models for M and the covariate.

We also used the same two fishing scenarios as Miller et al. (In reviewa) for OMs. In the first scenario, the stock experienced overfishing at $2.5F_{MSY}$ for the first 20 years followed by

fishing at F_{MSY} for the last 20 years (denoted $2.5F_{\text{MSY}} \rightarrow F_{\text{MSY}}$). In the second scenario, the stock was fished at F_{MSY} for the entire time period (40 years). The magnitude of the overfishing assumptions was intended to reflect estimates of overfishing for Northeast US groundfish stocks from Wiedenmann et al. (2019).

We configured all R, R+S, and R+M OMs with uncorrelated random effects on recruitment with standard deviation on $\log(\text{recruitment})$ $\sigma_R = 0.5$. Miller et al. (In review) used this same assumption for R+M OMs and other OMs with fishery selectivity and index catchability process errors. For R+S OMs, apparent survival process errors were uncorrelated with $\sigma_{2+} = 0.3$. These standard deviations were on the lower end of the range of values estimated for groundfish stocks in the NE US (see Table S1 in Britten et al., 2026).

Catch and index observations

We defined the generation of observations of aggregate (total combined across ages) catch and indices and corresponding age composition identical to Miller et al. (In review). There was a single fleet operating year round for catch observations with logistic selectivity defined with $a_{50} = 5$ and slope = 1 (Figure S2, bottom left). Observations were generated for all 40 years of the model. There were two index time series intended to represent fishery-independent surveys occurring in the spring (0.25 way through the year) and the fall (0.75 way through the year). We assumed catchability of both surveys to be 0.3.

WHAM treats the aggregate catch and index observations as log-normal and we assumed the standard deviation parameter was 0.1 for all annual catch observations. We assumed catch and index age-composition observations were generated from a logistic-normal distribution where errors on the multivariate normal scale were independent (Aitchison and Shen, 1980; Stock and Miller, 2021; Trijoulet et al., 2023). The standard deviation parameter was also constant across ages. There were two levels of observation uncertainty for aggregate indices and age composition for both indices and fleet catch. A low-uncertainty specification assumed

standard deviation parameter equal to 0.1 for all annual aggregate index observations and the standard deviation of the logistic-normal for all age-composition observations was 0.3. In the high-uncertainty specification the standard deviation parameter for the annual aggregate index observations was 0.4 and that for the age-composition observations was 1.5.

Estimating models

There were three factors defining the configuration of each EM: 1) whether β_M was estimated or assumed known; 2) whether an environmental effect β_E was estimated or not; and 3) whether the process errors were assumed on recruitment only (R), recruitment and apparent survival (R+S), or recruitment and M (R+M). We fit each EM to each of 100 simulated data sets from each OM. The configuration of the process errors in the EMs generally matched the corresponding options in the OMs. For example, random effects were assumed uncorrelated for R EMs and R OMs and for R+S EMs and R+S OMs. However, R+M EMs did not assume M random effects were uncorrelated (ρ_M was estimated) although they were simulated without correlation in the R+M OMs. The environmental covariate observations were included in all EMs, whether effects on M were estimated or not, to ensure comparability of AIC. All fixed-effects parameters for selectivity, catchability, fully-selected F , mean recruitment, initial abundance at age, and standard deviations for logistic-normal age-composition distributions were estimated. Any process-error variance parameters for recruitment, apparent survival, and M were also estimated. For all EMs, the standard deviation parameters for aggregate catch, index, and environmental covariates were assumed known at the true value whereas that for the logistic-normal age-composition observations was estimated.

Measures of reliability

EM convergence

We measured the frequency of convergence when fitting each EM to the simulated data sets for each OM. There are various ways to assess convergence of the fit (e.g., Carvalho et al., 2021) but we defined successful convergence as the Hessian of the marginal log-likelihood being invertible and providing variance estimates for the fixed effects parameters as recommended by Miller et al. (In reviewa).

AIC for model selection

We measured the frequency of correct model selection using marginal AIC, known to be appropriate for mixed-effects models specifically when the analyst is interested in fixed effects rather than random effects (Vaida and Blanchard, 2005). Other studies have shown the utility of marginal AIC in distinguishing process error and other model structure for state-space assessment models applied to a particular stock (Miller and Hyun, 2018; Stock and Miller, 2021).

For a given OM, the set of EMs that were compared all made the same assumption about β_M (estimated or treated as known at the true value). For EM m , the marginal AIC is a function of the marginal log-likelihood maximized with respect to the estimated fixed effects in the EM θ and the number of estimated fixed effects $n(\theta)$,

$$\text{AIC}_m = -2 [\text{argmax}_{\theta} \log L_m(\theta) - n(\theta)].$$

All EM fits that successfully completed the optimization were used for this set of analyses. We did not condition on convergence as defined above because some lack of convergence would be expected for the correct behavior of more complicated models that include process errors that did not exist in the OM. For example R+M EMs fit to R OMs would be expected

to estimate no variance in the M random effects and the estimated variance parameter going to zero would cause poor convergence but have the same marginal log-likelihood (with more fixed effects) and therefore higher AIC as expected. The correct EM made the correct assumption for the source of process errors (R, R+S, R+M) and either included a covariate effect on M when an effect was simulated ($\beta_E \in \{0.25, 0.5\}$) or did not include an effect when one was not simulated ($\beta_E = 0$).

Parameter estimation bias and accuracy

All results here used OM simulations with fits that satisfied the Hessian-based convergence criterion described above. We used this conditioning to reflect how practitioners would proceed in analyses of model fits with real assessment data.

We focused on statistical behavior of estimators of the covariate effect on M ($\hat{\beta}_E$); the median M parameter ($\hat{\beta}_M$); and terminal year M , SSB, and fully-selected fishing mortality (F). In preliminary analyses we examined results for the estimators of all the annual values for M , SSB and F over the whole time series, but we found no appreciable differences in patterns across the various factors defining the OMs and EMs. Furthermore, because results for terminal year F were generally inversely related to those for SSB, they are not discussed further but provided in the Supplementary Materials.

We calculated errors of $\hat{\beta}_E$ and $\hat{\beta}_M$, and the Hessian-based standard error estimators of these parameters ($\widehat{SE}(\hat{\beta}_E)$ and $\widehat{SE}(\hat{\beta}_M)$) as

$$\delta_i = \hat{\theta}_i - \theta_i$$

where θ_i is the true value of a given parameter or attribute for simulation i and $\hat{\theta}_i$ is the estimate from an EM fitted to data from simulation i . We defined the true standard error as the standard deviation of estimates across converged fits of a given EM and OM combination.

268 We calculated the relative errors for terminal year M , SSB, and F as

$$\text{RE}_i(\theta_i) = \frac{\hat{\theta}_i - \theta_i}{\theta_i}. \quad (1)$$

269 To measure accuracy we also calculated the root mean square error (RMSE),

$$\text{RMSE}(\hat{\theta}) = \sqrt{\frac{1}{n} \sum (\hat{\theta}_i - \theta_i)^2},$$

270 where n is the number of simulations with converged fits of a given EM and OM. The true
 271 values for terminal year SSB, and in some OMs M (R+M OMs and any OM with covariate
 272 effects on M), varied among simulations. Finally, we calculated 95% confidence intervals for
 273 $\hat{\beta}_E$ and $\hat{\beta}_M$ using Hessian-based standard error estimates for converged EMs that estimated
 274 these parameters in each OM simulation and recorded whether they included the true value.

275 Estimation of terminal year M could appear to be unbiased even for EMs that assumed
 276 no temporal variation in M because the assumed or estimated β_M parameter can be equal
 277 or near the median of the true terminal year values. This centering of the true values at
 278 the constant value of M in the EM happens because the mean of the M process error and
 279 covariate distributions were assumed equal to 0. Therefore, we calculated the correlation of
 280 estimates and simulated values for terminal year M for a given EM and OM combination,

$$\text{Cor}(\hat{M}, M) = \frac{\text{Cov}(\hat{M}, M)}{\text{SD}(\hat{M}) \text{SD}(M)}.$$

281 For R+M OMs and any other OMs where there were covariate effects on M , high correlation
 282 (approaching 1) along with median relative errors close to 0 indicates ability of the EM to
 283 estimate annual M . If correlation and median relative errors are both near 0, this indicates
 284 no ability to estimate annual M . Note also that the correlation is undefined when either the
 285 estimated or true value are constant across simulations because the corresponding standard
 286 deviations are 0. This applies to R and R+S EMs that assumed β_M to be known and

$\beta_E = 0$, and R and to R+S OM s where $\beta_E = 0$. We also did not use calculated correlations for EM s when there were only two converged fits because they are uninformative. Because true terminal year SSB values also varied across simulations we made the same correlation calculations for them as well.

Summarizing results across OM and EM attributes

There were numerous OM and EM attributes across all simulation scenarios and, like Miller et al. (In review a), we used two methods to summarize the major factors explaining differences in results for each measure of reliability. First, we fit regression models with the responses as the measures of reliability described above and the predictor variables were defined based on OM and EM attributes (e.g., MacKinnon et al., 1995; Wang et al., 2017; Harwell et al., 2018). We used logistic regression for binary indicators of convergence and AIC-based selection of the appropriate assumption of the covariate effect on M . For indicators of AIC-based selection of EM process error source (multiple categories), we performed multinomial regressions. For other measures of reliability we fit ordinary linear regression models. Relative errors of terminal year M , SSB, and F (Eq. 1) are bounded below at -1, so we used a transformation of these values

$$f(\hat{\theta}_i, \theta_i) = \log [\text{RE}(\hat{\theta}_i, \theta_i) + 1]. \quad (2)$$

We omitted fits where estimated terminal year SSB, M , or F was equal to zero because of the undefined transformation. RMSE is bounded below at 0 so we used a log transformation for responses in corresponding regressions. We did not use any transformation for the correlation of estimated and true values for terminal year M and SSB. Note there was only one RMSE and correlation calculated for an EM from all simulation fits that converged from a given OM scenario. For all regressions we fit separate models with just individual OM and EM factors included, all factors combined, with all second order interactions, and with all third order

interactions. For the multinomial regression, we used the `vglm` function from the VGAM package (Yee, 2008, 2015). We calculated percent reduction of residual deviance (from the null model with no factors) for each of the regression fits. As Miller et al. (In reviewa) noted, there is a lack of independence of the results for each EM fitted to the same simulated data set of a given OM and therefore we did not perform formal statistical analyses of effects of OM and EM attributes.

For the second summarization method, we used classification and regression trees (Breiman et al., 1984) to illustrate the primary OM and EM attributes and interactions that partition the values for each measure of reliability (e.g., Gonzalez et al., 2018; Collier et al., 2022). We used classification trees for categorical measures (convergence and AIC model selection) and regression trees for the other measures with continuous scales (errors, relative error, and RMSE). The response variables were the same as the regressions for the deviance reduction analyses. We used the `rpart` function in the `rpart` package (Therneau and Atkinson, 2025) to fit trees. Full trees were determined using default settings except that we increased the number of cross-validations to 100. For one classification tree fitted to AIC selection of process error configuration results for R+S OMs, we had to make a small changes to the default prior probabilities (the proportions of each class in the data) used in the criterion on whether to allow branches from a given node because the default priors would not produce any branches. For clarity, we manually pruned the full trees to show just the primary branches.

All OM and EM factors we used to examine reductions in deviance and regression trees are given in Table S1. We provide more detailed results for each EM and OM configuration in the Supplementary Materials using similar methods to Miller et al. (In reviewa). The detailed results present probability of convergence, probability of each EM having lowest AIC, median error and RMSE of β_M and β_E and corresponding standard error estimates, and median relative error and RMSE for terminal year SSB, F , and M . There are also detailed results for correlation of estimates and true values for terminal year M and SSB.

Results

EM Convergence

For fitted logistic regression models to indicators of convergence, the EM process error assumption provided the largest percent reduction in deviance (9-25%) of all OM and EM attributes for all three OM process error types (Table 1). Including second order interactions of OM and EM factors also provided further reduction of residual deviance (between 7 and 11%), indicating successful convergence depended on a combination of OM and EM attributes.

Classification trees for each OM process error source all had the primary branches defined using the attribute (EM process error assumption) that also provided the largest reduction in deviance (Figure 1). Across all fits for each OM process error configuration, convergence was best for R+S OMs, but better convergence occurred when the process error was correct for R and R+S OMs. For R+M OMs, R EMs converged well (88%), but good convergence of R+M EMs occurred for any true process error source if the OMs also had constant fishing pressure and EMs assumed median M parameter (β_M) to be known. All branches based on observation error of covariates or other assessment data (indices and age composition) showed better convergence with more precise observations. Better convergence also occurred when EMs assumed no covariate effects (regardless of whether the OM simulated them), when EMs assumed median M was known, and when OMs assumed greater temporal variability in the true environmental covariate.

AIC performance

Process error source selection

For all OM process error types, the level of error in both the population and covariate observations were the attributes that resulted in the largest percent reductions in deviance for multinomial regression fits to indicators of AIC selection of the process error configuration (Table 2). For R+S and R+M OMs, level of error in population observations provided deviance reduction (19% and 13%, respectively) much larger than any other OM and EM factors whereas error in covariate observations provided the largest reduction (8%) for R OMs. Lesser deviance reduction (2-3%) occurred for the true covariate effect size and whether the EM made the correct assumption about including a covariate effect for R OMs and error in covariate observations for R+M OMs. Including second and third order interactions, provided the largest reductions in residual deviance for R OMs (24%) and little reduction for R+S and R+M OMs (4% and 6%, respectively).

The attributes defining the primary branches of classification trees matched those that provided the largest reductions in deviance for all OM process error types (Figure 2). AIC performed poorly in selecting the correct process error for R+M OMs where lowest AIC occurred for the simpler R EMs. However, accuracy of AIC-based selection was high for R and R+S OMs. For R+S OMs, mis-classification occurred to R EMs with the lowest AIC when OMs had higher error in population observations. For R OMs, there was a small decrease in accuracy when the OMs included the largest covariate effect on M , but in those scenarios, AIC was more accurate for the process error assumption when the EMs also incorrectly assumed no covariate effect.

Covariate effect selection

The factors explaining the largest reduction in deviance for logistic regression models fitted to indicators of AIC selection of the correct covariate effect assumption depended on the magnitude of the true effect assumed in the OM (Table 3). When OMs had no covariate effect ($\beta_E = 0$) the OM process error type provided the largest reduction in deviance (4%). When OMs assumed a covariate effect ($\beta_E > 0$), level of error in population observations and magnitude of temporal variability in the true covariate provided the largest reductions in deviance (4% and 8-21%, respectively). The reduction in deviance provided by the magnitude of covariate temporal variability also increased with larger true covariate effect. Including second and third order interactions provided a modest reduction in deviance (5-7%).

The factors defining the primary branches of classification trees for indicators of AIC selecting the correct covariate effect assumption matched the factors providing the largest deviance reductions (Figure 3). Accuracy of AIC-based model selection for the covariate effect assumption was high overall for OMs with no covariate effect (88%) (low Type I error) and low when there was a covariate effect (23% and 35% for OMs with $\beta_E = 0.25$ and 0.5, respectively) (high Type II error), but higher accuracy occurred for certain combinations of OM attributes. When the true covariate effect was greatest ($\beta_E = 0.5$), AIC accuracy was 91% for EMs fit to OMs with high temporal variability in the covariate and low error in population and covariate observations regardless of whether the EM process error was correct. However, when the covariate effect was weaker ($\beta_E = 0.25$), high accuracy only occurred for a subset of those OMs with R or R+M process errors (76%), and the further conditioning on OMs with high autocorrelation of the covariate provided higher accuracy (86%). When there was no covariate effect, AIC accuracy was best for R OMs (95%), and for R+S and R+M OMs, accuracy was improved if the OMs also had lower error in population observations and the EM process error assumption was correct (85%).

Covariate effect inferences

Estimation bias

For regression models fit to errors in estimation of the covariate effect β_E , we found very little reduction in deviance for any of the OM and EM factors (Table 4). For the normal model in these regressions, deviance is the sum of squares and there were extremely large estimates of β_E (and errors) for many simulations which resulted in extremely large sums of squares and relative differences from the null model were therefore small ($<1\%$). Nevertheless, observation error of the covariate provided either the largest or second largest reductions in deviance of any of the single OM and EM attributes for OM process error configuration types. OM fishing history provided reductions of similar scale for R and R+S OMs. Other factors providing similar reductions were true covariate effect size for R OMs and level of error in population observations and EM process error assumption for R+S OMs. Including second and third order interactions also provided further reductions in residual deviance similar in scale to the individual factors.

Median errors for $\hat{\beta}_E$ across all simulations for each OM process error configuration were negative but close to 0 (-0.1 to -0.07) and primary branches were based on factors that matched those providing the largest reductions in deviance (Figure 4). Branches based on level of error in population or covariate observations provided better median estimation error (closer to 0) with lower uncertainty. Branches based on level of covariate temporal variation provided better median estimation error with higher temporal variation. For R OMs with the largest true covariate effect, estimation error was poor unless there was also high temporal variation and low observation error for the covariate. For R+S OMs, we also found lower estimation error when the EM process error assumption matched. We observed low median error across all simulations for R+M OMs with low error in covariate observations. The detailed results for all OM and EM configurations demonstrate that the median errors get worse with increased values for the true β_E for many scenarios without low

error in population and covariate observations and contrast in fishing pressure, indicating that the estimates remain close to zero when the true $\beta_E > 0$ (Figures S16 to S18). The detailed results also indicated little bias in covariate effect estimation regardless of the EM process error configuration when OMs had low population and covariate observation error and contrast in fishing pressure.

Standard error estimation bias

Factors providing the largest reductions in deviance for errors in estimation of the standard error of the covariate effect size ($\widehat{\text{SE}}(\hat{\beta}_E)$) were generally similar to those that were most important for estimation of β_E , but deviance reductions were one or two orders of magnitude larger (Table S2). Level of error in covariate observations and EM process error assumption was important for all OM process error configurations (6-13% and 3-4%, respectively). Level of error in population observations provided relatively large reductions in deviance for R+S and R+M OMs (3% and 8%, respectively). The OM fishing pressure history provided a lesser reduction in deviance for all OM process error types (2-4%). Like estimation of β_E , additional large reductions in deviance also occurred when second and third order interactions of OM and EM attributes were included in the regression models (11-31%).

Median errors in estimation of the standard error for $\hat{\beta}_E$ across all simulations for a given OM process error configuration were strongly negative (-0.8 to -0.6), but combinations of OM and EM attributes resulted in improved values closer to zero (Figure S4). For all OM process error types, branches with lower error in covariate observations provided better median errors in the standard error estimator (closer to 0).

Examining the detailed results for each OM and EM configuration shows little bias of standard error estimation in the same OM scenarios where there was little bias in estimation of β_E was close to zero (Figures S19 to S21). However, in these high information OMs, bias of standard error estimation was observed for several EMs that did not have the matching

R+S and R+M process error configuration.

Confidence interval bias

For logistic regressions of indicators of confidence intervals including the true value of β_E , factors that provided the largest reductions in deviance were true covariate effect size for R and R+M OMs (11% and 3%, respectively) and EM process error configuration for R+S OMs (7%) (Table 5). Covariate observation error also provided relatively large reduction in deviance for R OMs (8%). Lesser reductions of 1-2% occurred for level of error in population observations and covariate temporal variability for all OM process error types. Including second and third order interactions also provided relatively large further reductions in deviance (5-9%).

Over all simulations, rates of 95% confidence interval coverage indicated negative bias with rates ranging 85-88% for the different OM process error configurations (Figure 5). Factors defining the primary branches matched the factors that made the largest reductions in deviance for fitted logistic regression models. For R OMs, the primary branches based on error in covariate observations indicated higher rates of confidence interval coverage with lower error, but when that error was higher, higher rates were associated with OMs where no covariate affect was assumed ($\beta_E = 0$). For R OMs with some covariate effect and higher error in covariate observations, higher rates of coverage occurred with higher error in the population observations. For R+S OMs, higher rates of confidence interval coverage were observed for EMs that assumed R+S or R+M process errors.

The more detailed results for each OM and EM configuration show that good confidence interval coverage can be obtained for all of the investigated covariate effect sizes when there was low error in covariate and population observations, high covariate temporal variability and contrast in fishing pressure for R and R+S OMs. The EM process error configuration was not a factor for the R OMs, but R+S or R+M EM configurations were necessary for

R+S OMs (Figures S22 to S23). However, confidence interval coverage was negatively biased for all EM process error configurations fit to R+M OMs with these conditions even though little bias was observed in estimation of β_E or its standard error (Figure S24). Examining the estimates for each simulated data set when R+M EMs were fit to R+M OMs where we observed little estimation bias, there appears to be a positive correlation of the covariate and standard error estimates such that estimates less than the true value had negatively biased standard error estimates which would make confidence intervals too small (Figure S29).

Median natural mortality rate inferences

Estimation bias

Across all OM process error types, regression models fit to errors for median M parameter estimation ($\hat{\beta}_M$) showed largest reductions in deviance from the type of OM fishing pressure (4-17%), EM process error assumption (2-12%), and the EM covariate effect assumption (3-7%, Table 6). The level of observation error also provided a similar reduction in deviance for R OMs (3%). Relatively large reductions in deviance also occurred with second and third order interactions (7-16%).

Like $\hat{\beta}_E$, median errors for $\hat{\beta}_M$ were negative but close to 0 (-0.1 to -0.07) across all simulations for each OM process error configuration (Figure 6). The primary branches for all OM process error types were defined by the type of OM fishing pressure, with median errors closer to zero when there was a change in fishing pressure for R+S and R+M OMs. Branches based on the level of error in population observations showed median errors closer to zero with more precise observations. For R+S and R+M OMs, branches that included the matching EM process error assumption provided better median errors.

Detailed results reveal that bias of $\hat{\beta}_M$ was negligible for all EM process error assumptions fitted to R and R+M OMs when there was contrast in fishing pressure and low error in population observations, but the matching EM process error assumption was also important

for EMs fit to R+S OM (Figures S30 to S32). For those OM, any attributes related to covariate process error and effects on M had little effect on bias.

Standard error estimation bias

The EM process error assumption provided the largest reduction in deviance for regression models fitted to errors in estimation of the standard errors of $\hat{\beta}_M$ from R (3%) and R+M (7%) OM simulations (Table S3). The type of OM fishing pressure provided the largest reduction (13%) for R+S OM and a lesser reduction in deviance for R+M OM (4%). The EM covariate effect assumption also provided similar reductions in deviance for R+S (9%) and R+M (4%) OM.

The factors defining the primary branches of regression trees matched those providing the largest reductions in deviance for errors in $\widehat{SE}(\hat{\beta}_M)$, but median errors indicated strong negative bias across all OM process error types (Figure S5). Branches with lower error in population observations provided better median errors (closer to 0). For R+S OM, branches where the EM process error assumption was correct provided better median errors.

Detailed results for each OM and EM configuration indicate little bias in certain scenarios where OM had temporal contrast in fishing pressure and low error in population observations (Figures S33 to S35). For R and R+M OM with those conditions, all EM process error assumptions provided median errors close to zero except for OM with the true covariate effect strongest and the true covariate time series was autocorrelated and had high temporal variation. For R+S OM with those conditions, only EMs with the correct process error assumption exhibited low (absolute) median error.

Confidence interval bias

For logistic regressions of indicators of confidence intervals including β_M , factors that provided the largest reductions in deviance were the OM fishing history and level of error in

population observations for all OM process error types (0.3-6%) (Table 7). Including second and third order interactions provided the largest relative increase in deviance reduction for R+S (8-11%) and R+M OMs (5-8%) and lesser increases for R OMs (3-5%).

The factors defining the primary branches of classification trees for indicators of confidence interval inclusion of β_M matched those providing the largest reductions in deviance for each of the OM process error types (Figure 7). Across all simulations, rates of 95% confidence interval coverage indicated negative bias with rates ranging 83-87% for the different OM process error types. Branches based on contrast in OM fishing history and lower error in population observations indicated less bias in confidence interval coverage except R+S OMs where the R EM configuration was incorrectly assumed.

The more detailed results for each OM and EM configuration show that good confidence interval coverage can be obtained for many R and R+S OM scenarios with low error in population observations and contrast in fishing pressure, but coverage was generally unreliable for all R+M OM scenarios (Figures S22 to S24).

Terminal year natural morality rate

Estimation bias

Regressions of errors in estimation of terminal year M show largest reductions in deviance from whether the EM treats β_M as known (Table 8). For R and R+S OMs, annual M was constant, and therefore, terminal M was known when the true β_M was assumed known and there will be no error in any of those EMs. Beyond the β_M assumption, the OM fishing history, level of error in population observations, and EM assumptions for covariate effect and process error all provided notable deviance reductions.

Regression trees for errors in estimation of terminal year M have primary branches based on the whether β_M was assumed known or estimated for all OM process error types (Figure

8). For R and R+S OM, the branches where β_M was assumed known have no error as expected because yearly M was equal to e^{β_M} , but there was also very little error in terminal year M for the same branch in R+M OM. When β_M was estimated, median errors were near zero for many EMs in R OM, but median error was problematic for this subset of EMs in R+S OM. On the other hand, detailed results for each OM and EM attribute show that there was little evidence of bias for R+S OM when error in population observations was low and there was contrast in fishing pressure and the EM process error configuration was correct (Figure S45). In R+M OM, median errors indicated little bias overall with temporal contrast in fishing pressure, although detailed results demonstrated best reliability when there was also lower error in population observations (Figure S46).

Estimation accuracy

Like bias of terminal year M , whether the EMs treated β_M as known or estimated provided the largest reduction in deviance (22-45%) for accuracy of estimates as measured by RMSE for all OM process error types (Table S4). Including second and third order interactions also provided large further reductions in deviance (21-38%). Also like bias, regression trees fit to log-RMSE of terminal M showed better accuracy when EMs assumed β_M was known rather than estimated (Figure S6). Better accuracy was also generally associated with lower error in population observations and temporal contrast in fishing pressure. For R+S OM, R+S EMs provided better accuracy than incorrect process error assumptions.

Using correlation to measure accuracy of terminal year M estimation provides a different perspective. Treatment of β_M provided relatively large reductions in deviance for all OM process error types (3-12%), but level of variability in the covariate was equally or more important (3-15%) as was whether the covariate effect was included in the EM (12%) for R and R+S OM (Table S5). Including second and third order interactions also provided relatively large further reductions in deviance (15 to 24%). Regression trees demonstrated

better accuracy with higher covariate variability, lower error in population and covariate observations, and when EMs assumed β_M was known (Figure S7).

Terminal year spawning stock biomass

Estimation bias

Fits of regression models to log-scale errors of terminal SSB resulted in largest reductions in deviance for OM fishing history (2-3%), error in population observations (1% for R and R+M OMs), and EM β_M assumption (2%; Table 9). The type of EM process error assumed also provided a deviance reduction similar in scale for R+S OMs (1%). Including second and third order interactions of OM and EM attributes provided further deviance reductions of 5-10%.

The primary branches of regression trees fitted to log-scale errors in terminal SSB were based on type of OM fishing history for all OM process error types, but differences in median errors between branches were small (Figure 9). For R+S and R+M OMs, branches that assumed β_M was known indicated less bias than those where it was estimated. For R+S OMs with constant fishing pressure and β_M estimated, less bias was indicated when the EM process error assumption was correct.

Estimation accuracy

Largest reductions in deviance for accuracy of terminal year SSB as measured by log-RMSE were provided by whether β_M was known or estimated (20-21%) and whether there was temporal contrast in fishing pressure (20-33%) across all OM process error types (Table S6). Lesser reductions were also provided by the EM process error assumption for R and R+M OMs. Inclusion of second and third order interactions of OM and EM attributes provided further reductions in deviance of 26-40%.

Primary branches of regression trees fit to log-RMSE of terminal year SSB were based on the same factors that provided the largest reduction in deviance (Figure S8). All branches with temporal change in fishing pressure provided better accuracy than branches with constant fishing pressure. Similarly, better accuracy occurred for branches with β_M assumed known rather than estimated, and lower error in population observations.

Using correlation to measure accuracy of terminal year SSB estimation, temporal contrast in fishing pressure and EM treatment of β_M provided relatively important reductions in deviance like RMSE, but level of error in population observations was important rather than EM process error type (Table S7). Including second and third order interactions also provided relatively large further reductions in deviance (6 to 20%). Regression trees demonstrated better accuracy with contrast in fishing pressure, lower error in population observations, and when EMs assumed β_M was known (Figure S9).

Discussion

Our simulation study demonstrated that reliable inferences about effects on natural mortality require low observation error, contrast in fishing pressure, and large temporal variability in the environmental covariate. Under these conditions, reliable AIC-based selection and estimation of environmental effects on M can be possible even when the process error was mis-specified (e.g., R and R+S EMs fit to R+M OM). Under those same conditions, reliable estimation of standard errors and confidence interval coverage was also possible for R and R+S OMs especially when the EM process error type was correct. However, there was poor confidence interval coverage for R+M OMs even though there was little bias in estimation of the effect or standard errors, possibly related to correlation of the estimated effects and standard errors. Cadigan et al. (2024) found confidence interval coverage to be biased for SSB and F estimation in a state-space model in some scenarios but they attributed the poor coverage to bias in Hessian-based standard error estimation and their simulations held

any process error random effects constant. Consideration of other methods of calculating confidence intervals may be warranted (e.g., Boyko and O'Meara, 2024). Previous research has shown that estimation of a constant M parameter requires contrast in time series and informative data (Lee et al., 2011), so it is unsurprising that estimation of covariate effects on M also requires relatively good information via more precise observations and higher contrast in the covariate time series.

We found AIC unreliable for determining the source of process error for EMs fit to R+M OMs where marginal temporal variability was specified as $\sigma_M = 0.3$. Miller et al. (In reviewa) investigated R+M OMs with two levels of M process-error variability ($\sigma_M \in \{0.1, 0.5\}$) and only found AIC able to accurately distinguish R+M process errors with the higher level of process-error variability. If AIC accuracy increases with σ_M , our results together would suggest the minimum level of variability for reliable detection may be with σ_M somewhere between 0.3 and 0.5. In our results and those by Miller et al. (In reviewa), inaccurate selection of AIC typically chose R EMs which would indicate the fitted R+M EMs would estimate no variability in the M process errors. Future studies like ours where R+M OMs are simulated with greater variability in M process errors would better inform reliability of covariate effect inferences under such scenarios.

Deriso et al. (2008) attempted to estimate process errors as well as covariate effects with M for Pacific herring but similarly found no variability in M , suggesting there was too much uncertainty in the available observations relative to the true temporal variability in M . Given that we found covariate effect inferences using R EMs were reliable in R+M OMs with apparently little variability in M process errors, the findings of Deriso et al. (2008) on covariate effects for Pacific herring would presumably also be robust to true low variability in M . However, they did not account for uncertainty in covariate observations, some of which would probably have substantial uncertainty (e.g., competition and predation covariates). We found higher covariate observation uncertainty resulted in true covariate effects to be less detectable using AIC but we did not investigate the implications for incorrectly assuming

no covariate uncertainty for covariate inferences.

It was important to consider RMSE and correlation of estimates with the true values for reliable estimation of terminal year M because summaries of relative errors could suggest unbiasedness that is not relevant due to the distribution of true values being centered at an assumed constant value or near an estimated constant value in the EM (e.g., R and R+S EMs that have a temporally constant M fit to OM with temporally varying M). Despite the inability of AIC to distinguish M process errors, reliable estimation of annual M was possible in some scenarios regardless of the EM process error assumption. To achieve little bias and high correlation of terminal M estimates required larger variability in the covariate (when OM and EMs included the effect on M) along with lower population and covariate observation error. It was also more difficult when EMs estimated β_M rather than treating it as known. However, there was little correlation of terminal year M estimates and true values for R+M OM without covariate effects for any combination of OM and EM attributes (Figure S52). Therefore, our results suggest estimating annual M is easier when the temporal variation is due to effects of highly variable covariates than unexplained variation in M . Like the results for AIC-based selection, this may be a function of the level of variability in M we assumed for R+M OM.

Accurate estimation of terminal year SSB, was more robust than terminal year M . When OM had contrast in fishing pressure and low error in population observations, there was little bias and high correlation of terminal year SSB estimates regardless of whether OM and EMs included covariate effects. However, for R+S OM, it was important for the EM process error configuration to be correct. Fortunately, our results and those by Miller et al. (In review), suggest AIC-based model selection is accurate for this type of process error. However, the reliability of the SSB estimation does break down in the less ideal scenarios when there is higher error in population observations, and lack of contrast in fishing pressure (e.g., Figures S53 to S55).

679 The R+S and R+M EMs both include process error for the apparent survival of cohorts
 680 and would be expected to perform similarly, and they did in our simulations when the OM
 681 and EM matched. However, we found that the accuracy for model output like SSB and
 682 F that are important for management was generally worse using R+M EMs for R+S OMs
 683 than using R+S EMs for R+M OMs in the high information OMs with contrast in fishing
 684 pressure and low error in population observations. Additionally, there are implications for
 685 biological reference points for R+M EMs (e.g., Legault and Palmer, 2016) that are not present
 686 with R+S EMs. We therefore recommend following the suggestion from Li et al. (2024) to
 687 prefer R+S EMs over R+M EMs unless strong biological evidence is present to support a
 688 particular R+M EM. Such support could be found through both biological understanding
 689 (e.g., Trijoulet et al., 2020) as well as statistical properties such as a large delta AIC for
 690 R+M compared to R+S associated with greater temporal variability in M (Miller et al., In
 691 reviewa).

692 The pattern of improved inferences using state-space models in the presence of higher con-
 693 trast in fishing pressure, lower observation error and greater process error variability that
 694 emerges from our work here and by Miller et al. (In reviewb) is consistent with expectations
 695 from statistical theory. State-space models are more reliable when observation error is lower
 696 than process error (Auger-Méthé et al., 2016), and, more generally, maximum likelihood es-
 697 timation is less biased and more accurate as the information in the data increases (Neyman
 698 and Scott, 1948; Kiefer and Wolfowitz, 1956). However, the greater complexity of state-
 699 space assessment models over the more well-studied linear and Gaussian state-space models
 700 makes determining sufficient levels of precision in observations difficult. Statistical informa-
 701 tion available to the state-space assessment model could be increased with longer time series
 702 of observations, more time series (e.g., multiple indices of abundance and corresponding age
 703 composition data sets), or more precise observations of a given time series of observations
 704 (e.g., greater index observation precision or more sampling for age composition). Therefore,
 705 it will be important to conduct self-test simulations (where the OM and EM are the same)

on a case-by-case basis to ensure the reliability of models used to manage commercially important fish stocks.

The ability to accurately infer covariate effects on M in some situations indicates that such investigations may be fruitful. The ability to make inferences could improve further when WHAM is extended to incorporate tagging data (Miller et al., 2025). Tagging data can greatly inform M estimation (Pollock et al., 1991; Hampton, 2000) and this impact on M estimation should also apply to estimation of covariate effects or unexplained temporal variation in M . Given our findings and planned future WHAM development, we expect investigations of, and accounting for, covariate effects on M to become more common within the fisheries stock assessment process. At the same time, it will be equally important to conduct research that will improve our understanding of how best to measure the depletion of stocks and determine catch advice for these stocks with covariate effects on M .

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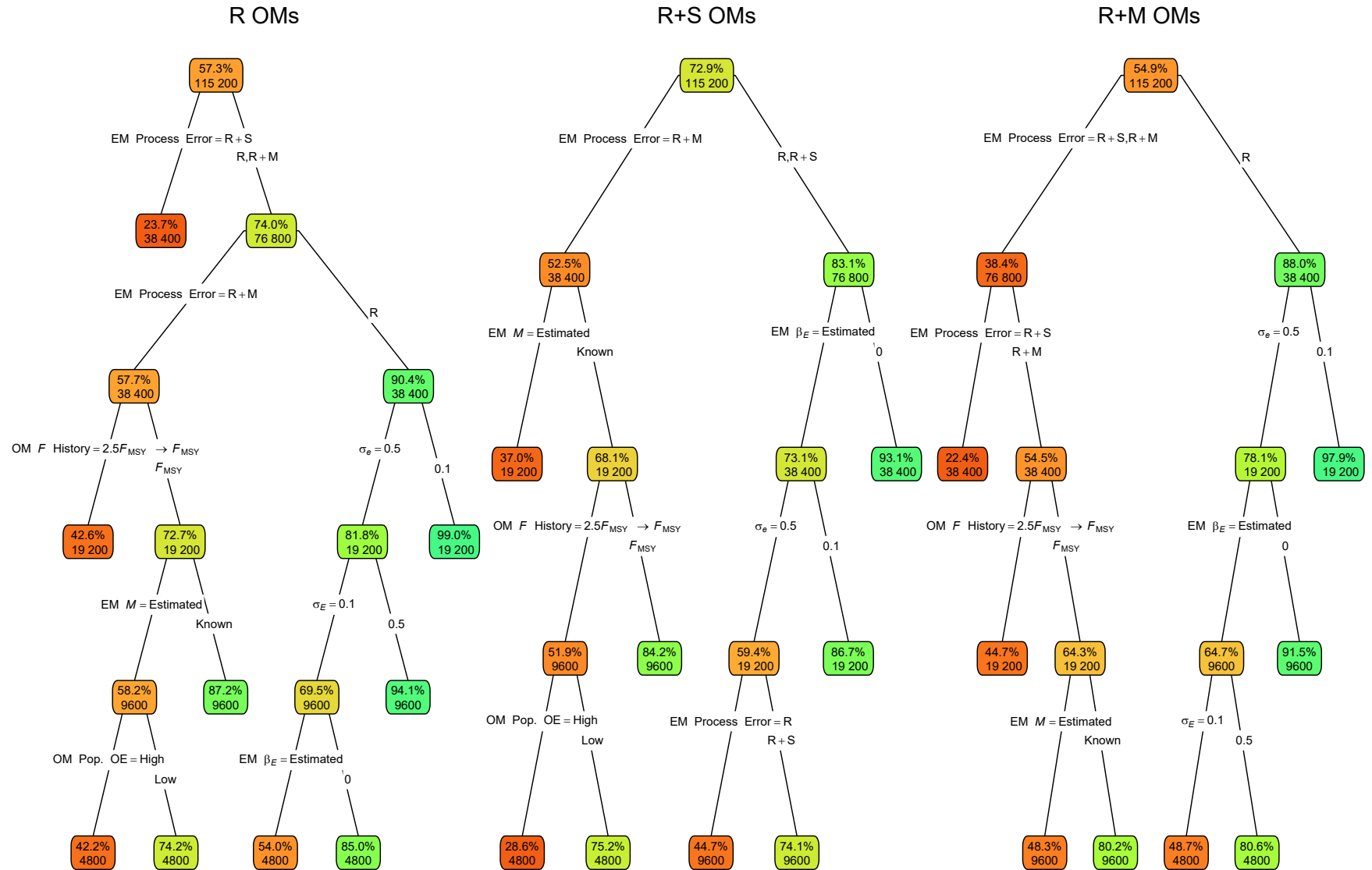


Fig. 1. Classification trees indicating primary factors determining convergence as defined by providing Hessian-based standard errors for operating models (OMs) with process error on recruitment only (R), recruitment and apparent survival (R+S), or recruitment and natural mortality (R+M). Nodes denote percent convergence (top) and number of fits (bottom) for the corresponding subset. Lower or higher convergence rates are indicated by more red or green polygons, respectively. See Table S1 for description of OM and EM factors defining nodes and branches.

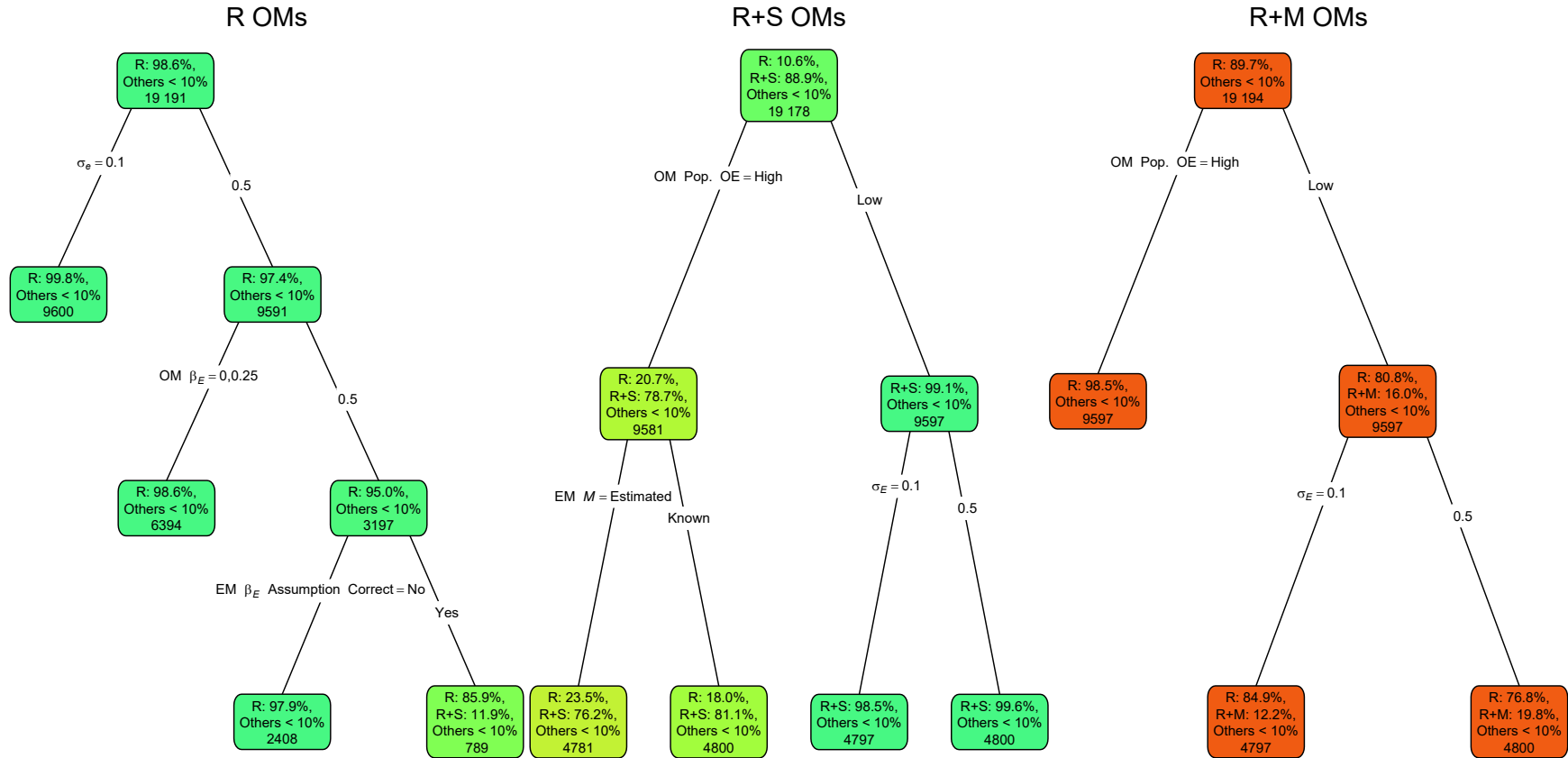


Fig. 2. Classification trees indicating primary factors determining which process error assumption in estimating models (EMs) provides the lowest AIC for operating models (OMs) with process error on recruitment only (R), recruitment and apparent survival (R+S), or recruitment and natural mortality (R+M). Each node shows the percentage of EM fits with a given process error assumption having the lowest AIC and the number of observations for the corresponding subset of fits. Lower or higher accuracy of the process error assumption are indicated by more red or green polygons, respectively. See Table S1 for description of OM and EM factors defining nodes and branches.

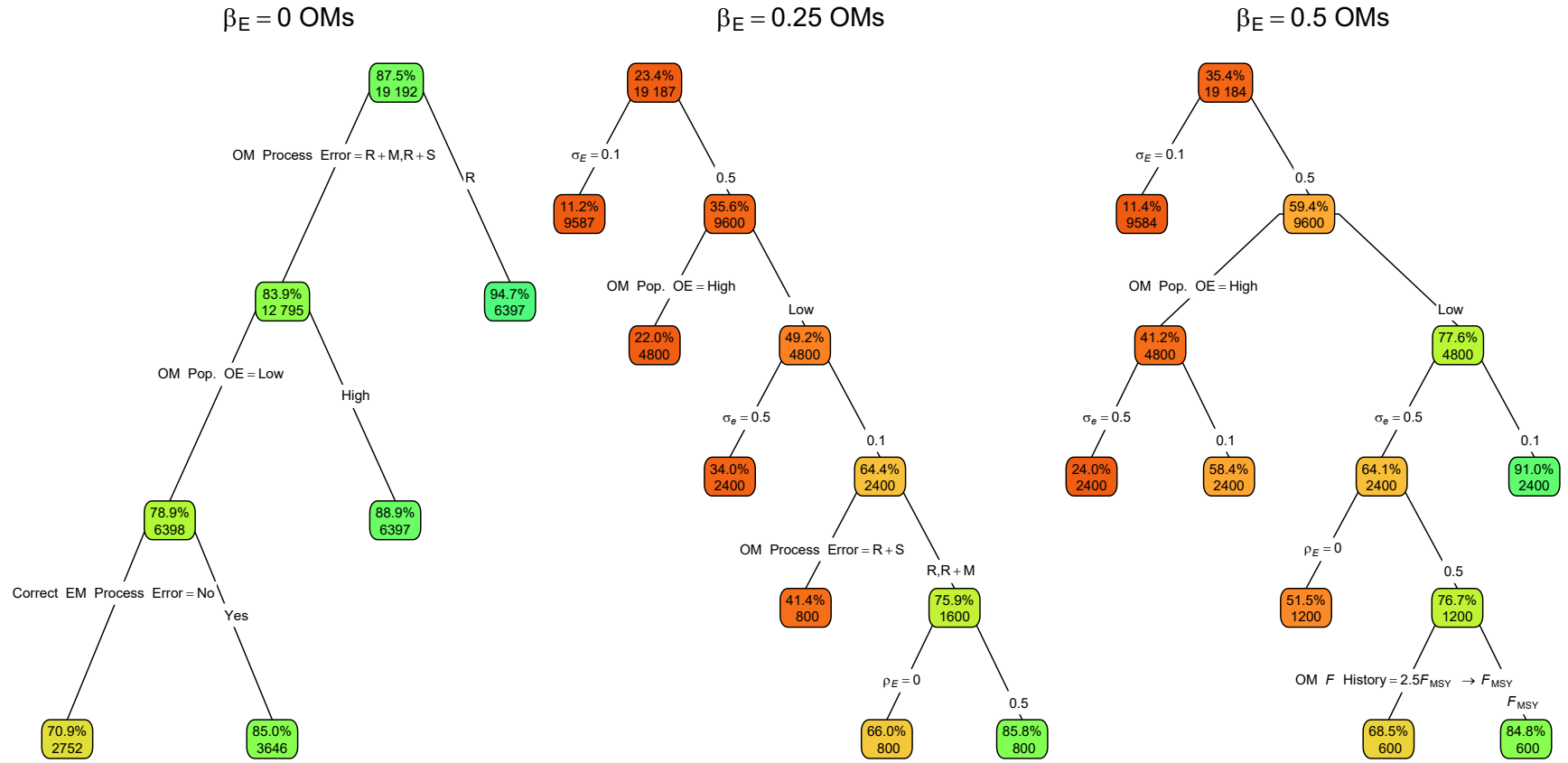


Fig. 3. Classification trees indicating primary factors determining whether the correct EM assumption for covariate effect on M (no effect with OM $\beta_E = 0$ or estimated effect when OM $\beta_E > 0$) provides the lowest AIC for OMs assuming values for β_E of 0, 0.25, and 0.5. Nodes denote the percentage of estimating models (EMs) with correct assumption and lowest AIC (top), and number of observations (bottom) for the corresponding subset. Lower or higher accuracy of the process error assumption are indicated by more red or green polygons, respectively. See Table S1 for description of OM and EM factors defining nodes and branches.

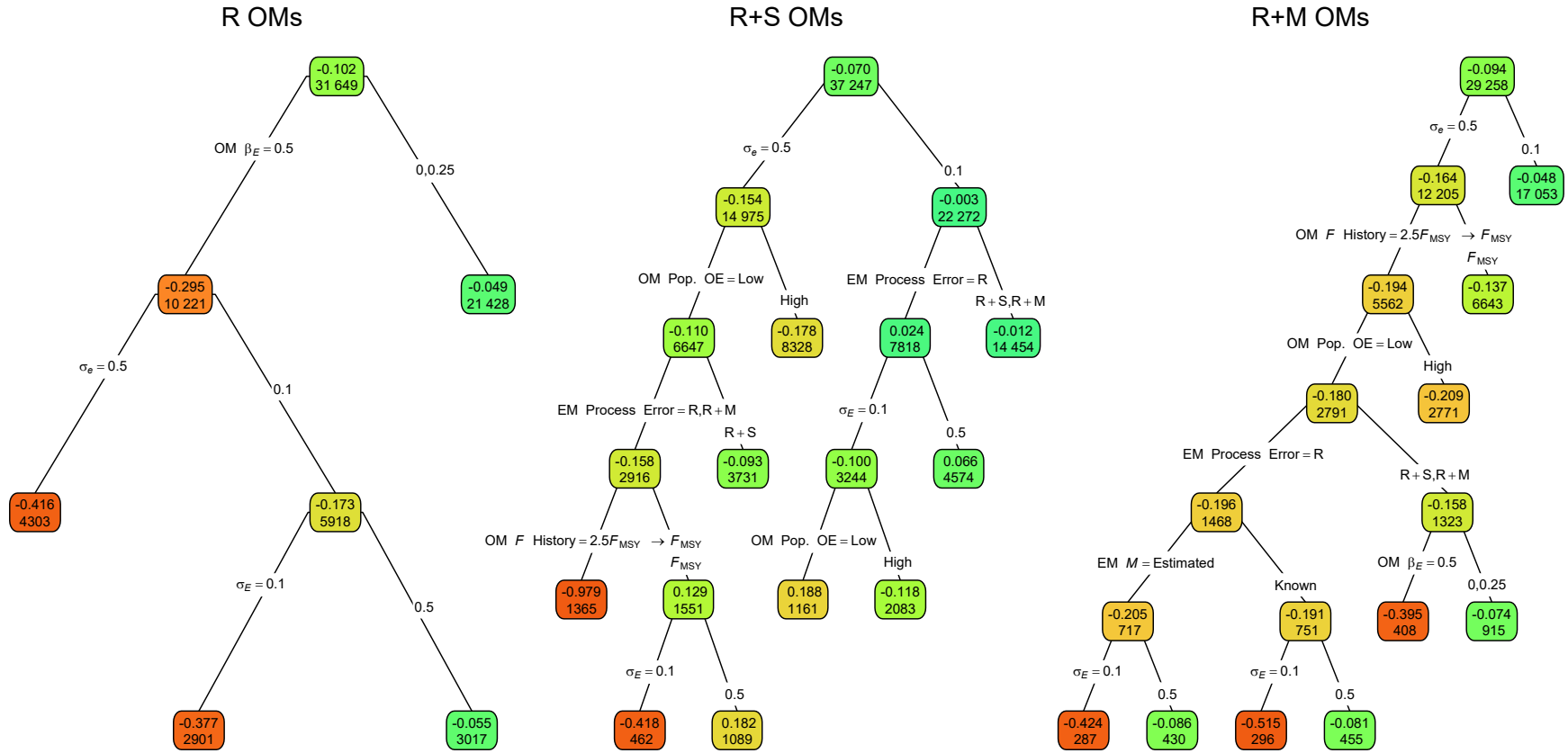


Fig. 4. Regression trees indicating primary factors determining reductions in sums of squares of errors in estimation of the covariate effect on M for operating models (OMs) with process error on recruitment only (R), recruitment and apparent survival (R+S), or recruitment and natural mortality (R+M). Each node shows the median error (top) and number of observations (bottom) for the corresponding subset. Lower or higher median absolute errors of the process error assumption are indicated by more green or red polygons, respectively. See Table S1 for description of OM and EM factors defining nodes and branches.

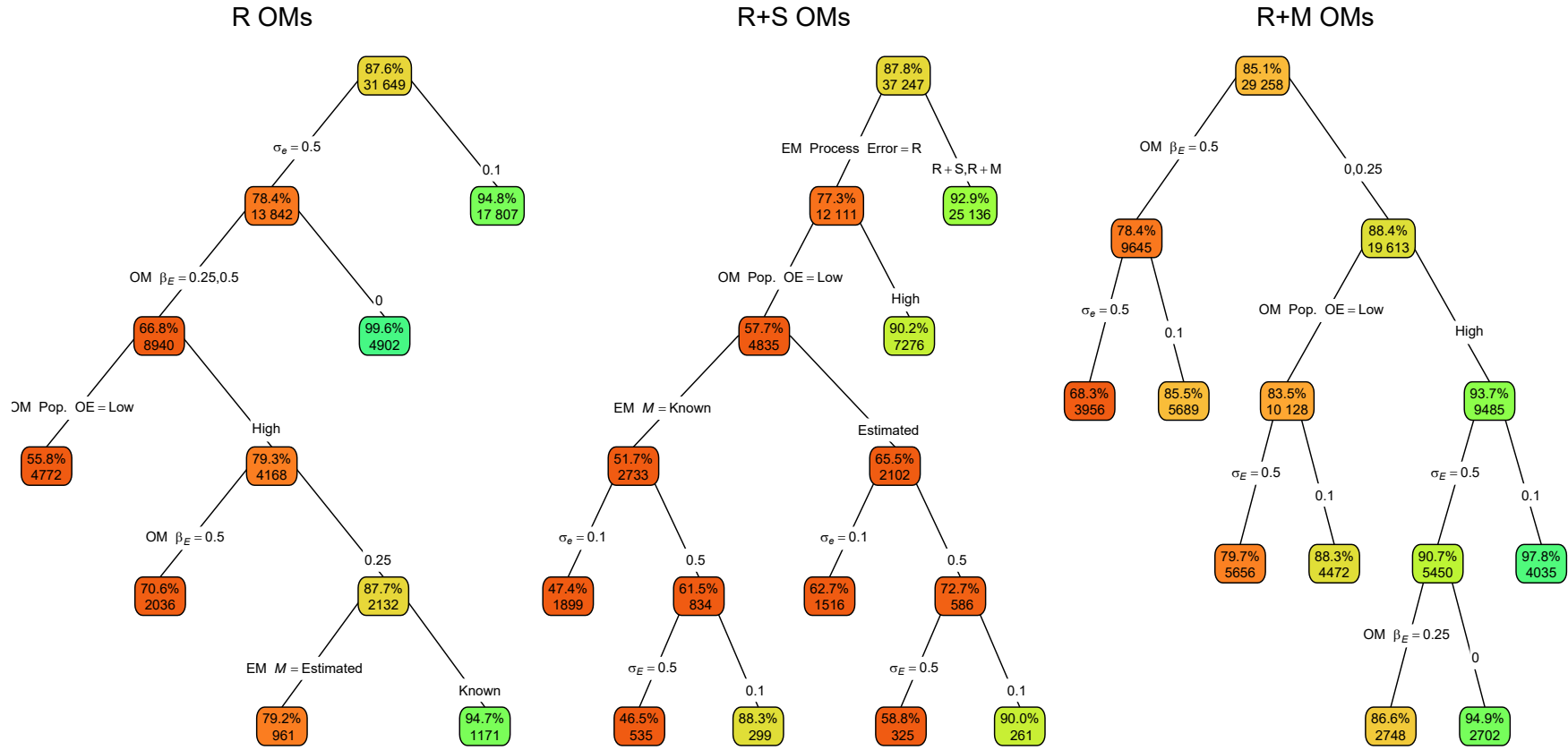


Fig. 5. Classification trees indicating primary factors determining whether confidence intervals for estimated covariate effects on M in estimating models (EMs) fitted to operating models (OMs) with process error on recruitment only (R), recruitment and apparent survival (R+S), or recruitment and natural mortality (R+M) included the true value. Each node shows the median error (top) and number of observations (bottom) for the corresponding subset. Lower or higher median absolute errors of the process error assumption are indicated by more green or red polygons, respectively. See Table S1 for description of OM and EM factors defining nodes and branches.

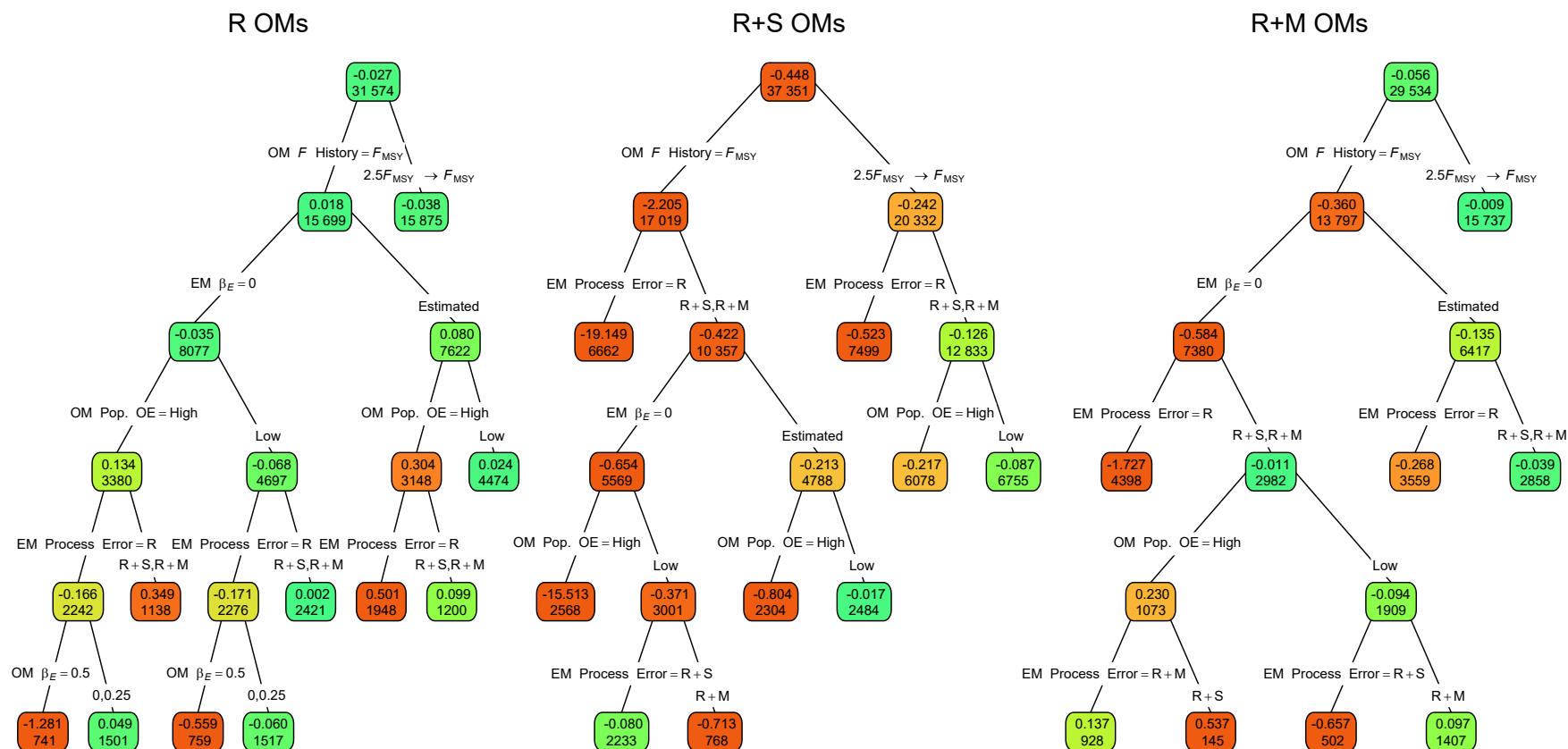


Fig. 6. Regression trees indicating primary factors determining reductions in sums of squares of errors in estimation of the median M parameter (β_M) in estimating models (EMs) fitted to operating models (OMs) with process error on recruitment only (R), recruitment and apparent survival (R+S), or recruitment and natural mortality (R+M). Each node shows the median error (top) and number of observations (bottom) for the corresponding subset. Lower or higher median absolute errors of the process error assumption are indicated by more green or red polygons, respectively. See Table S1 for description of OM and EM factors defining nodes and branches.



Fig. 7. Classification trees indicating primary factors determining whether confidence intervals for estimated median M parameter (β_M) in estimating models (EMs) fitted to operating models (OMs) with process error on recruitment only (R), recruitment and apparent survival (R+S), or recruitment and natural mortality (R+M) included the true value. Each node shows the median error (top) and number of observations (bottom) for the corresponding subset. Lower or higher median absolute errors of the process error assumption are indicated by more green or red polygons, respectively. See Table S1 for description of OM and EM factors defining nodes and branches.

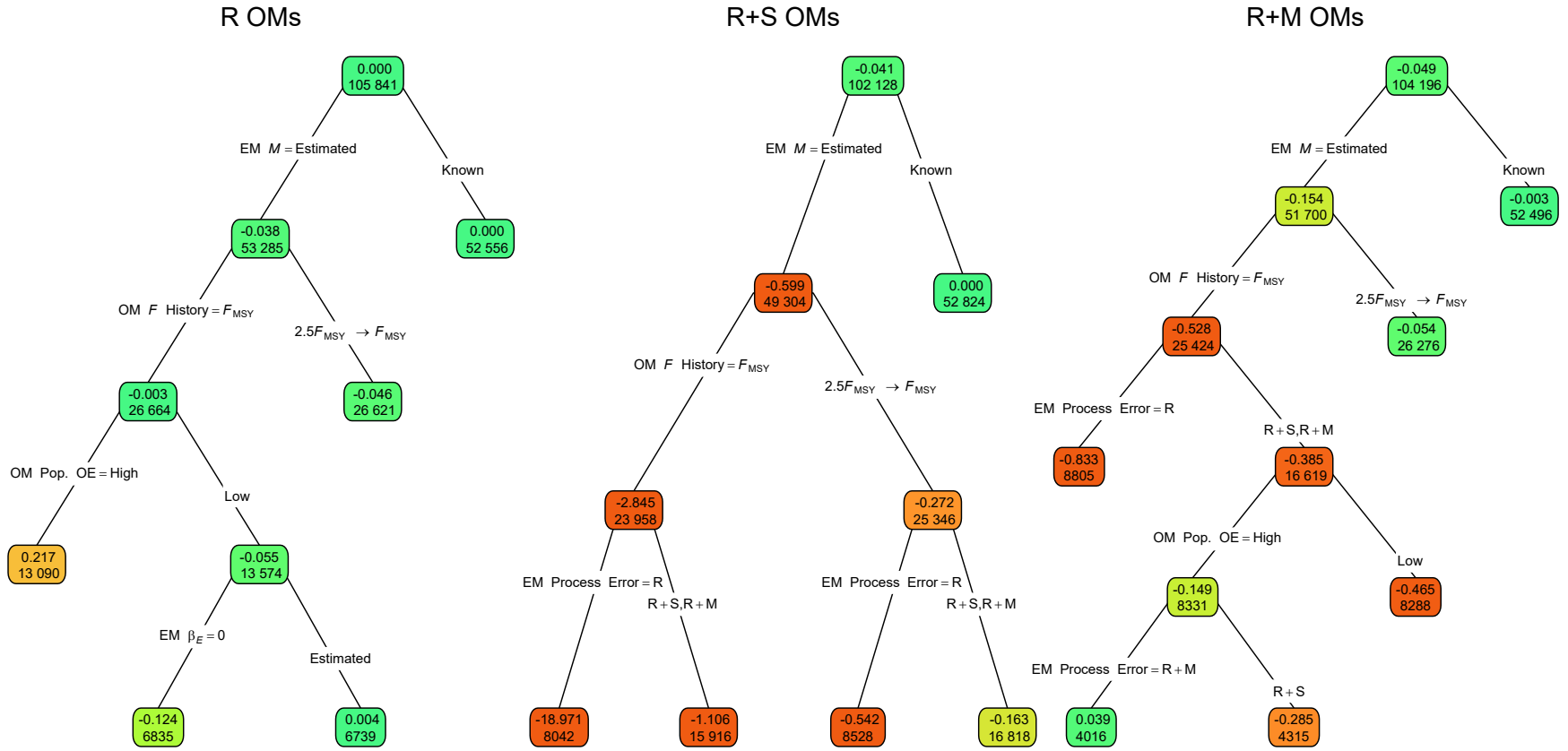


Fig. 8. Regression trees indicating primary factors determining reductions in sums of squares of errors in estimation measured by Eq. 2 for the terminal year M in estimating models (EMs) fitted to operating models (OMs) with process error on recruitment only (R), recruitment and apparent survival (R+S), or recruitment and natural mortality (R+M). Each node shows the median error (top) and number of observations (bottom) for the corresponding subset. Lower or higher median absolute errors of the process error assumption are indicated by more green or red polygons, respectively. See Table S1 for description of OM and EM factors defining nodes and branches.

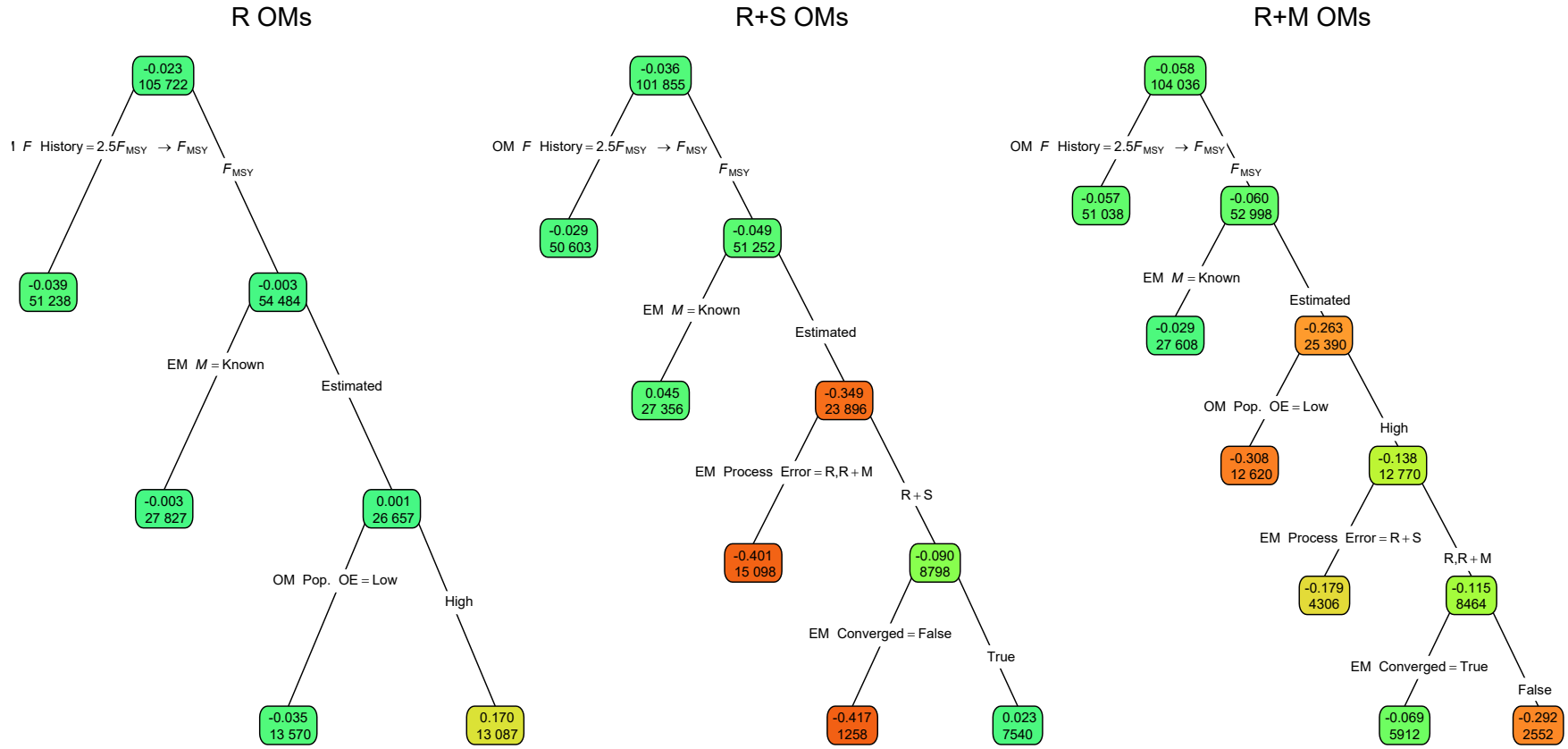


Fig. 9. Regression trees indicating primary factors determining reductions in sums of squares of errors in estimation measured by Eq. 2 for the terminal year SSB in estimating models (EMs) fitted to operating models (OMs) with process error on recruitment only (R), recruitment and apparent survival (R+S), or recruitment and natural mortality (R+M). Each node shows the median error (top) and number of observations (bottom) for the corresponding subset. Lower or higher median absolute errors of the process error assumption are indicated by more green or red polygons, respectively. See Table S1 for description of OM and EM factors defining nodes and branches.

Table 1. Percent reduction in deviance for logistic regression models fit to indicators of convergence (providing Hessian-based standard errors). Table rows give each operating model (OM) and estimating model (EM) factor included individually, combined, and with second and third order interactions. Table columns are operating models (OMs) with process error on recruitment only (R), recruitment and apparent survival (R+S), or recruitment and natural mortality (R+M).

Factor	R	R+S	R+M
OM F history	0.86	<0.01	0.24
OM Obs. Error	0.56	0.03	0.26
OM σ_e	0.66	2.99	0.93
OM σ_E	0.53	2.22	0.62
OM ρ_E	<0.01	0.02	<0.01
OM β_E	0.02	<0.01	<0.01
EM Process Error	24.53	9.33	23.06
EM β_E assumption	0.16	2.96	0.51
EM M Assumption	0.18	2.83	0.40
All factors	28.92	22.67	27.34
+ All Two Way	36.15	33.54	34.03
+ All Three Way	37.95	36.58	35.57

Table 2. Percent reduction in deviance for multinomial logistic regression models fit to indicators of process error assumption in the estimating models (EMs) with lowest AIC. Table rows give each operating model (OM) and estimating model (EM) factor included individually, combined, and with second and third order interactions. Table columns are operating models (OMs) with process error on recruitment only (R), recruitment and apparent survival (R+S), or recruitment and natural mortality (R+M).

Factor	R	R+S	R+M
OM F history	0.23	0.06	0.30
OM Obs. Error	0.54	18.58	13.43
OM σ_e	8.41	0.05	2.23
OM σ_E	0.17	0.08	0.59
OM ρ_E	1.29	0.03	0.06
OM β_E	3.42	0.04	0.38
EM M Assumption	0.35	0.34	0.48
EM β_E Assumption Correct	2.35	0.22	0.78
All factors	21.97	19.29	19.07
+ All Two Way	38.25	21.13	24.73
+ All Three Way	46.26	22.85	26.97

Table 3. Percent reduction in deviance for logistic regression models fit to indicators of correct estimating model (EM) covariate effect assumption (no effect with OM $\beta_E = 0$ or estimated effect when OM $\beta_E > 0$) with lowest AIC. Table rows give each operating model (OM) and estimating model (EM) factor included individually, combined, and with second and third order interactions. Table columns are operating models (OMs) with process error on recruitment only (R), recruitment and apparent survival (R+S), or recruitment and natural mortality (R+M).

Factor	$\beta_E = 0$	$\beta_E = 0.25$	$\beta_E = 0.5$
OM F history	<0.01	0.09	0.18
OM Obs. Error	1.19	4.06	4.64
OM Process Error	4.11	0.71	0.25
OM σ_e	0.66	2.00	1.97
OM σ_E	0.35	7.97	20.66
OM ρ_E	0.21	1.23	1.48
EM M Assumption	0.23	0.15	0.15
EM Process Error Assumption Correct	1.95	0.39	0.06
All factors	6.95	17.65	33.44
+ All Two Way	10.58	23.21	38.36
+ All Three Way	11.83	24.95	39.79

Table 4. Percent reduction in deviance for linear regression models fit to errors in estimation of the covariate effect on natural mortality rate ($\hat{\beta}_E$). Table rows give each operating model (OM) and estimating model (EM) factor included individually, combined, and with second and third order interactions. Table columns are operating models (OMs) with process error on recruitment only (R), recruitment and apparent survival (R+S), or recruitment and natural mortality (R+M).

Factor	R	R+S	R+M
OM F history	0.03	0.06	0.02
OM Obs. Error	<0.01	0.06	0.02
OM σ_e	0.04	0.08	0.06
OM σ_E	<0.01	0.02	0.01
OM ρ_E	<0.01	0.01	<0.01
OM β_E	0.05	<0.01	<0.01
EM Process Error	0.01	0.06	0.01
EM M assumption	0.02	0.02	<0.01
All factors	0.18	0.37	0.14
+ All Two Way	0.50	1.11	0.35
+ All Three Way	1.38	1.88	0.66

Table 5. Percent reduction in deviance for logistic regression models fit to indicators of whether confidence intervals for covariate effect estimates includes the true value. Table rows give each operating model (OM) and estimating model (EM) factor included individually, combined, and with second and third order interactions. Table columns are operating models (OMs) with process error on recruitment only (R), recruitment and apparent survival (R+S), or recruitment and natural mortality (R+M).

Factor	R	R+S	R+M
OM F history	0.24	0.05	0.01
OM Obs. Error	1.36	1.91	1.78
OM σ_e	8.26	0.24	0.92
OM σ_E	0.92	1.70	1.56
OM ρ_E	0.03	0.05	0.06
OM β_E	11.10	0.68	2.72
EM Process Error	0.01	6.51	0.27
EM M assumption	0.25	0.29	0.06
All factors	23.61	12.16	7.78
+ All Two Way	30.17	18.08	12.63
+ All Three Way	32.58	20.62	14.87

Table 6. Percent reduction in deviance for linear regression models fit to errors in estimation of the median natural mortality rate parameter ($\hat{\beta}_M$). Table rows give each operating model (OM) and estimating model (EM) factor included individually, combined, and with second and third order interactions. Table columns are operating models (OMs) with process error on recruitment only (R), recruitment and apparent survival (R+S), or recruitment and natural mortality (R+M).

Factor	R	R+S	R+M
OM F history	4.03	16.52	6.51
OM Obs. Error	2.74	0.54	0.64
OM σ_e	0.01	<0.01	0.01
OM σ_E	0.18	0.02	0.15
OM ρ_E	0.07	0.05	<0.01
OM β_E	0.37	0.04	0.10
EM Process Error	2.31	11.99	2.65
EM β_E assumption	2.83	7.20	3.25
All factors	12.14	33.71	12.81
+ All Two Way	21.74	46.46	19.84
+ All Three Way	26.38	49.41	22.24

Table 7. Percent reduction in deviance for logistic regression models fit to indicators of whether confidence intervals for estimates of the median natural mortality rate parameter ($\hat{\beta}_M$) includes the true value. Table rows give each operating model (OM) and estimating model (EM) factor included individually, combined, and with second and third order interactions. Table columns are operating models (OMs) with process error on recruitment only (R), recruitment and apparent survival (R+S), or recruitment and natural mortality (R+M).

Factor	R	R+S	R+M
OM F history	6.08	1.46	0.14
OM Obs. Error	1.48	0.41	0.29
OM σ_e	0.01	0.06	0.01
OM σ_E	0.13	0.02	0.04
OM ρ_E	<0.01	<0.01	0.02
OM β_E	0.08	0.11	0.09
EM Process Error	0.53	0.08	0.04
EM β_E assumption	<0.01	0.19	0.01
All factors	8.46	2.32	0.62
+ All Two Way	11.97	10.57	5.99
+ All Three Way	13.35	13.51	8.44

Table 8. Percent reduction in deviance for linear regression models fit to errors in estimation measured by Eq. 2 for the terminal year natural mortality rate (M). Table rows give each operating model (OM) and estimating model (EM) factor included individually, combined, and with second and third order interactions. Table columns are operating models (OMs) with process error on recruitment only (R), recruitment and apparent survival (R+S), or recruitment and natural mortality (R+M).

Factor	R	R+S	R+M
Convergence	<0.01	0.18	0.01
OM F history	0.66	2.69	1.00
OM Obs. Error	0.29	0.43	0.16
OM σ_e	<0.01	<0.01	<0.01
OM σ_E	0.02	<0.01	<0.01
OM ρ_E	<0.01	0.01	<0.01
OM β_E	0.03	0.01	0.01
EM Process Error	0.22	1.42	0.43
EM β_E assumption	0.35	1.07	0.39
EM M assumption	0.84	5.10	1.22
All factors	2.56	10.83	3.37
+ All Two Way	5.41	18.75	6.38
+ All Three Way	7.93	22.49	8.76

Table 9. Percent reduction in deviance for linear regression models fit to errors in estimation measured by Eq. 2 for the terminal year spawning stock biomass (SSB). Table rows give each operating model (OM) and estimating model (EM) factor included individually, combined, and with second and third order interactions. Table columns are operating models (OMs) with process error on recruitment only (R), recruitment and apparent survival (R+S), or recruitment and natural mortality (R+M).

Factor	R	R+S	R+M
Convergence	0.02	0.13	<0.01
OM F history	2.08	2.74	1.75
OM Obs. Error	1.09	0.18	1.19
OM σ_e	0.01	<0.01	<0.01
OM σ_E	<0.01	<0.01	<0.01
OM ρ_E	<0.01	<0.01	<0.01
OM β_E	<0.01	0.01	<0.01
EM Process Error	0.52	1.05	0.57
EM β_E assumption	<0.01	0.05	0.01
EM M assumption	1.76	2.12	1.51
All factors	5.97	6.58	5.21
+ All Two Way	12.81	13.00	11.97
+ All Three Way	16.41	15.57	15.73

888 **Supplemental Materials**

889 **Referenced Figures and Tables**



Fig. S1. Example simulations of environmental covariate latent processes and observations with different levels of observation error, and different assumptions about variability of the latent process.

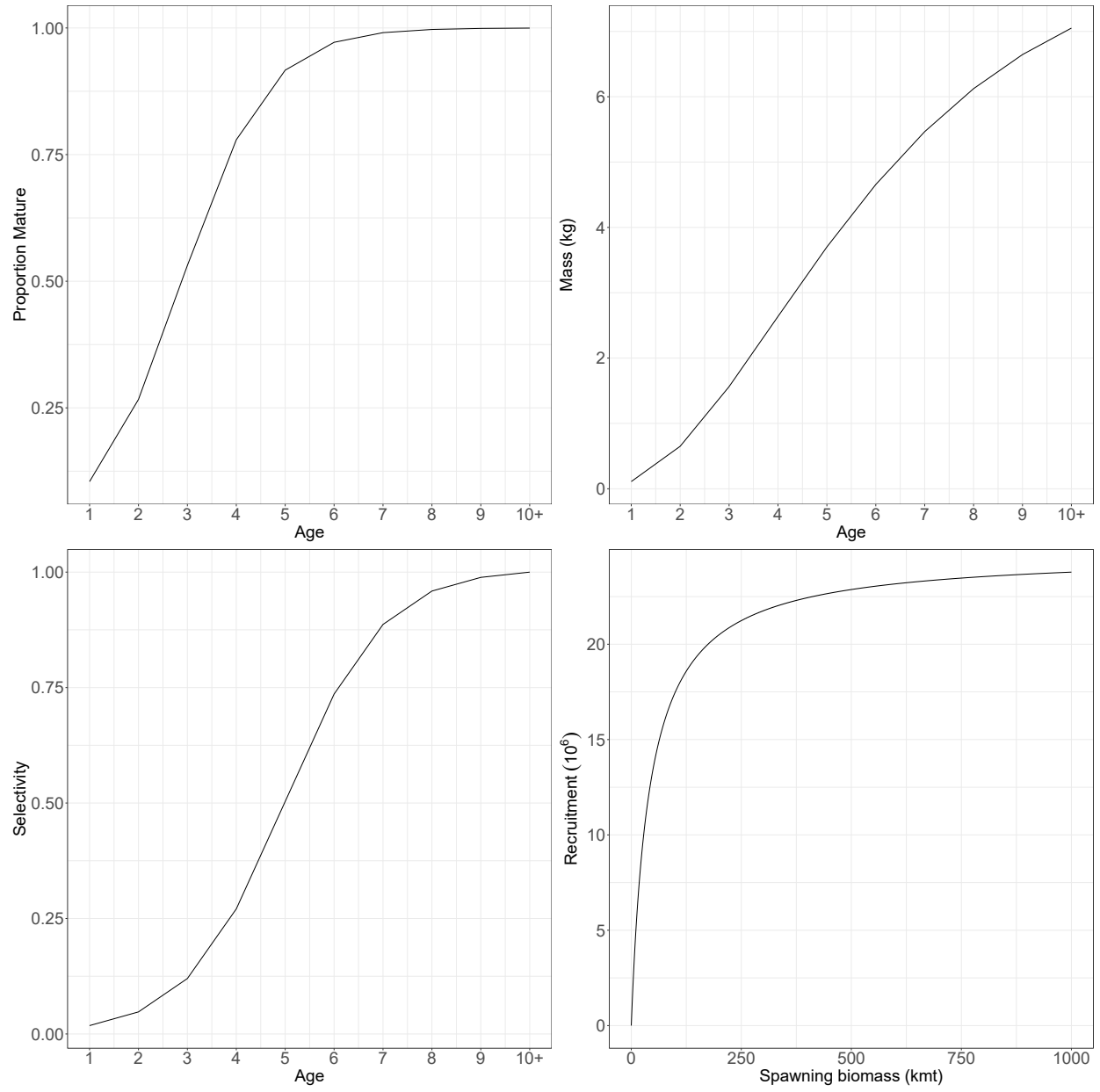


Fig. S2. The proportion mature at age, weight at age, fleet and index selectivity at age, and Beverton-Holt stock-recruit relationship assumed for the population in all OMs. For OMs with random effects on fleet selectivity, this represents the selectivity at the mean of the random effects.

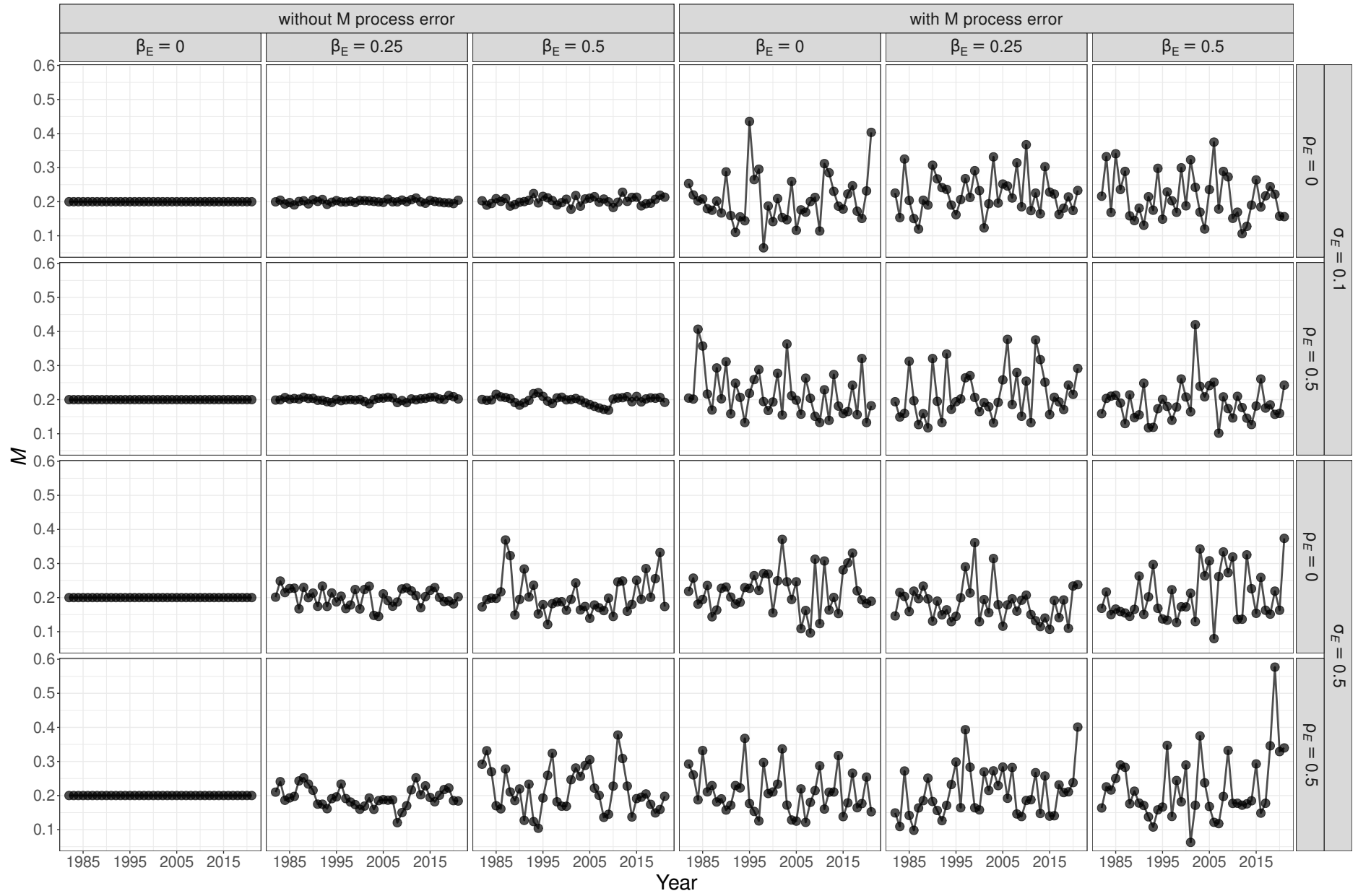


Fig. S3. Example simulations of annual M that may be a function of a temporally varying environmental covariate and autoregressive random effects.

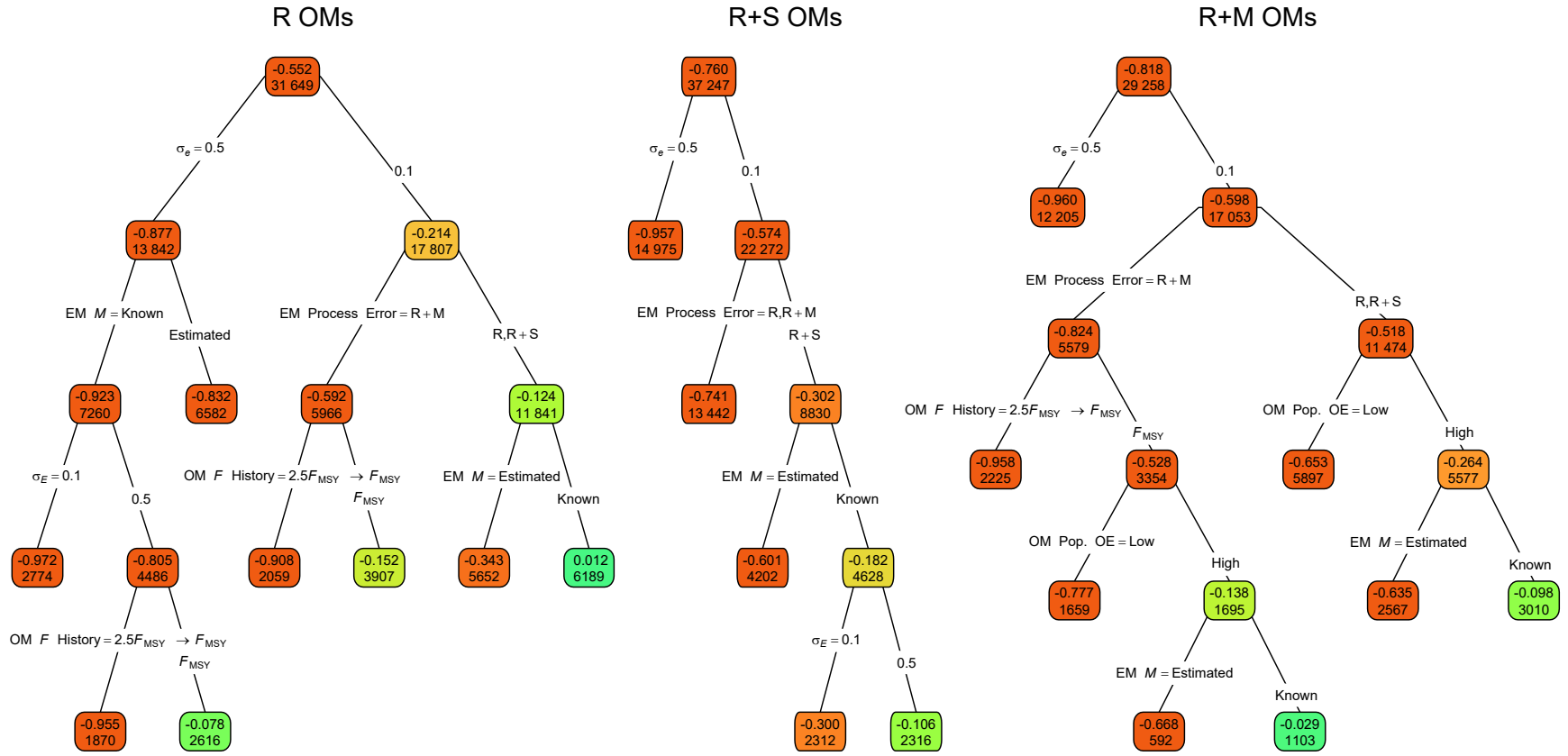


Fig. S4. Regression trees indicating primary factors determining reductions in sums of squares of errors in estimation of the Hessian-based standard error estimates for covariate effect on M ($\widehat{SE}(\widehat{\beta}_E)$) for operating models (OMs) with process error on recruitment only (R), recruitment and apparent survival (R+S), or recruitment and natural mortality (R+M). Each node shows the median error (top) and number of observations (bottom) for the corresponding subset. Lower or higher median absolute errors of the process error assumption are indicated by more green or red polygons, respectively.

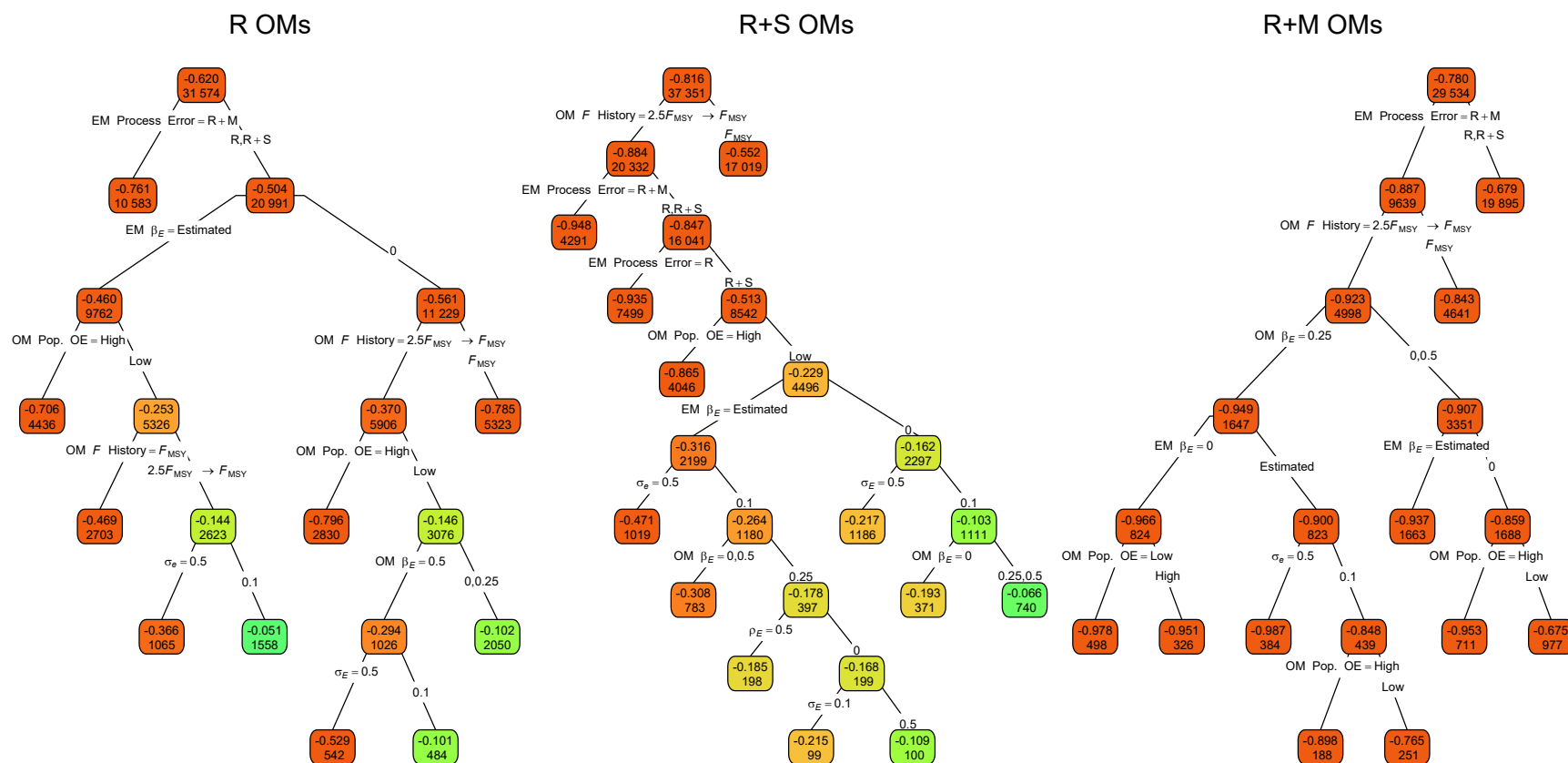


Fig. S5. Regression trees indicating primary factors determining reductions in sums of squares of errors in estimation of the Hessian-based standard error estimates for median M parameter ($\widehat{\text{SE}}(\hat{\beta}_M)$) in EMs fitted to operating models (OMs) with process error on recruitment only (R), recruitment and apparent survival (R+S), or recruitment and natural mortality (R+M). Each node shows the median error (top) and number of observations (bottom) for the corresponding subset. Lower or higher median absolute errors of the process error assumption are indicated by more green or red polygons, respectively.

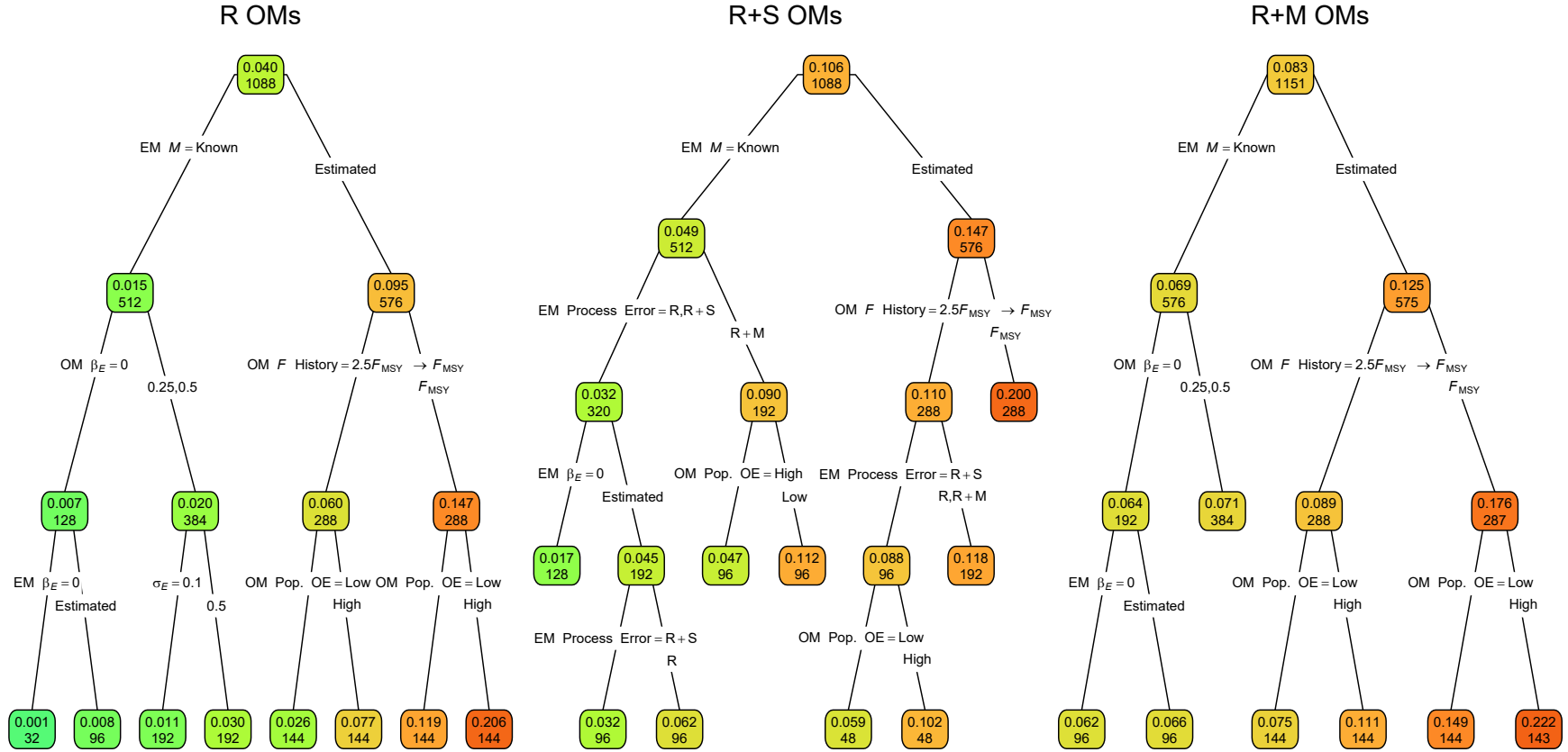


Fig. S6. Regression trees indicating primary factors determining reductions in sums of squares for the log-transformed RMSE of terminal year M in EMs fitted to operating models (OMs) with process error on recruitment only (R), recruitment and apparent survival (R+S), or recruitment and natural mortality (R+M). Each node shows the median error (top) and number of observations (bottom) for the corresponding subset. Lower or higher median RMSE are indicated by more red or green polygons, respectively.

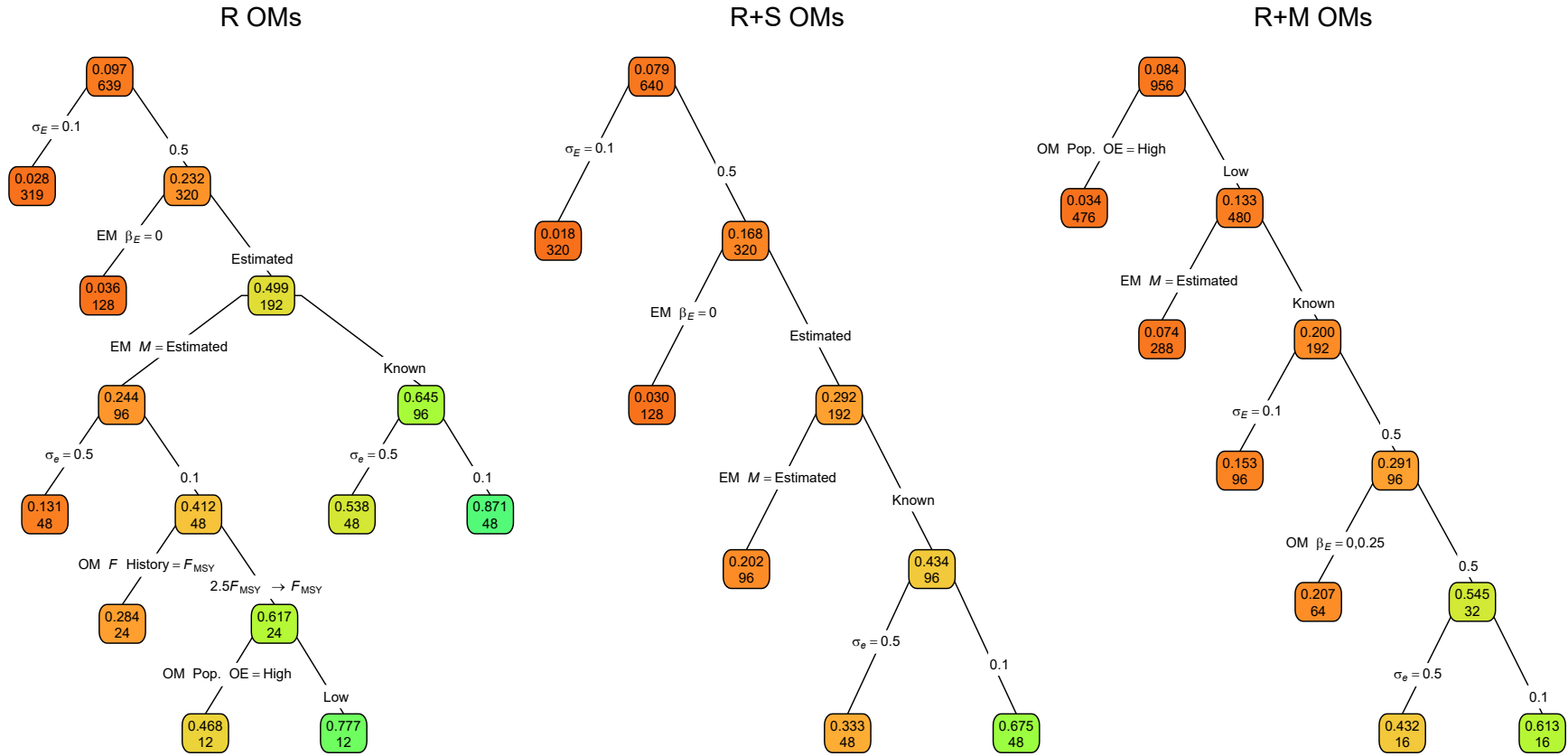


Fig. S7. Regression trees indicating primary factors determining reductions in sums of squares for the correlation of terminal year M estimates and true values in EMs fitted to operating models (OMs) with process error on recruitment only (R), recruitment and apparent survival (R+S), or recruitment and natural mortality (R+M). Each node shows the median error (top) and number of observations (bottom) for the corresponding subset. Lower or higher median correlations are indicated by more red or green polygons, respectively.

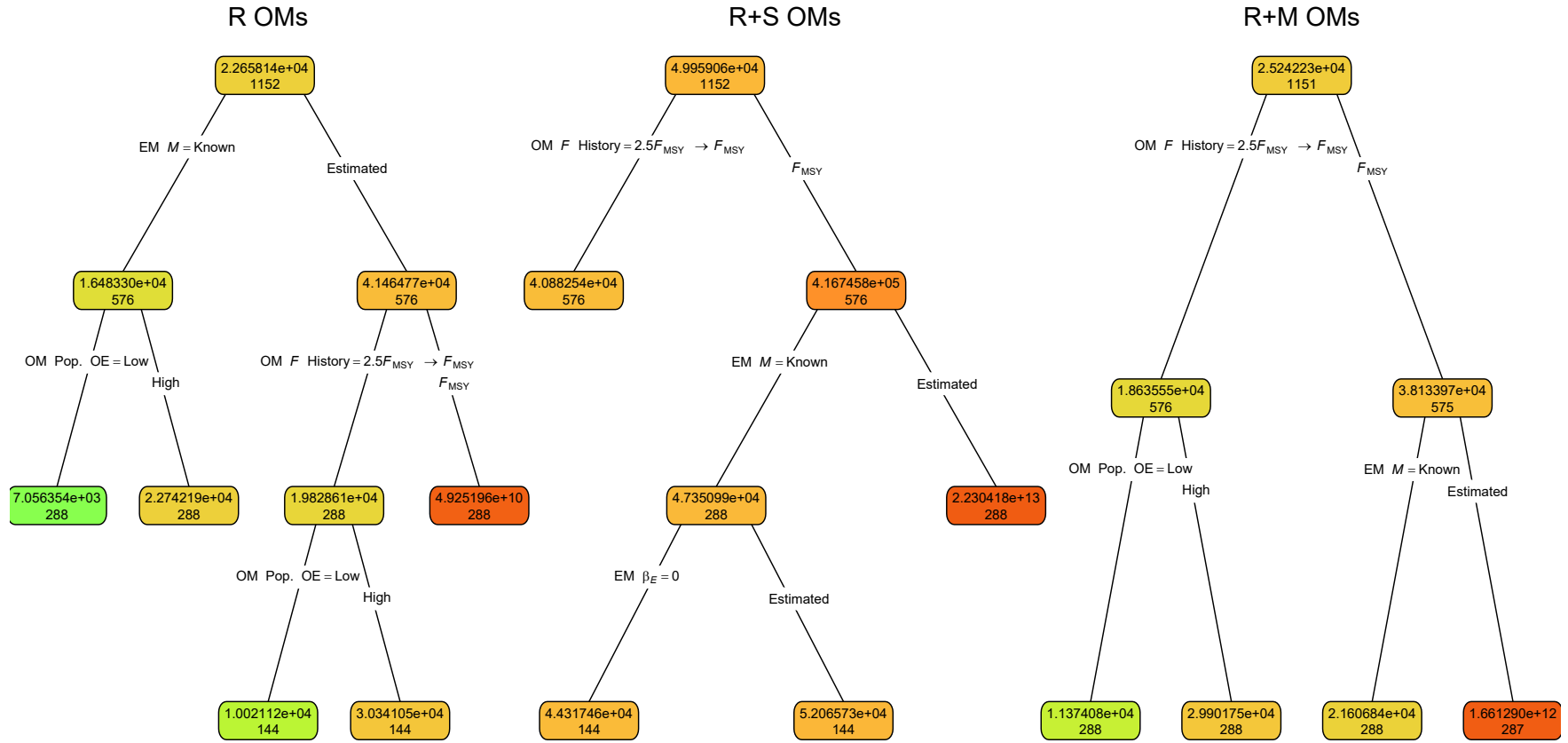


Fig. S8. Regression trees indicating primary factors determining reductions in sums of squares for the log-transformed RMSE of terminal year SSB in EMs fitted to operating models (OMs) with process error on recruitment only (R), recruitment and apparent survival (R+S), or recruitment and natural mortality (R+M). Each node shows the median error (top) and number of observations (bottom) for the corresponding subset. Lower or higher median RMSE are indicated by more red or green polygons, respectively.

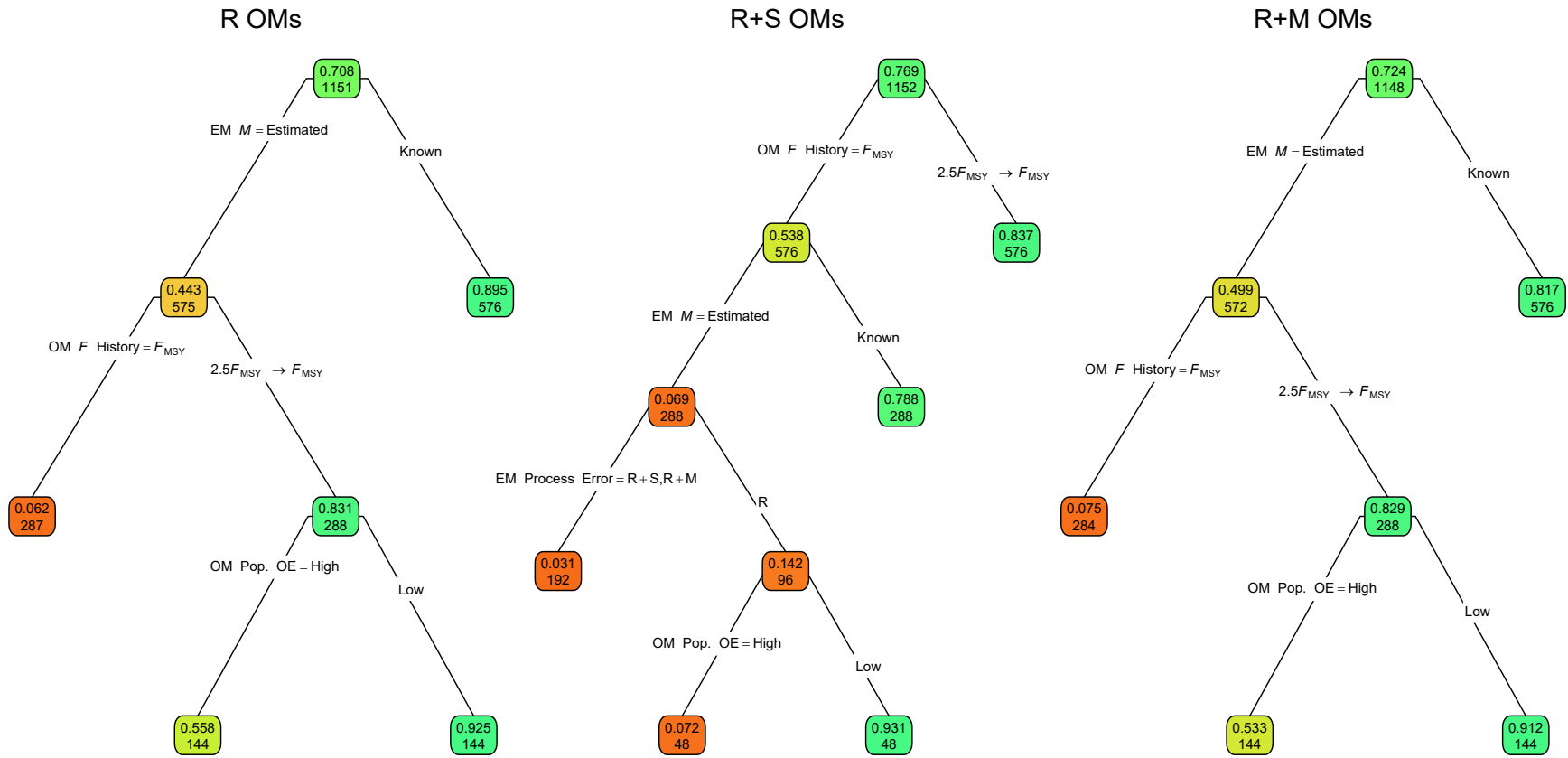


Fig. S9. Regression trees indicating primary factors determining reductions in sums of squares for the correlation of terminal year SSB estimates and true values in EMs fitted to operating models (OMs) with process error on recruitment only (R), recruitment and apparent survival (R+S), or recruitment and natural mortality (R+M). Each node shows the median error (top) and number of observations (bottom) for the corresponding subset. Lower or higher median correlations are indicated by more red or green polygons, respectively.

Table S1. Operating (OM) and estimating model (EM) attributes used in analyses of deviance reduction and classification and regression trees. R, R+S, and R+M, denote models (OM or EM) with process error on recruitment only, recruitment and apparent survival, and recruitment and natural mortality, respectively. SD denotes standard deviation and F_{MSY} is the fishing mortality rate that achieves maximum sustainable yield.

Factor	Levels
OM Process error	R, R+S, R+M
OM Fishing History	$F_{\text{MSY}}, 2.5F_{\text{MSY}} \rightarrow F_{\text{MSY}}$
OM Covariate effect size (β_E)	0, 0.25, 0.5
OM Population Observation Error	Low, High
OM Covariate Observation Error	Low ($\sigma_e = 0.1$), High ($\sigma_e = 0.5$)
OM Covariate Process Error SD (σ_E)	0.1, 0.5
OM Covariate Process Error Correlation (ρ_E)	0, 0.5
EM Process Error	R, R+S, R+M
EM Covariate Effect	None ($\beta_E = 0$), β_E estimated
EM Median Natural Mortality Rate Parameter (β_M)	Known, Estimated

Table S2. Percent reduction in deviance for linear regression models fit to errors in estimation of the Hessian-based standard error of the estimates of the covariate effect on M ($\widehat{\text{SE}}(\hat{\beta}_E)$). Table rows give each operating model (OM) and estimating model (EM) factor included individually, combined, and with second and third order interactions. Table columns are operating models (OMs) with process error on recruitment only (R), recruitment and apparent survival (R+S), or recruitment and natural mortality (R+M).

Factor	R	R+S	R+M
OM F history	1.84	2.68	4.00
OM Obs. Error	0.06	2.74	8.04
OM σ_e	6.27	7.28	12.83
OM σ_E	0.48	1.05	0.46
OM ρ_E	0.17	0.01	0.02
OM β_E	0.37	0.01	0.05
EM Process Error	2.90	3.89	2.98
EM M assumption	0.15	0.34	0.47
All factors	13.01	20.95	29.24
+ All Two Way	28.58	32.25	42.77
+ All Three Way	44.44	42.83	51.84

Table S3. Percent reduction in deviance for linear regression models fit to errors in estimation of the Hessian-based standard error of the estimates of the median M parameter ($\widehat{\text{SE}}(\hat{\beta}_M)$). Table rows give each operating model (OM) and estimating model (EM) factor included individually, combined, and with second and third order interactions. Table columns are operating models (OMs) with process error on recruitment only (R), recruitment and apparent survival (R+S), or recruitment and natural mortality (R+M).

Factor	R	R+S	R+M
OM F history	0.55	12.91	3.65
OM Obs. Error	0.98	0.01	0.07
OM σ_e	<0.01	0.03	0.11
OM σ_E	0.13	0.03	0.19
OM ρ_E	<0.01	0.02	<0.01
OM β_E	0.12	0.07	0.23
EM Process Error	3.16	8.79	6.83
EM β_E assumption	0.18	8.96	3.81
All factors	5.32	28.39	14.71
+ All Two Way	11.80	44.67	22.70
+ All Three Way	17.83	51.54	29.46

Table S4. Percent reduction in deviance for linear regression models fit to log-transformed RMSE of terminal year natural mortality (M). Table rows give each operating model (OM) and estimating model (EM) factor included individually, combined, and with second and third order interactions. Table columns are operating models (OMs) with process error on recruitment only (R), recruitment and apparent survival (R+S), or recruitment and natural mortality (R+M).

Factor	R	R+S	R+M
OM F history	0.26	2.21	14.65
OM Obs. Error	1.65	0.71	4.68
$OM\sigma_e$	0.02	0.16	0.01
$OM\sigma_E$	1.06	1.23	0.84
$OM\rho_E$	0.02	0.01	<0.01
OM β_E	3.73	1.94	1.14
EM Process Error	2.04	3.85	0.87
$EM\beta_E$ assumption	0.19	0.59	0.07
EM M assumption	22.28	45.15	44.70
All factors	32.83	56.71	66.99
+ All Two Way	57.65	84.17	87.96
+ All Three Way	74.93	94.57	91.94

Table S5. Percent reduction in deviance for linear regression models fit to correlation of terminal year natural mortality (M) estimates and true values. Table rows give each operating model (OM) and estimating model (EM) factor included individually, combined, and with second and third order interactions. Table columns are operating models (OMs) with process error on recruitment only (R), recruitment and apparent survival (R+S), or recruitment and natural mortality (R+M).

Factor	R	R+S	R+M
OM F history	0.05	0.02	0.37
OM Obs. Error	2.00	0.89	3.73
$OM\sigma_e$	2.30	2.56	0.37
$OM\sigma_E$	14.91	13.78	3.03
$OM\rho_E$	1.98	0.33	0.14
OM β_E	0.41	3.76	3.87
EM Process Error	0.43	1.52	0.62
$EM\beta_E$ assumption	12.72	12.30	1.56
EM M assumption	12.34	7.16	3.03
All factors	42.11	38.31	15.76
+ All Two Way	63.38	62.40	31.99
+ All Three Way	72.79	75.98	46.62

Table S6. Percent reduction in deviance for linear regression models fit to log-transformed RMSE of terminal year spawning stock biomass (SSB). Table rows give each operating model (OM) and estimating model (EM) factor included individually, combined, and with second and third order interactions. Table columns are operating models (OMs) with process error on recruitment only (R), recruitment and apparent survival (R+S), or recruitment and natural mortality (R+M).

Factor	R	R+S	R+M
OM F history	19.88	32.67	20.92
OM Obs. Error	2.21	0.11	1.48
$OM\sigma_e$	0.05	0.16	0.03
$OM\sigma_E$	0.08	0.16	0.02
$OM\rho_E$	0.03	<0.01	0.02
OM β_E	0.05	0.03	0.14
EM Process Error	5.72	0.13	5.73
$EM\beta_E$ assumption	0.03	0.79	0.05
EM M assumption	20.05	21.11	19.43
All factors	48.09	55.17	47.82
+ All Two Way	79.09	80.98	78.40
+ All Three Way	88.30	89.49	87.67

Table S7. Percent reduction in deviance for linear regression models fit to correlation of terminal year spawning stock biomass (SSB) estimates and true values. Table rows give each operating model (OM) and estimating model (EM) factor included individually, combined, and with second and third order interactions. Table columns are operating models (OMs) with process error on recruitment only (R), recruitment and apparent survival (R+S), or recruitment and natural mortality (R+M).

Factor	R	R+S	R+M
OM F history	19.27	25.70	19.59
OM Obs. Error	12.53	3.60	9.46
$OM\sigma_e$	0.08	0.44	0.09
$OM\sigma_E$	0.10	0.44	0.11
$OM\rho_E$	<0.01	<0.01	0.09
OM β_E	0.09	0.05	<0.01
EM Process Error	0.07	0.92	0.71
$EM\beta_E$ assumption	<0.01	1.32	0.38
EM M assumption	28.94	19.74	25.36
All factors	61.19	52.21	56.09
+ All Two Way	81.48	72.16	74.98
+ All Three Way	85.23	83.22	80.48

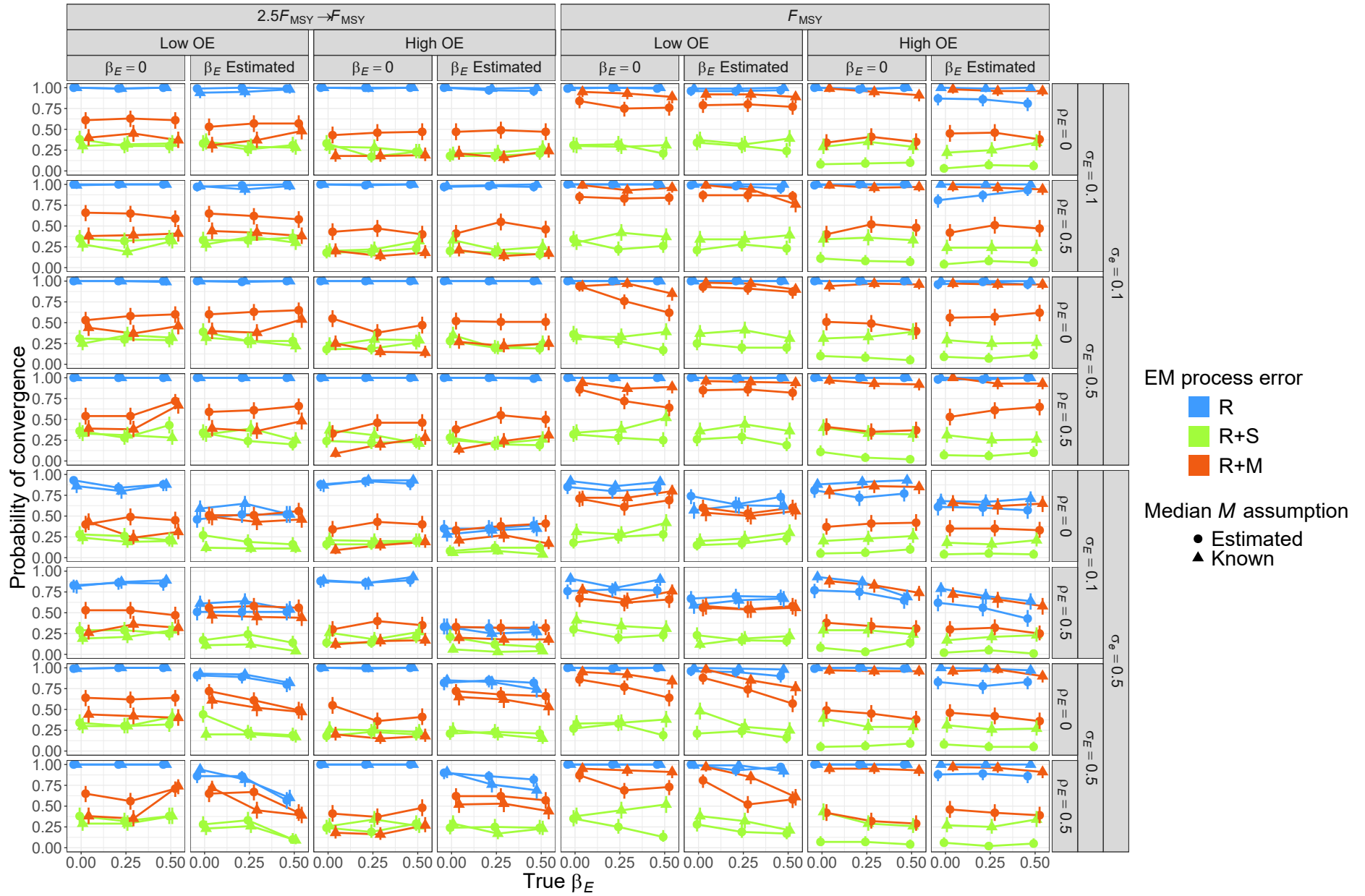


Fig. S10. Estimated probability of fits providing Hessian-based standard errors for EMs assuming alternative process error, that estimate or assume known median M , and that estimate or assume no covariate effect on median M when fitted to R OMs and three levels of true covariate effect on median M (x axis). Vertical lines represent 95% confidence intervals.

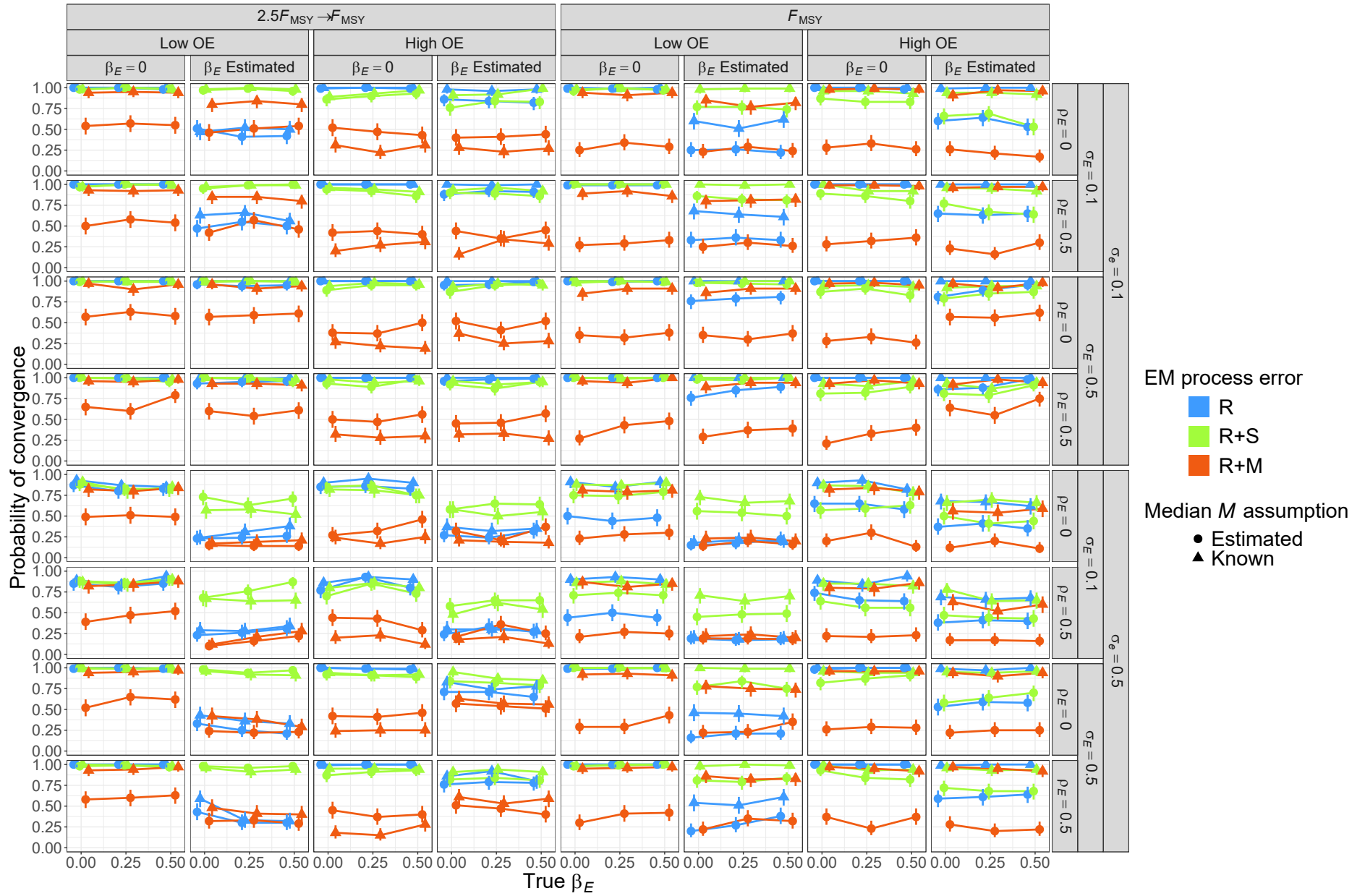


Fig. S11. Estimated probability of fits providing Hessian-based standard errors for EMs assuming alternative process error, that estimate or assume known median M , and that estimate or assume no covariate effect on median M when fitted to R+S OM and three levels of true covariate effect on median M (x axis). Vertical lines represent 95% confidence intervals.

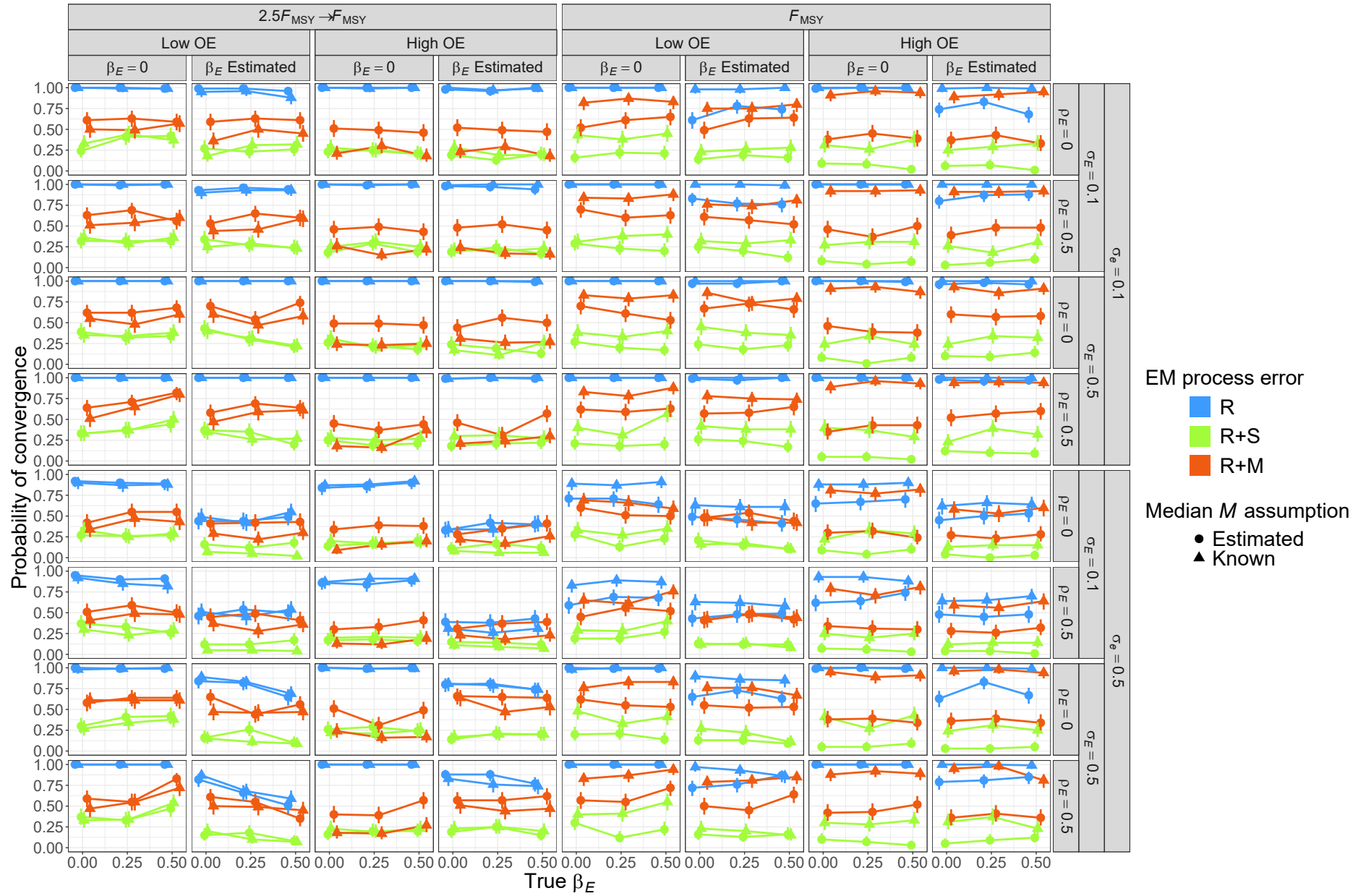


Fig. S12. Estimated probability of fits providing Hessian-based standard errors for EMs assuming alternative process error, that estimate or assume known median M , and that estimate or assume no covariate effect on median M when fitted to R+M OM and three levels of true covariate effect on median M (x axis). Vertical lines represent 95% confidence intervals.

891 **AIC results**

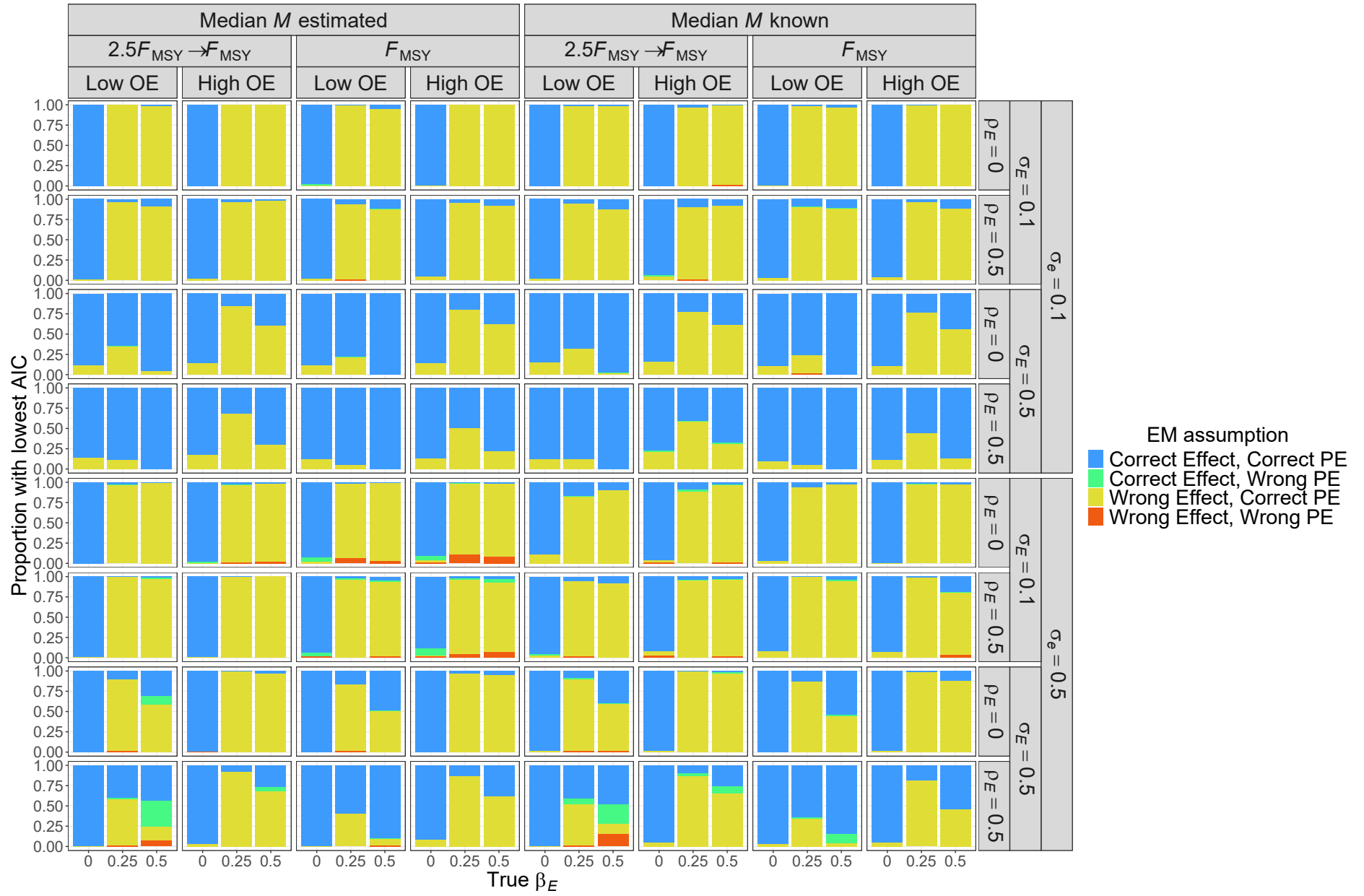


Fig. S13. Proportion of simulated data sets for R OMs where the EM type (treatment of environmental covariate and assumed process error type) had the lowest AIC.

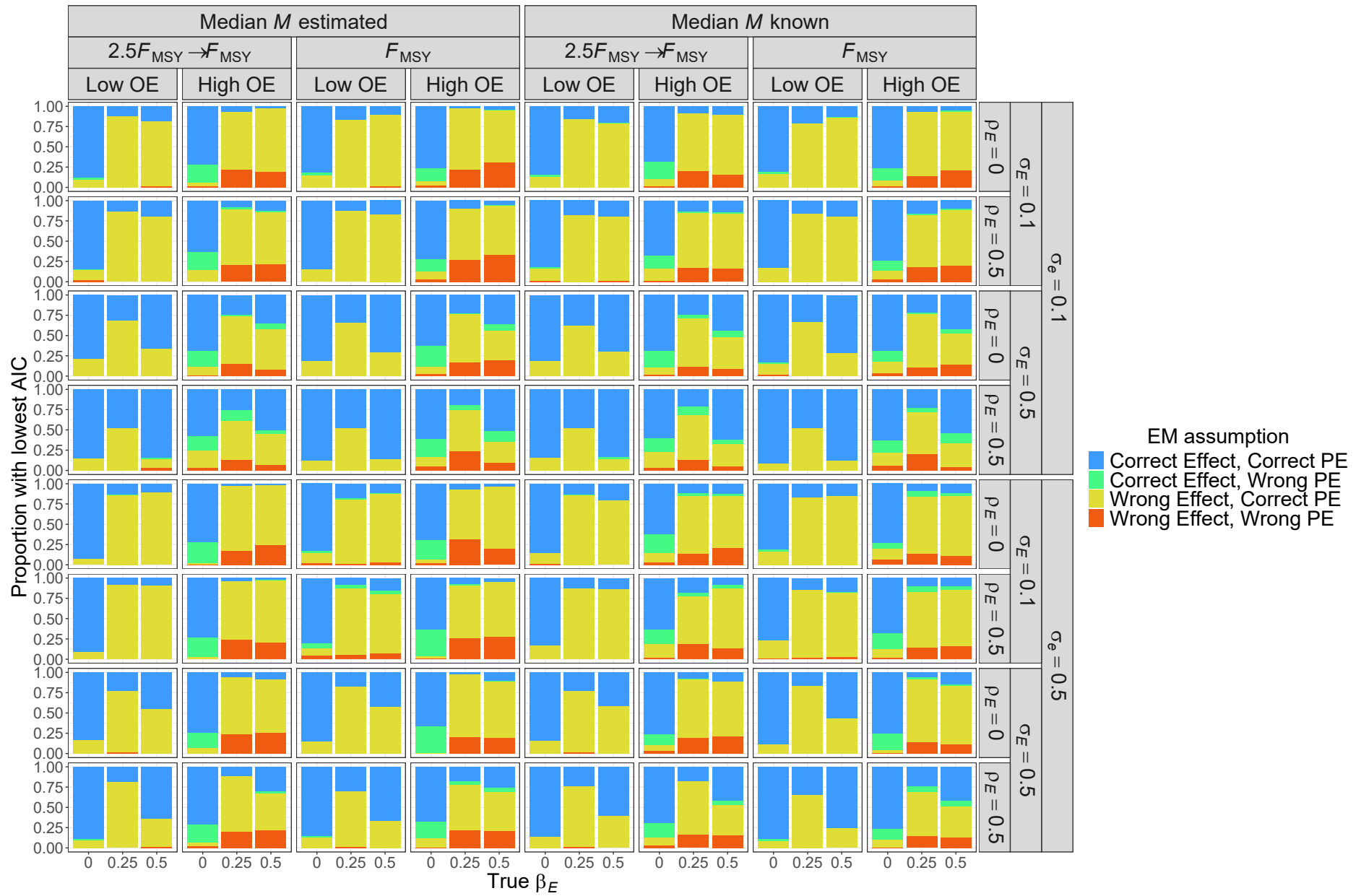


Fig. S14. Proportion of simulated data sets for R+S OMs where the EM type (treatment of environmental covariate and assumed process error type) had the lowest AIC.

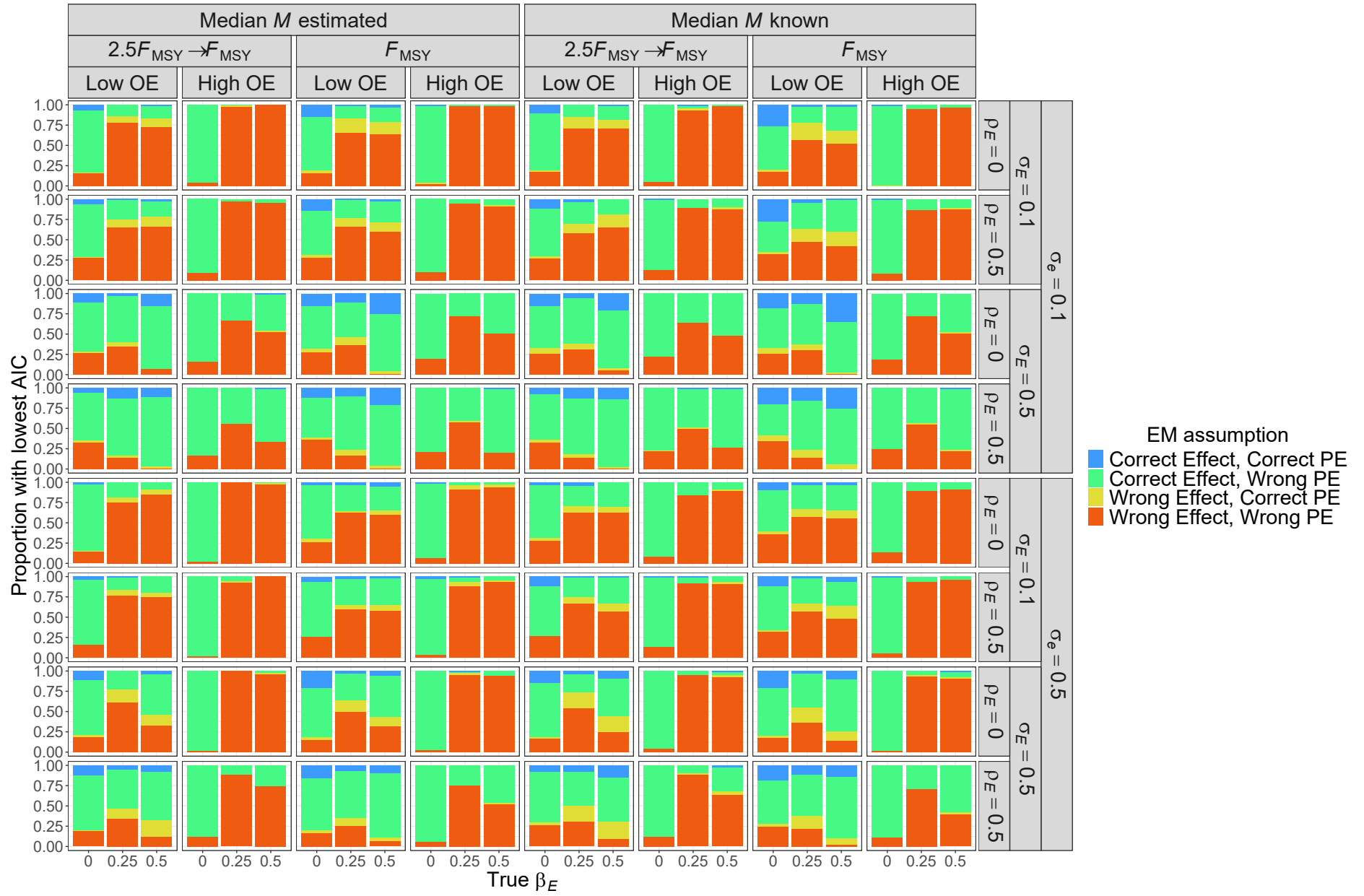


Fig. S15. Proportion of simulated data sets for R+M OMs where the EM type (treatment of environmental covariate and assumed process error type) had the lowest AIC.

Table S8. Percent reduction in deviance for linear regression models fit to errors in estimation of the covariate effect on M (β_E). Table rows give each operating model (OM) and estimating model (EM) factor included individually, combined, and with second and third order interactions. Table columns are operating models (OMs) with process error on recruitment only (R), recruitment and apparent survival (R+S), or recruitment and natural mortality (R+M).

Factor	R	R+S	R+M
OM F history	<0.01	0.01	<0.01
OM Obs. Error	<0.01	<0.01	<0.01
OM σ_e	<0.01	<0.01	<0.01
OM σ_E	<0.01	<0.01	<0.01
OM ρ_E	<0.01	<0.01	<0.01
OM β_E	<0.01	0.01	<0.01
EM Convergence	<0.01	<0.01	<0.01
EM Process Error	<0.01	0.01	0.01
EM M assumption	<0.01	<0.01	<0.01
All factors	0.02	0.03	0.03
+ All Two Way	0.16	0.20	0.18
+ All Three Way	0.58	0.73	0.59

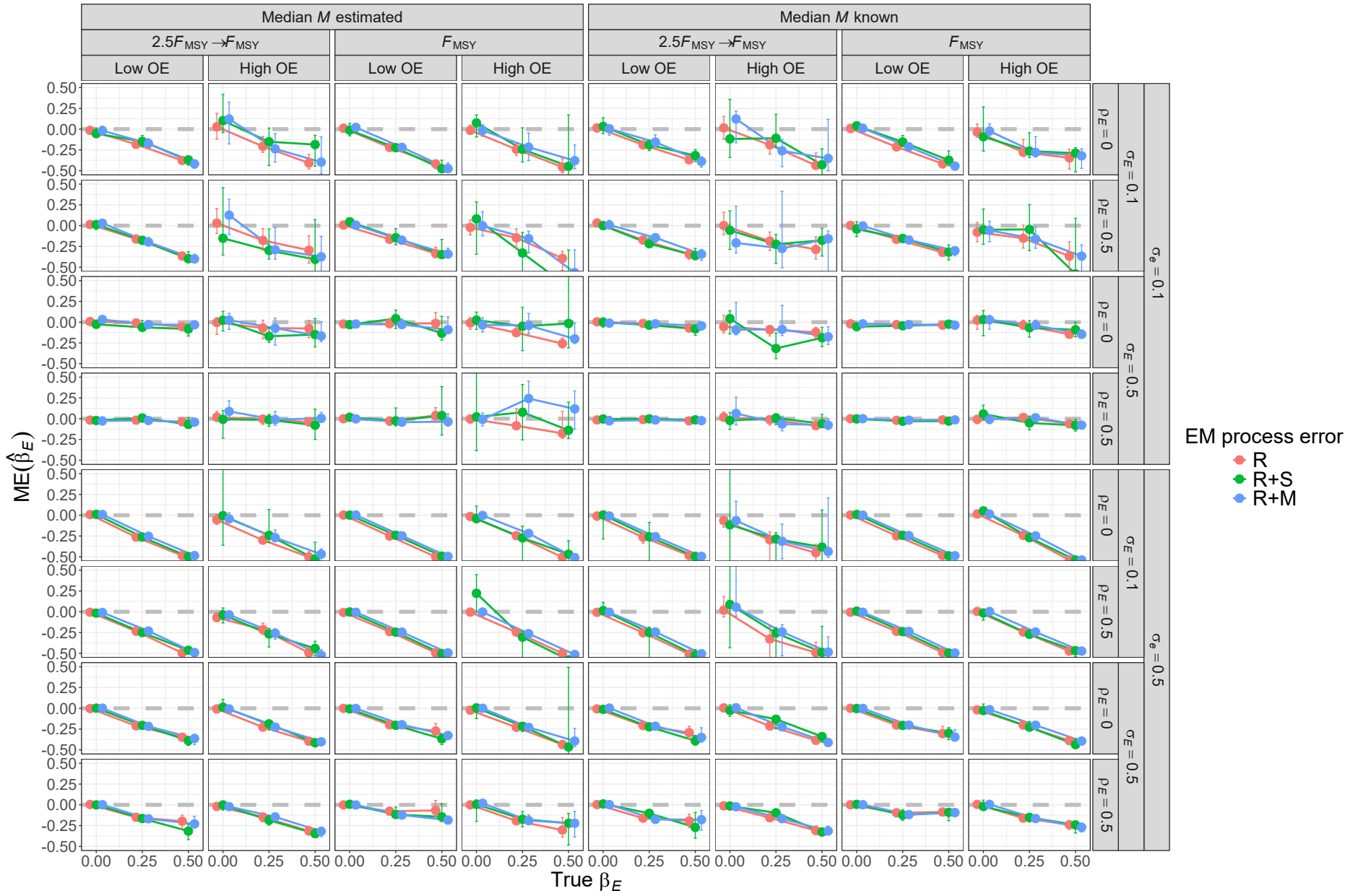


Fig. S16. For R OMs, median error (ME) of estimates of environmental effect on M (β_E) from fitting EMs with alternative process error assumptions and treatment of median M parameter (β_M). Vertical lines represent 95% confidence intervals.

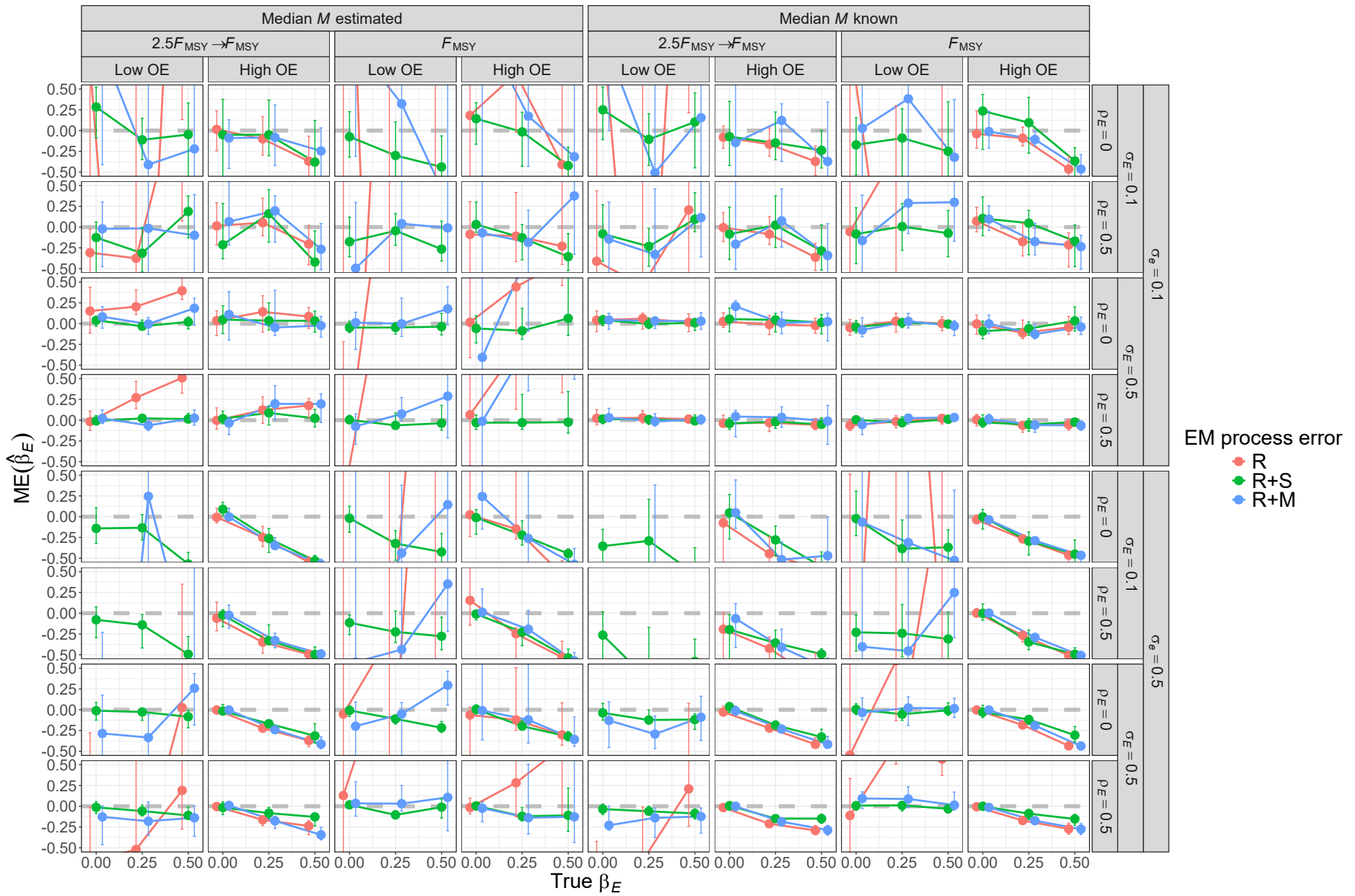


Fig. S17. For R+S OMs, median error (ME) of estimates of environmental effect on M (β_E) from fitting EMs with alternative process error assumptions and treatment of median M parameter (β_M). Vertical lines represent 95% confidence intervals.

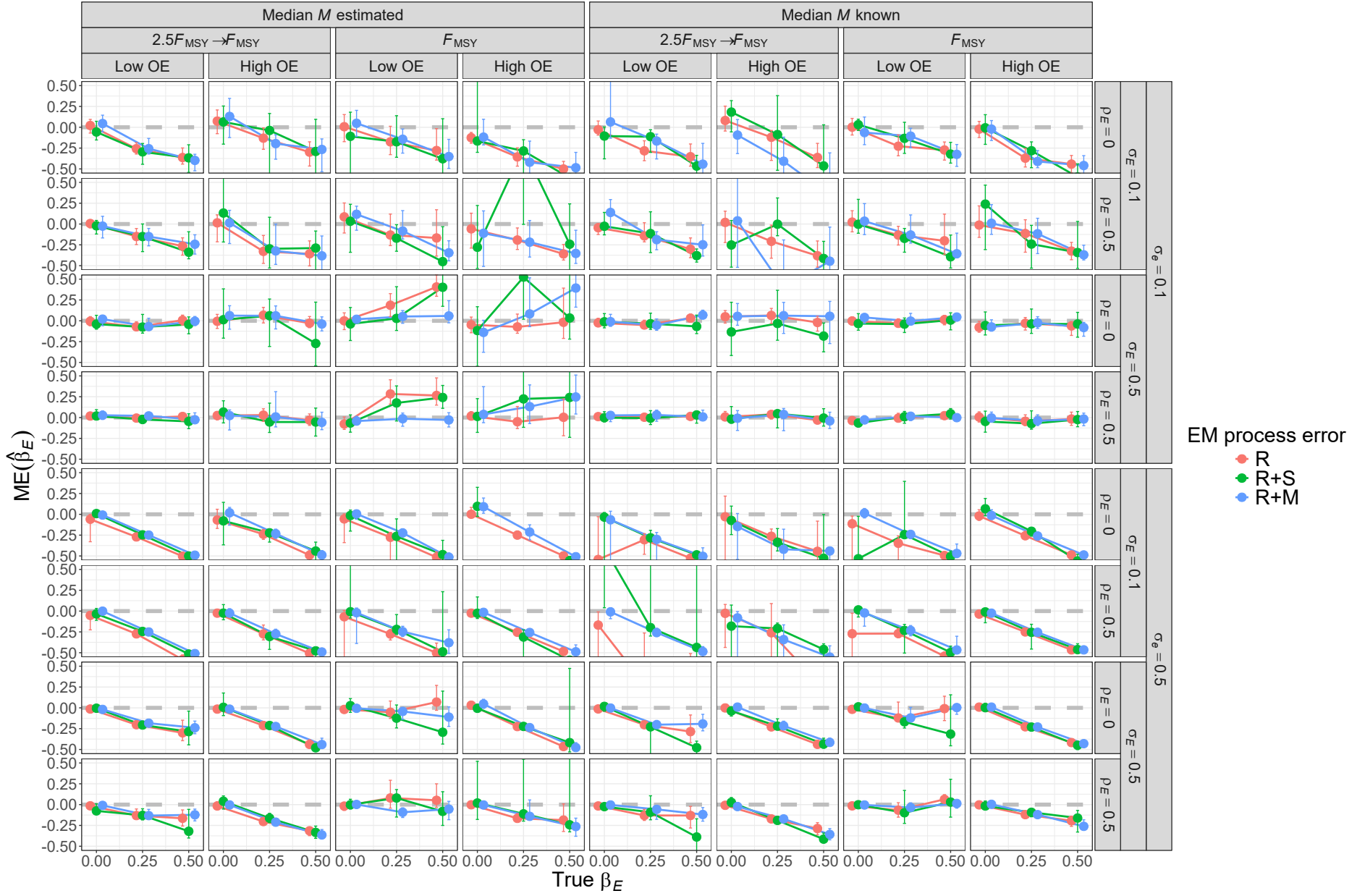


Fig. S18. For R+M OMs, median error (ME) of estimates of environmental effect on M (β_E) from fitting EMs with alternative process error assumptions and treatment of median M parameter (β_M). Vertical lines represent 95% confidence intervals.

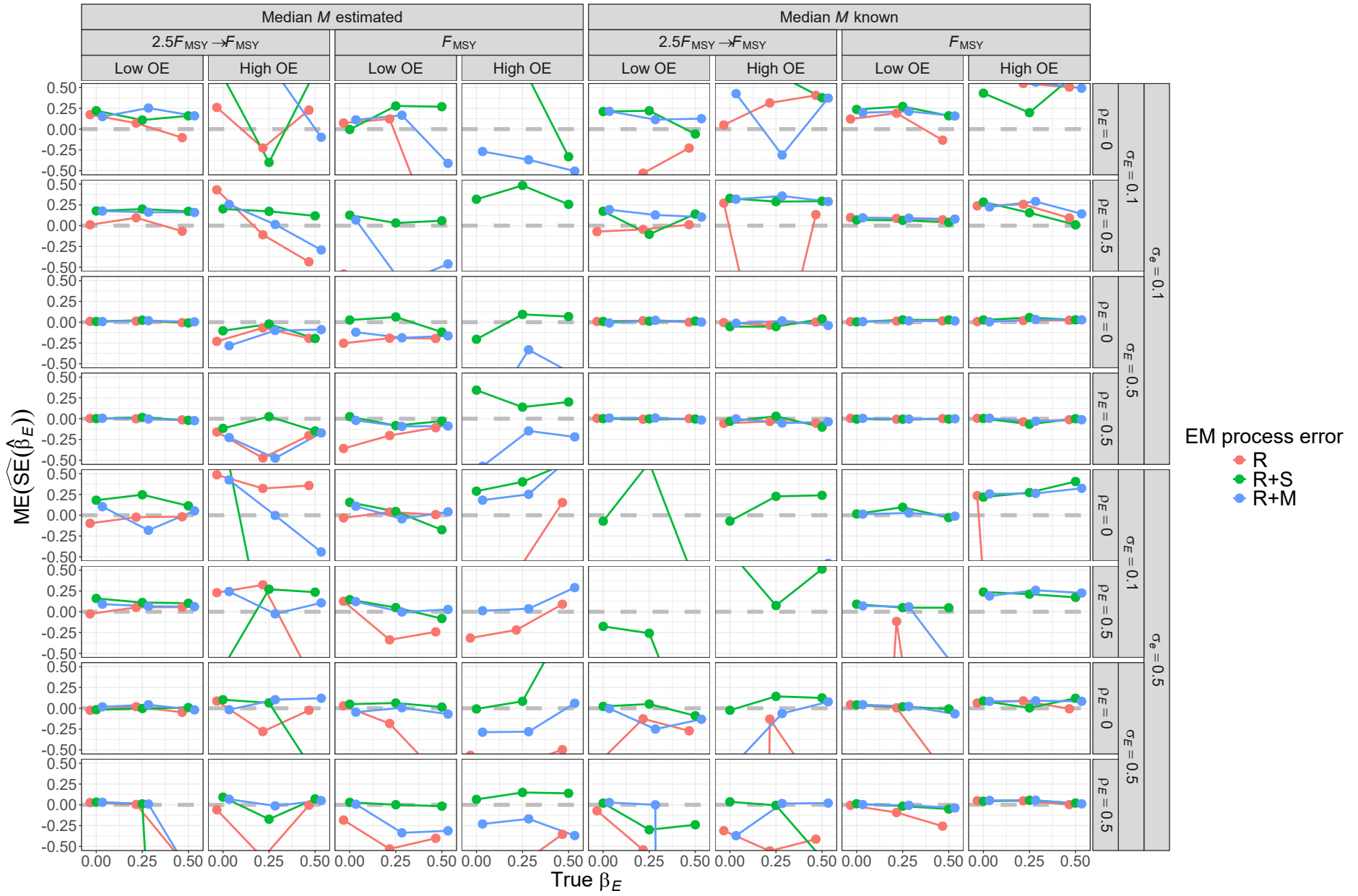


Fig. S19. For R OMs, median error (ME) of Hessian-based estimates of standard error for covariate effect on M (β_E) from fitting EMs with alternative process error assumptions and treatment of median M parameter (β_M). True standard error is defined as the mean of the standard error estimates across converged fits to simulated data sets for a given OM scenario.

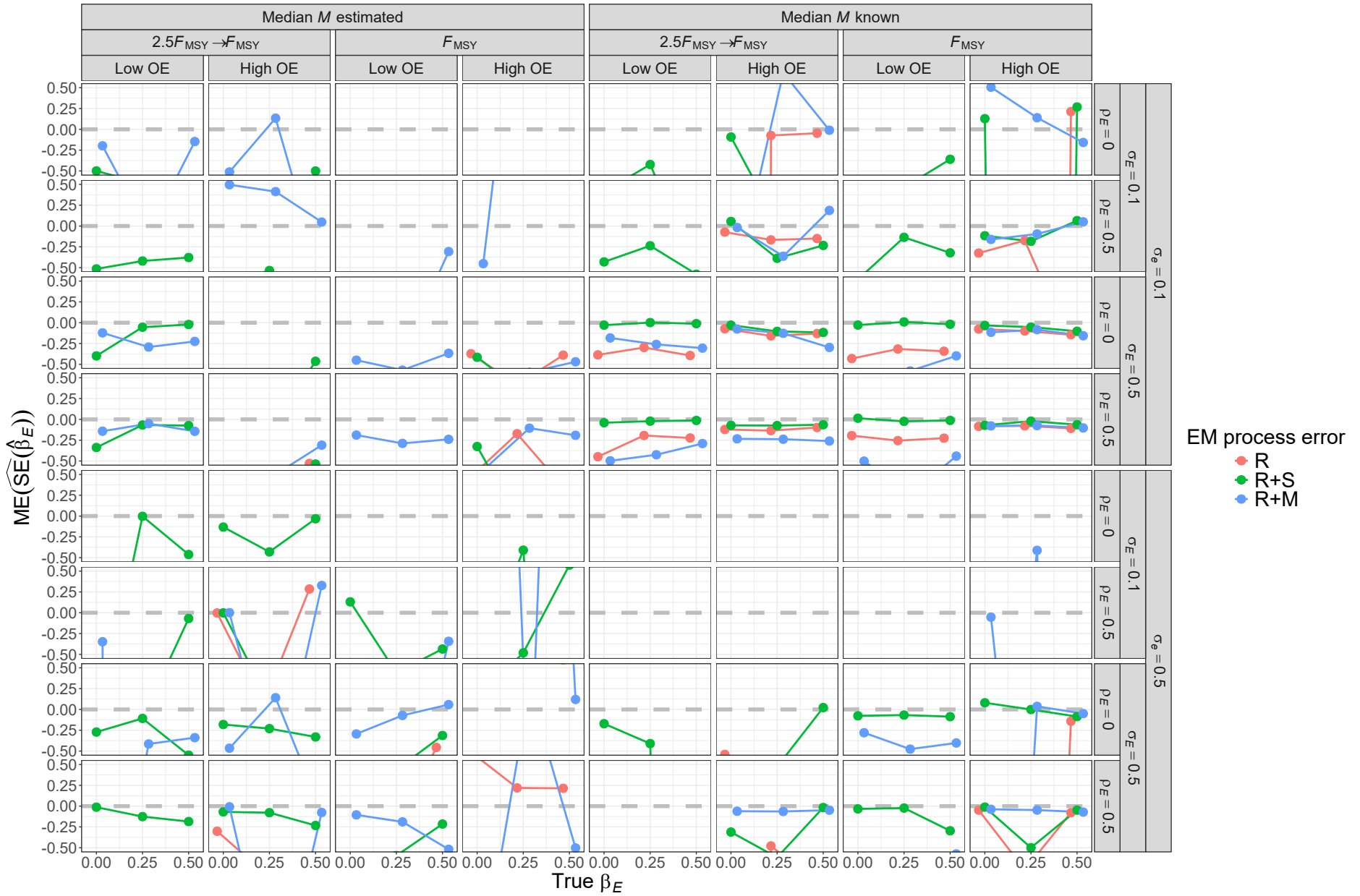


Fig. S20. For R+S OMs, median error (ME) of Hessian-based estimates of standard error for covariate effect on M (β_E) from fitting EMs with alternative process error assumptions and treatment of median M parameter (β_M). True standard error is defined as the mean of the standard error estimates across converged fits to simulated data sets for a given OM scenario.

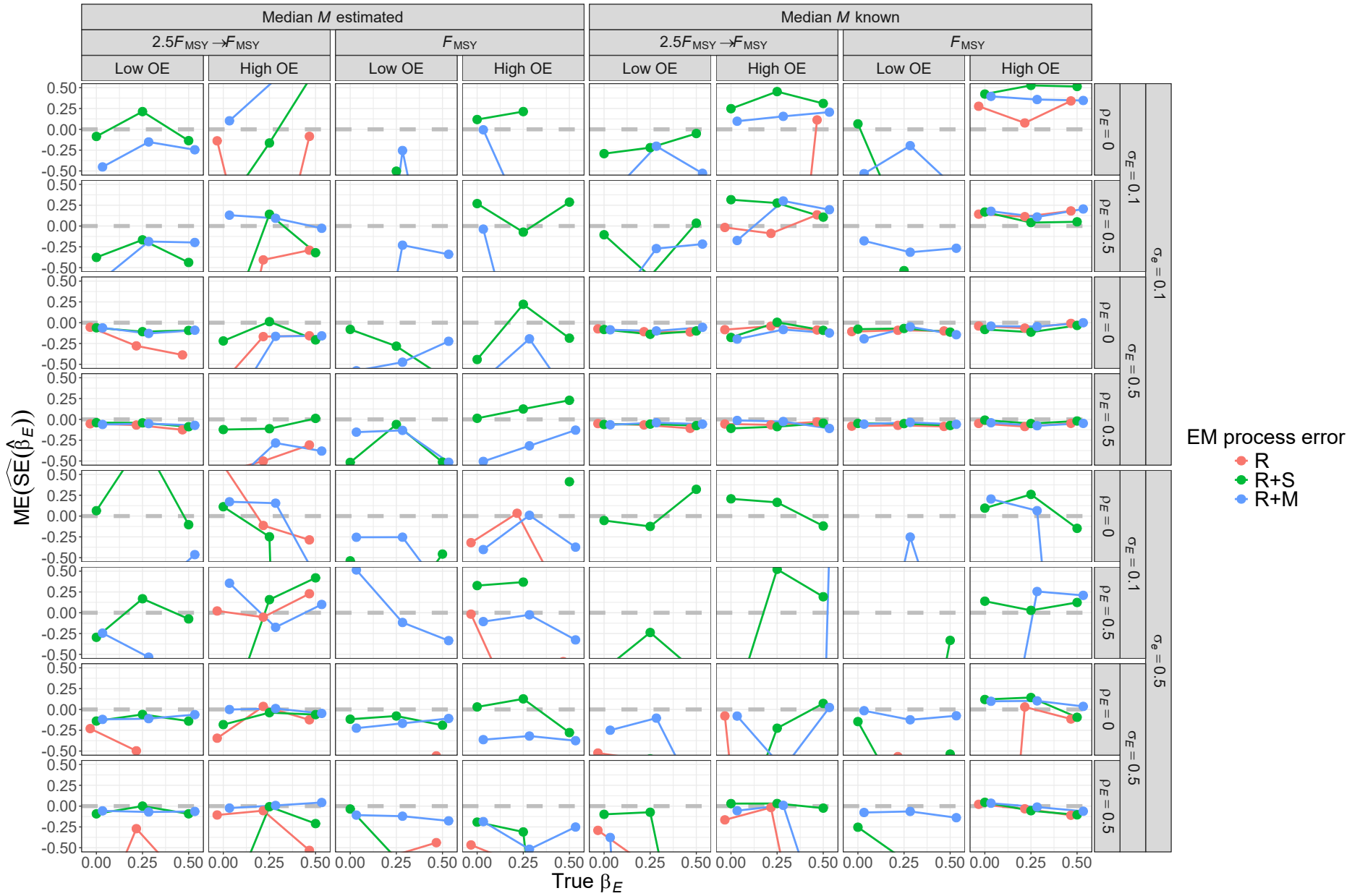


Fig. S21. For R+M OM, median error (ME) of Hessian-based estimates of standard error for covariate effect on M (β_E) from fitting EMs with alternative process error assumptions and treatment of median M parameter (β_M). True standard error is defined as the mean of the standard error estimates across converged fits to simulated data sets for a given OM scenario.

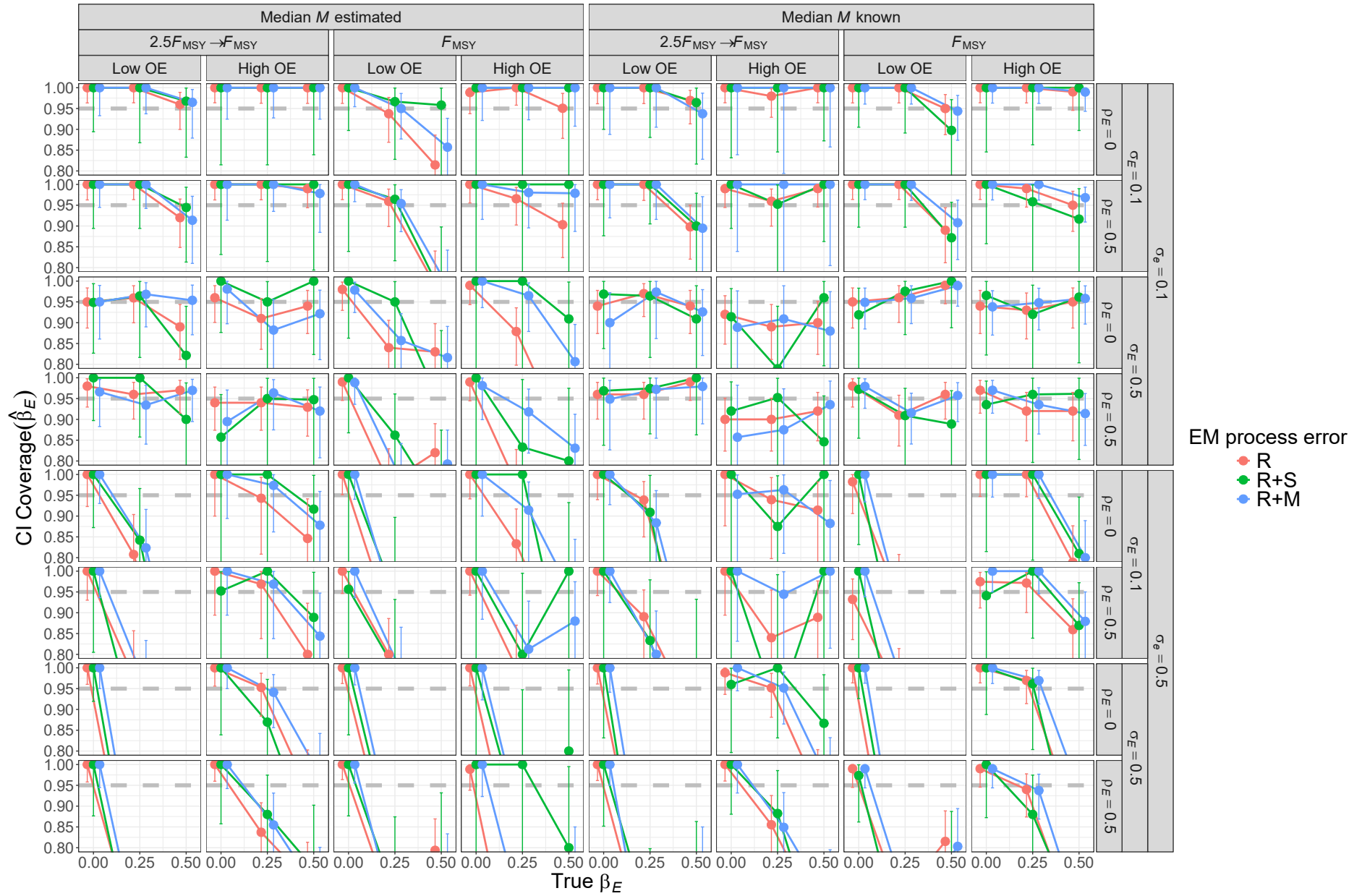


Fig. S22. For R OMs, probability of 95% confidence interval for β_E containing the true value for EMs with alternative process error assumptions and treatment of median M parameter (β_M). Vertical lines represent 95% confidence intervals.

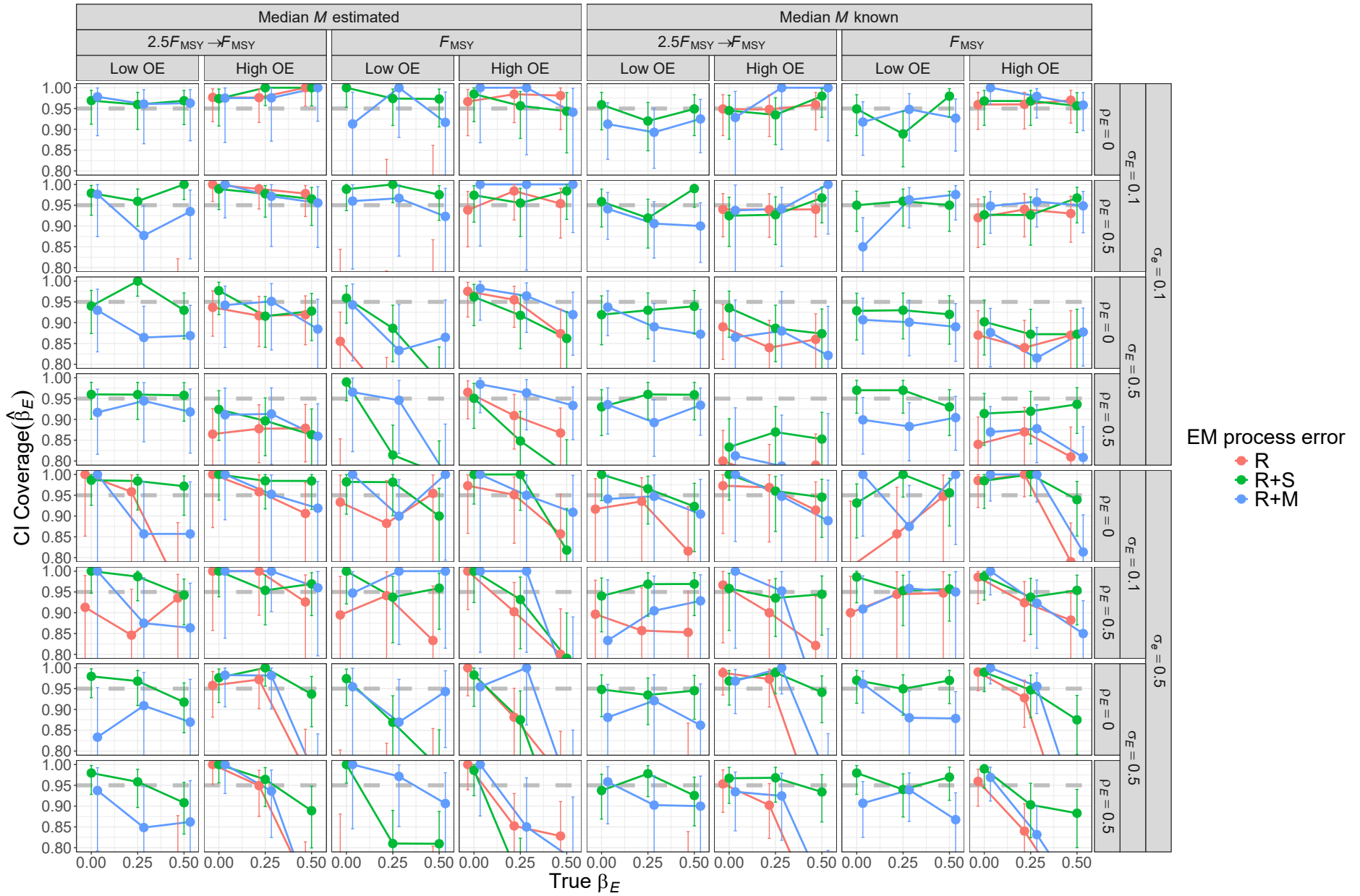


Fig. S23. For R+S OMs, probability of 95% confidence interval for β_E containing the true value for EMs with alternative process error assumptions and treatment of median M parameter (β_M). Vertical lines represent 95% confidence intervals.

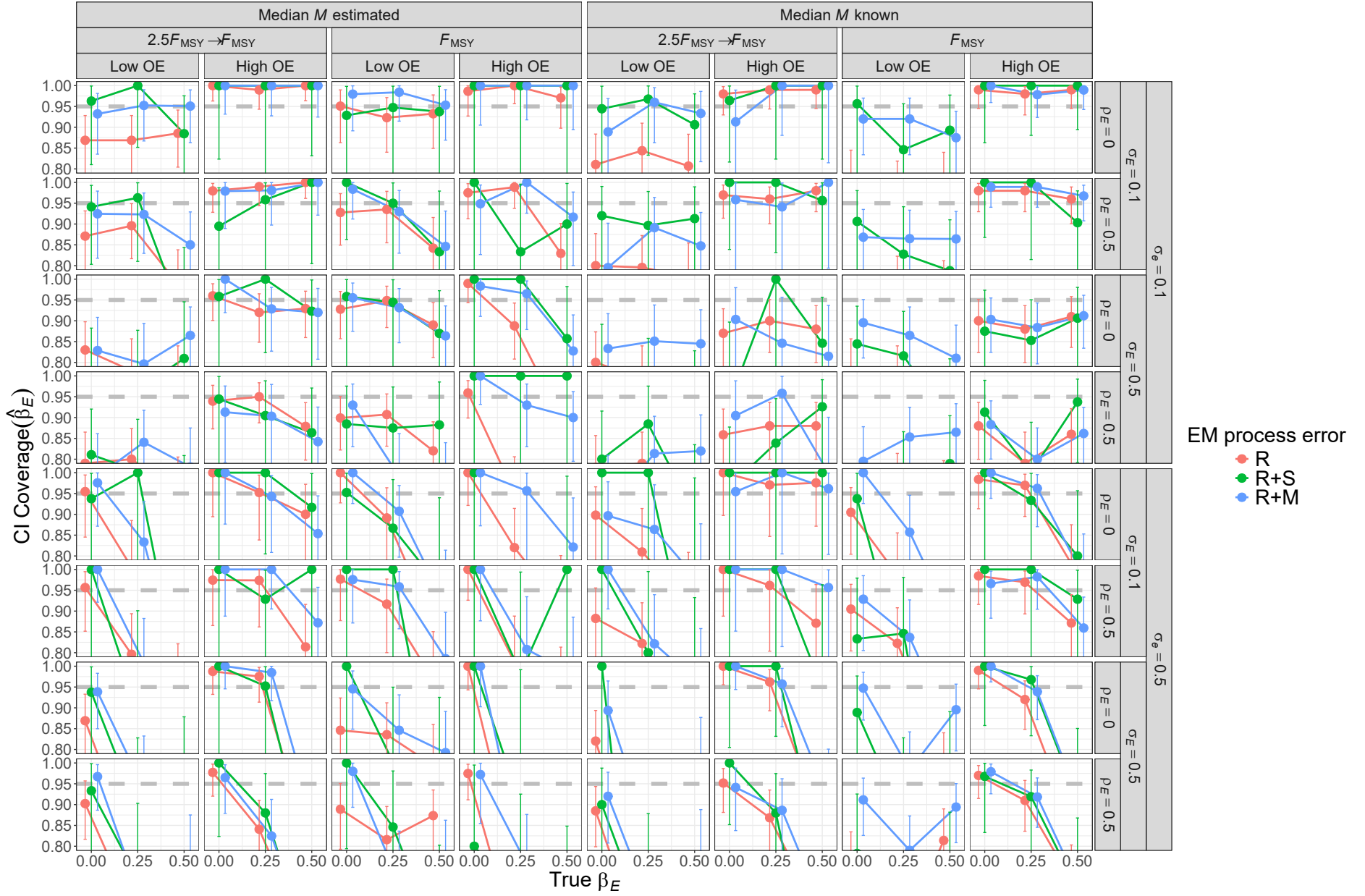


Fig. S24. For R+M OMs, probability of 95% confidence interval for β_E containing the true value for EMs with alternative process error assumptions and treatment of median M parameter (β_M). Vertical lines represent 95% confidence intervals.

895 **Covariate effect RMSE**

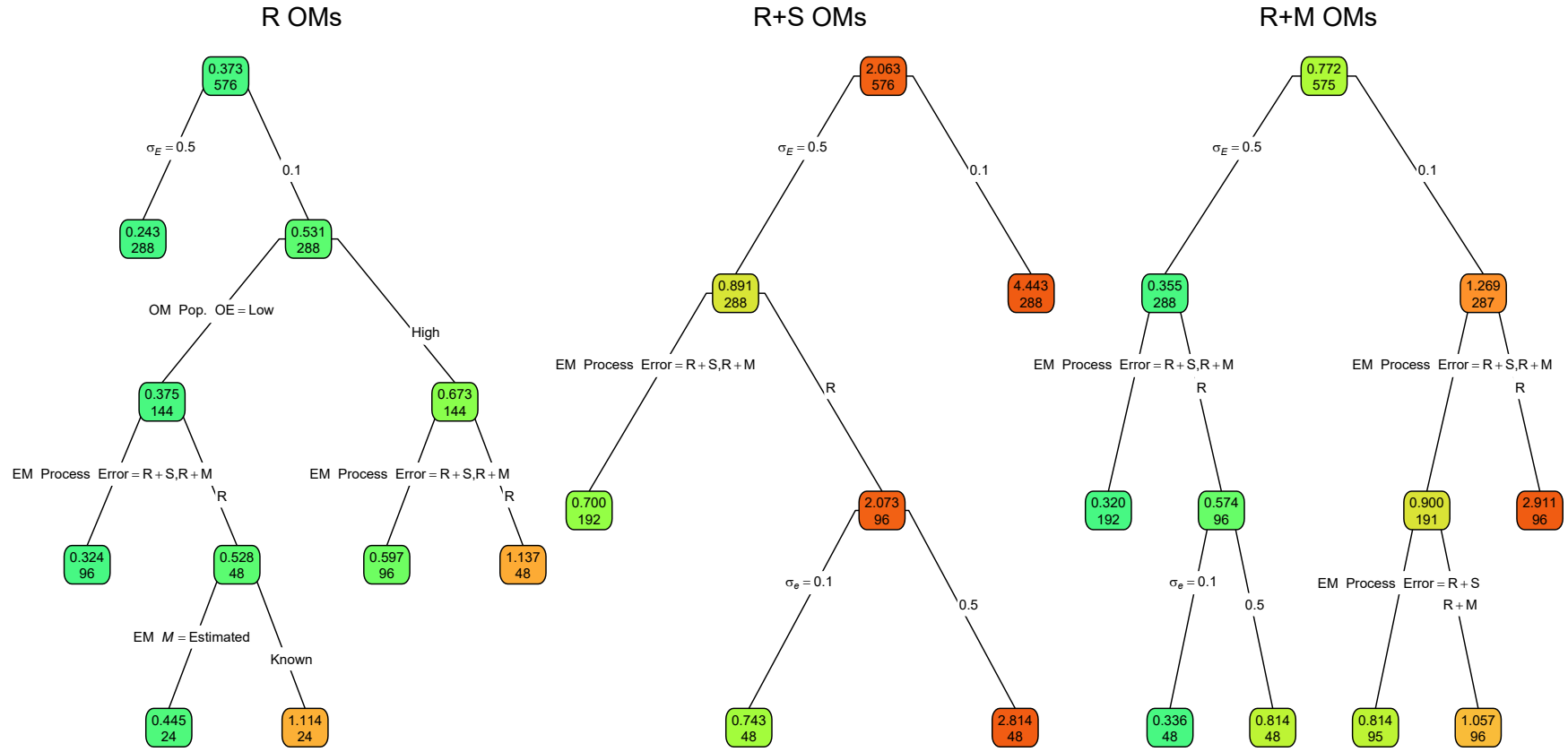


Fig. S25. Regression trees indicating primary factors determining reductions in sums of squares for the log-transformed RMSE of covariate effect on M ($\text{RMSE}(\hat{\beta}_E)$) for operating models (OMs) with process error on recruitment only (R), recruitment and apparent survival (R+S), or recruitment and natural mortality (R+M). Each node shows the median error (top) and number of observations (bottom) for the corresponding subset. Lower or higher median RMSE are indicated by more green or red polygons, respectively.

Table S9. Percent reduction in deviance for linear regression models fit to the log-transformed RMSE for estimates of the covariate effect on M ($\text{RMSE}(\hat{\beta}_E)$). Table rows give each operating model (OM) and estimating model (EM) factor included individually, combined, and with second and third order interactions. Table columns are operating models (OMs) with process error on recruitment only (R), recruitment and apparent survival (R+S), or recruitment and natural mortality (R+M).

Factor	R	R+S	R+M
OM F history	0.50	0.11	0.12
OM Obs. Error	12.04	5.66	0.36
$OM\sigma_e$	0.87	5.78	2.60
$OM\sigma_E$	15.85	24.18	24.26
$OM\rho_E$	0.36	0.82	0.34
OM β_E	6.72	0.07	0.96
EM Process Error	6.49	11.31	11.98
EM M assumption	0.04	0.64	0.07
All factors	42.87	48.58	40.65
+ All Two Way	67.34	74.09	61.74
+ All Three Way	79.42	82.75	71.92

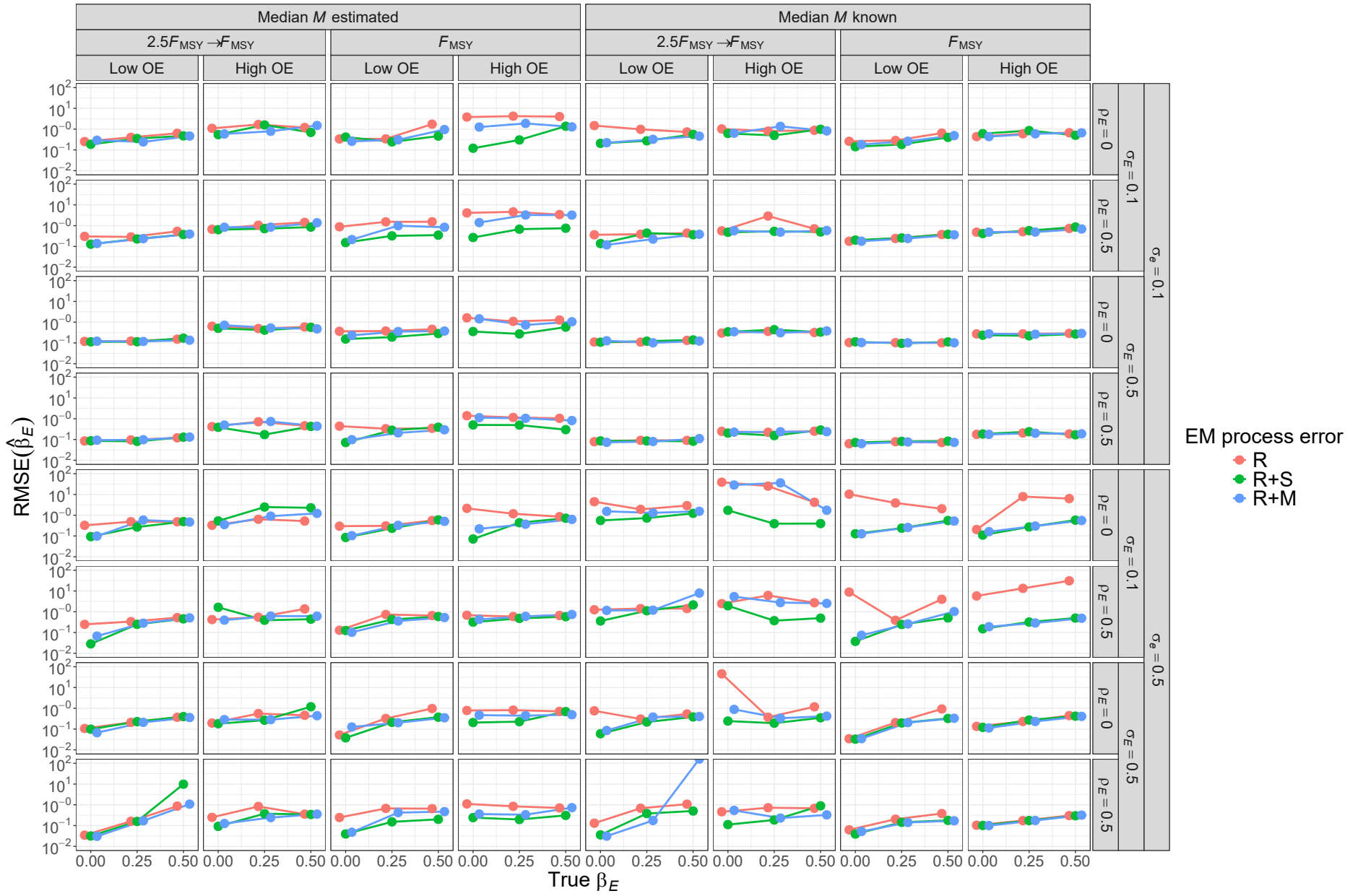


Fig. S26. For R OMs, RMSE of estimates of covariate effect on M (β_E) from fitting EMs with alternative process error assumptions and treatment of median M parameter (β_M).

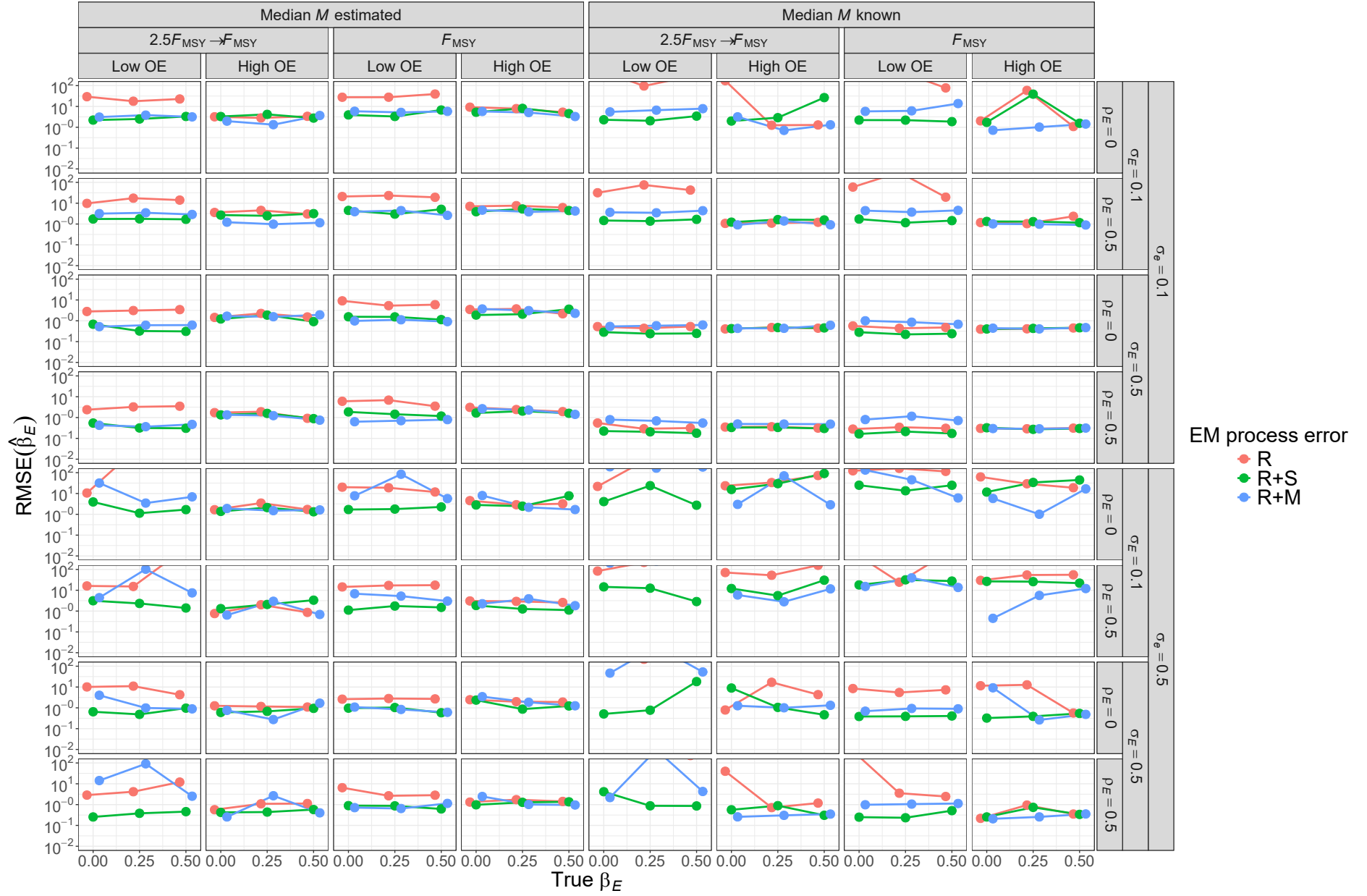


Fig. S27. For R+S OMs, RMSE of estimates of covariate effect on M (β_E) from fitting EMs with alternative process error assumptions and treatment of median M parameter (β_M).

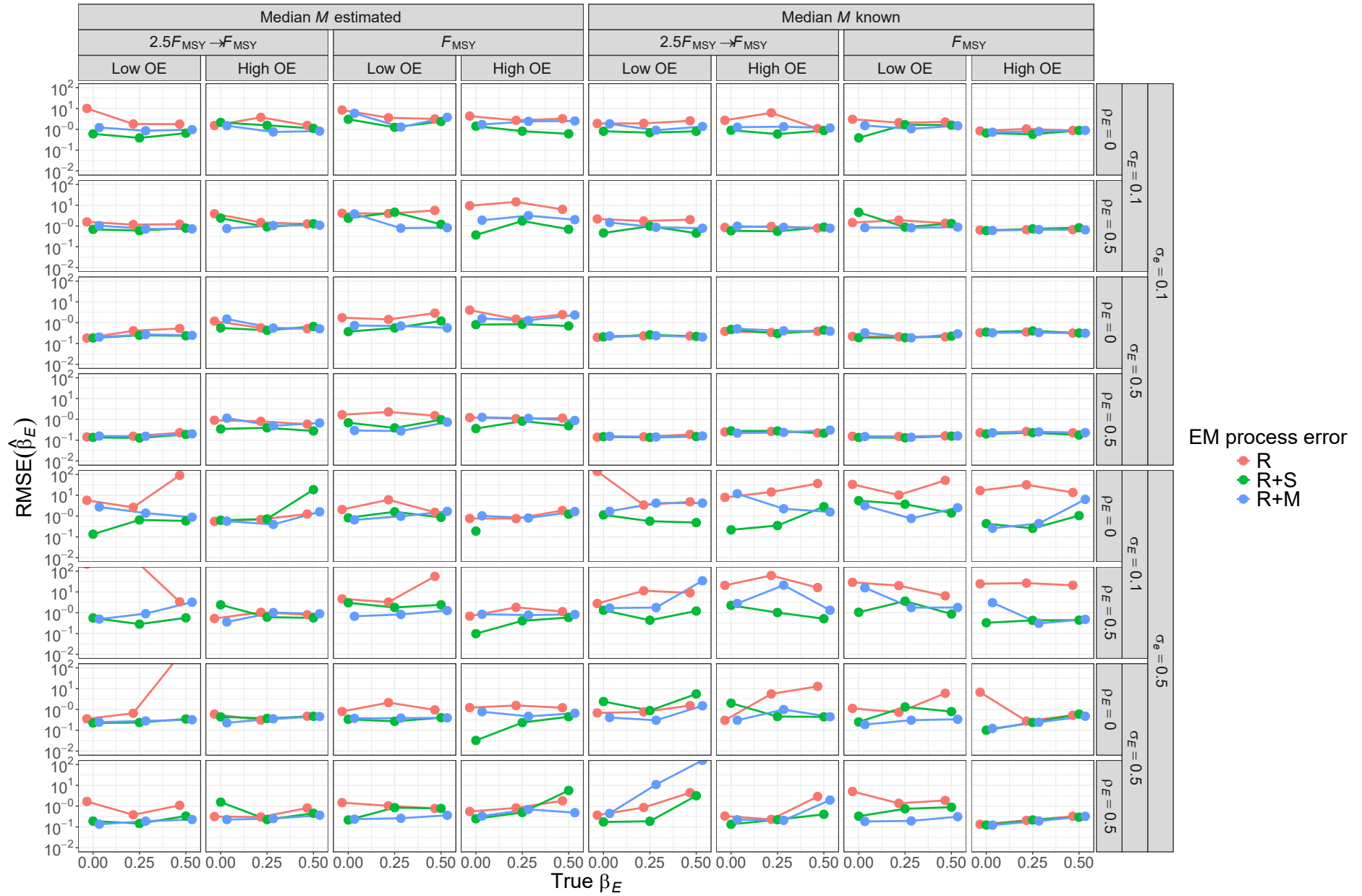


Fig. S28. For R+M OM, RMSE of estimates of covariate effect on M (β_E) from fitting EMs with alternative process error assumptions and treatment of median M parameter (β_M).

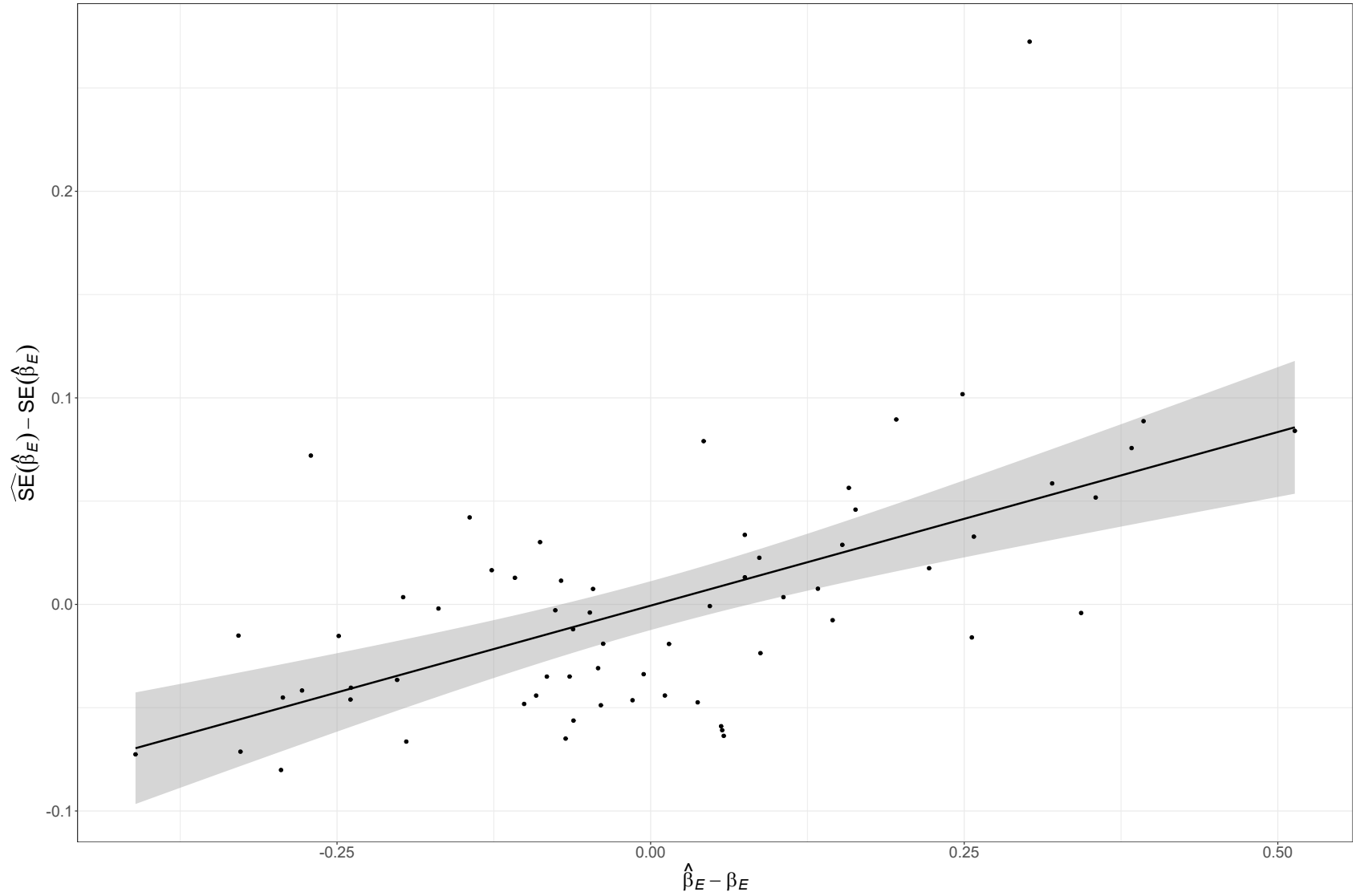


Fig. S29. Positive correlation of covariate effect estimates and Hessian-based standard error estimates for EM that also estimates the median M parameter (β_M) and has correct R+M process error assumption fitted to simulated data from the OM with R+M process errors, temporal contrast in fishing pressure, low observation uncertainty for both population (*LowOE*) and covariate observations ($\sigma_e = 0.1$), high and uncorrelated temporal variability in the true covariate ($\sigma_E = 0.5$ and $\rho_E = 0$), and the strongest covariate effect on M ($\beta_E = 0.5$).

Table S10. Percent reduction in deviance for linear regression models fit to errors in estimation of the median M parameter (β_M). Table rows give each operating model (OM) and estimating model (EM) factor included individually, combined, and with second and third order interactions. Table columns are operating models (OMs) with process error on recruitment only (R), recruitment and apparent survival (R+S), or recruitment and natural mortality (R+M).

Factor	R	R+S	R+M
OM F history	<0.01	<0.01	<0.01
OM Obs. Error	<0.01	<0.01	<0.01
OM σ_e	<0.01	<0.01	<0.01
OM σ_E	<0.01	<0.01	<0.01
OM ρ_E	<0.01	<0.01	<0.01
OM β_E	<0.01	<0.01	0.01
EM Convergence	<0.01	0.01	0.01
EM Process Error	<0.01	0.01	0.01
EM β_E assumption	<0.01	<0.01	<0.01
All factors	0.02	0.02	0.05
+ All Two Way	0.15	0.15	0.24
+ All Three Way	0.57	0.54	0.73

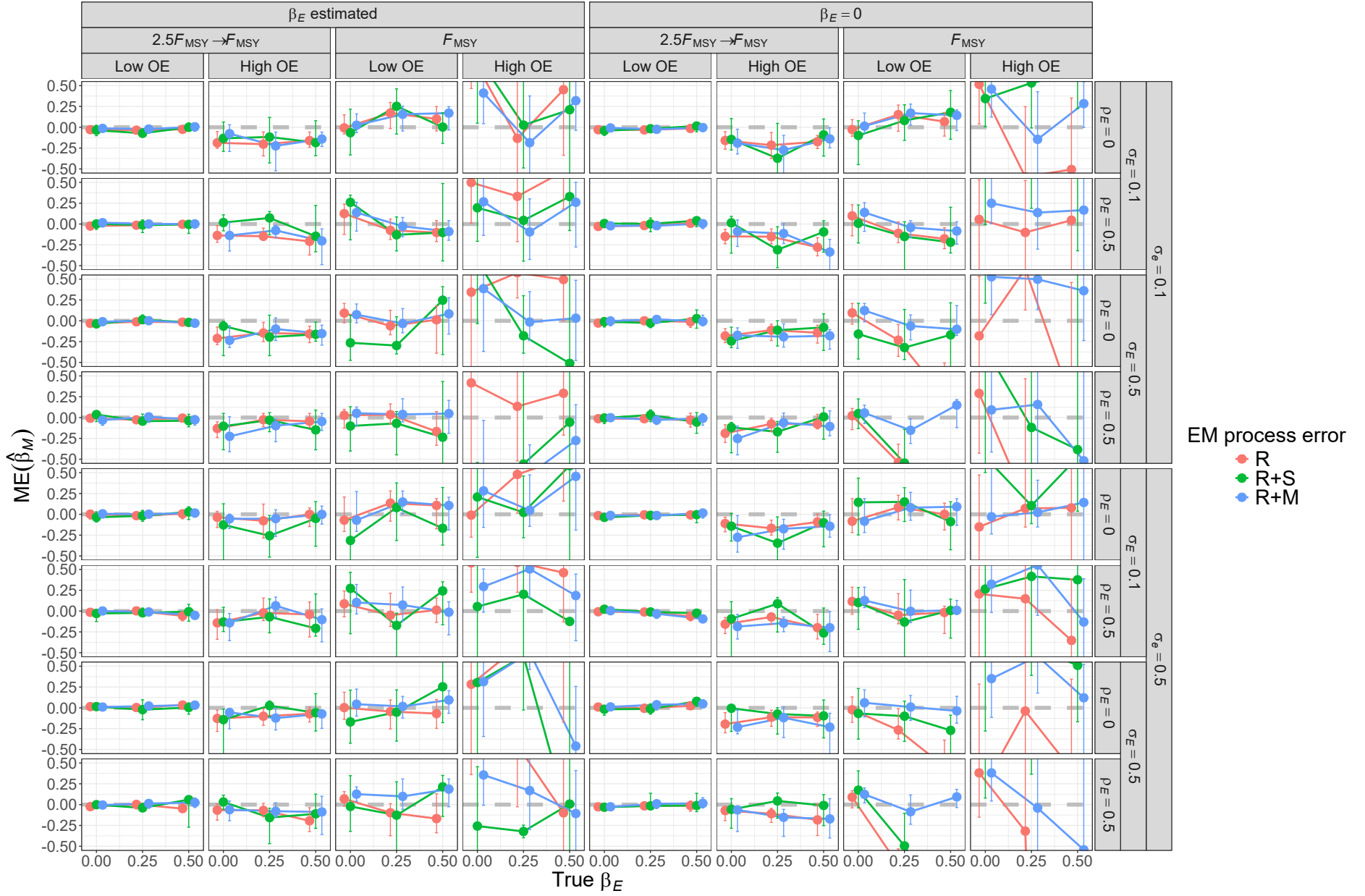


Fig. S30. For R OMs, median error (ME) of estimates of β_M from fitting EMs with alternative process error assumptions and treatment of covariate effect ($\beta_E = 0$ or estimated). Vertical lines represent 95% confidence intervals.

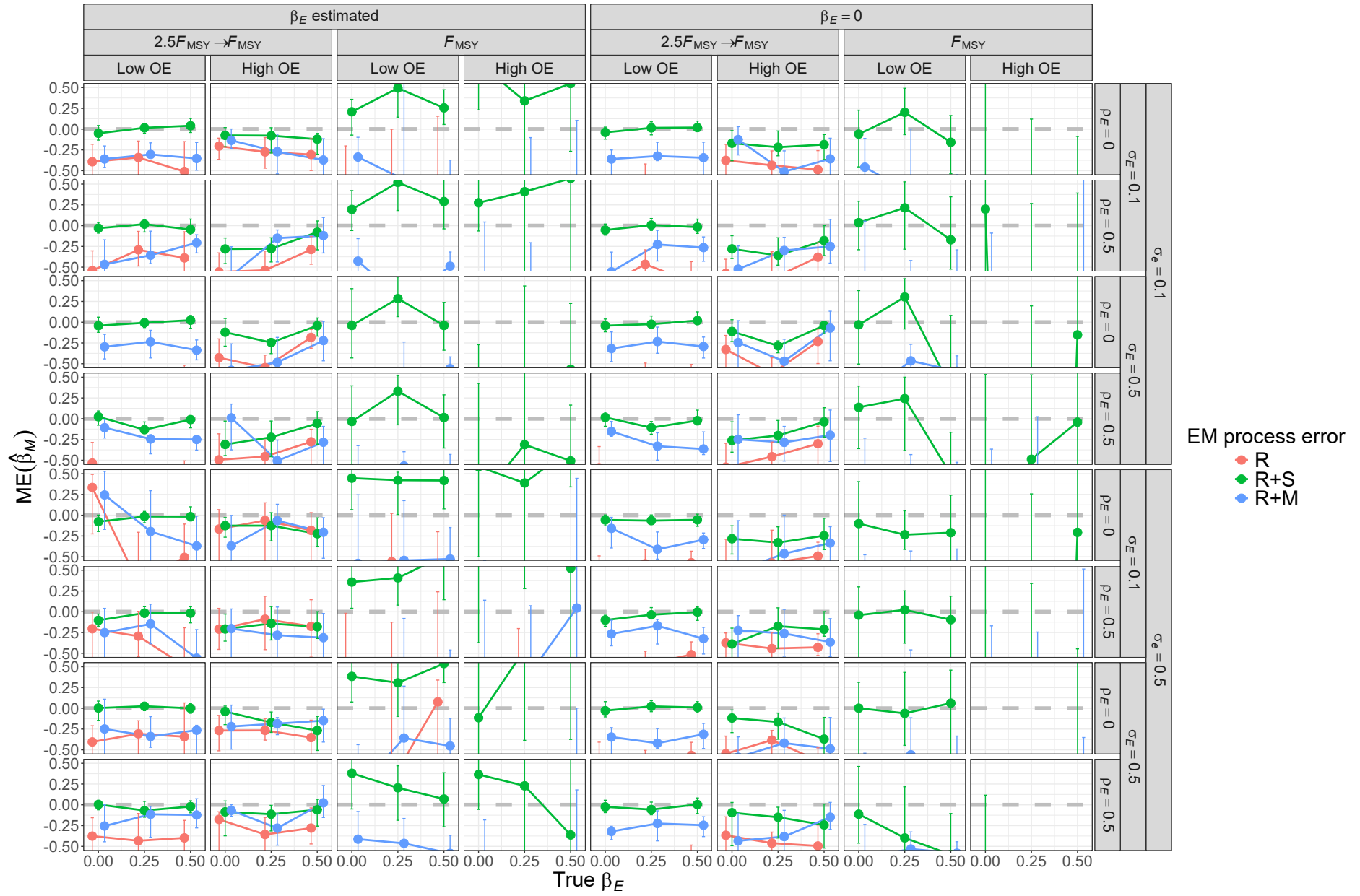


Fig. S31. For R+S OMs, median error (ME) of estimates of β_M from fitting EMs with alternative process error assumptions and treatment of covariate effect ($\beta_E = 0$ or estimated). Vertical lines represent 95% confidence intervals.

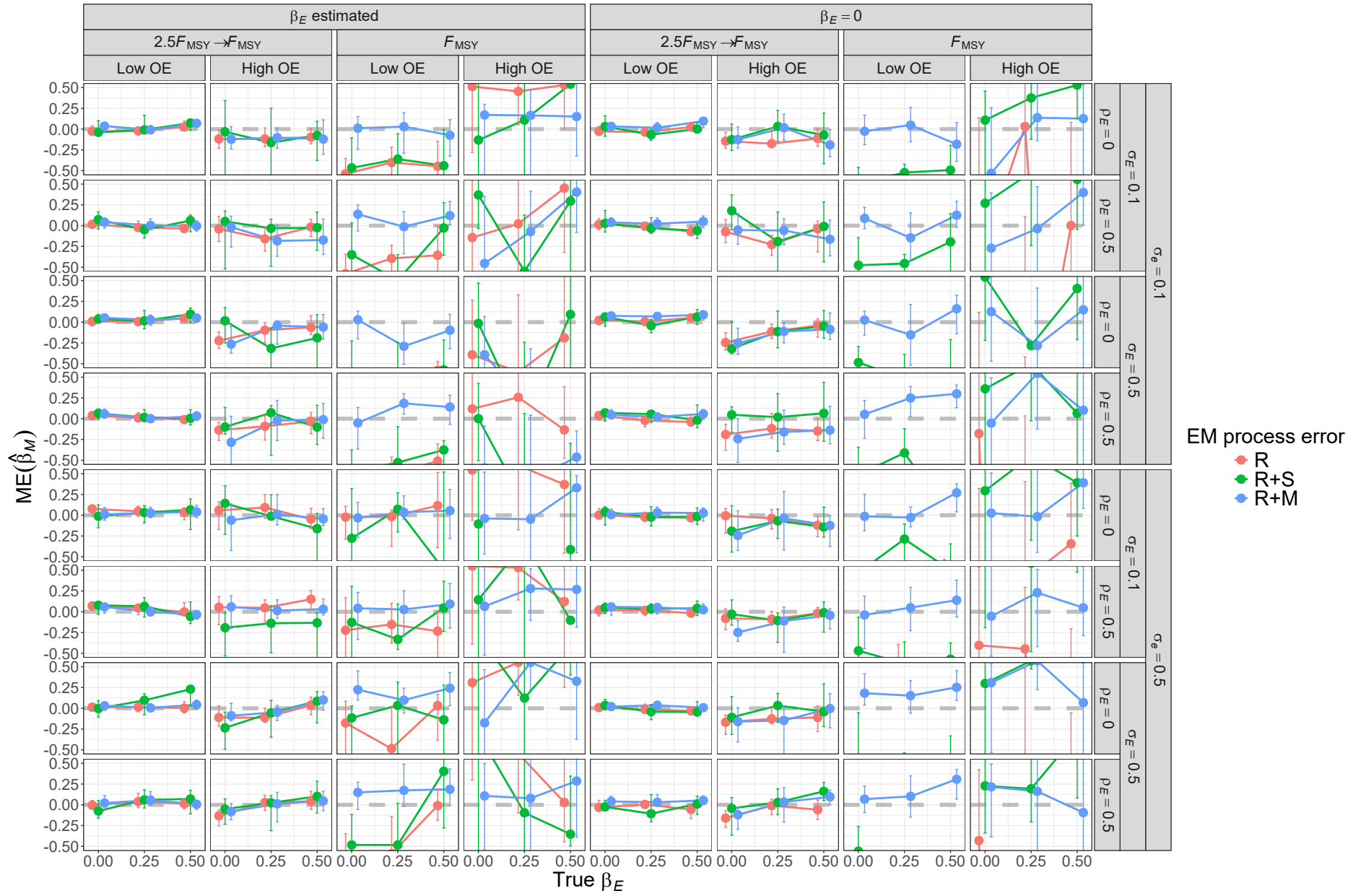


Fig. S32. For R+M OMs, median error (ME) of estimates of β_M from fitting EMs with alternative process error assumptions and treatment of covariate effect ($\beta_E = 0$ or estimated). Vertical lines represent 95% confidence intervals.

898 **Median natural mortality parameter standard error estimation bias**

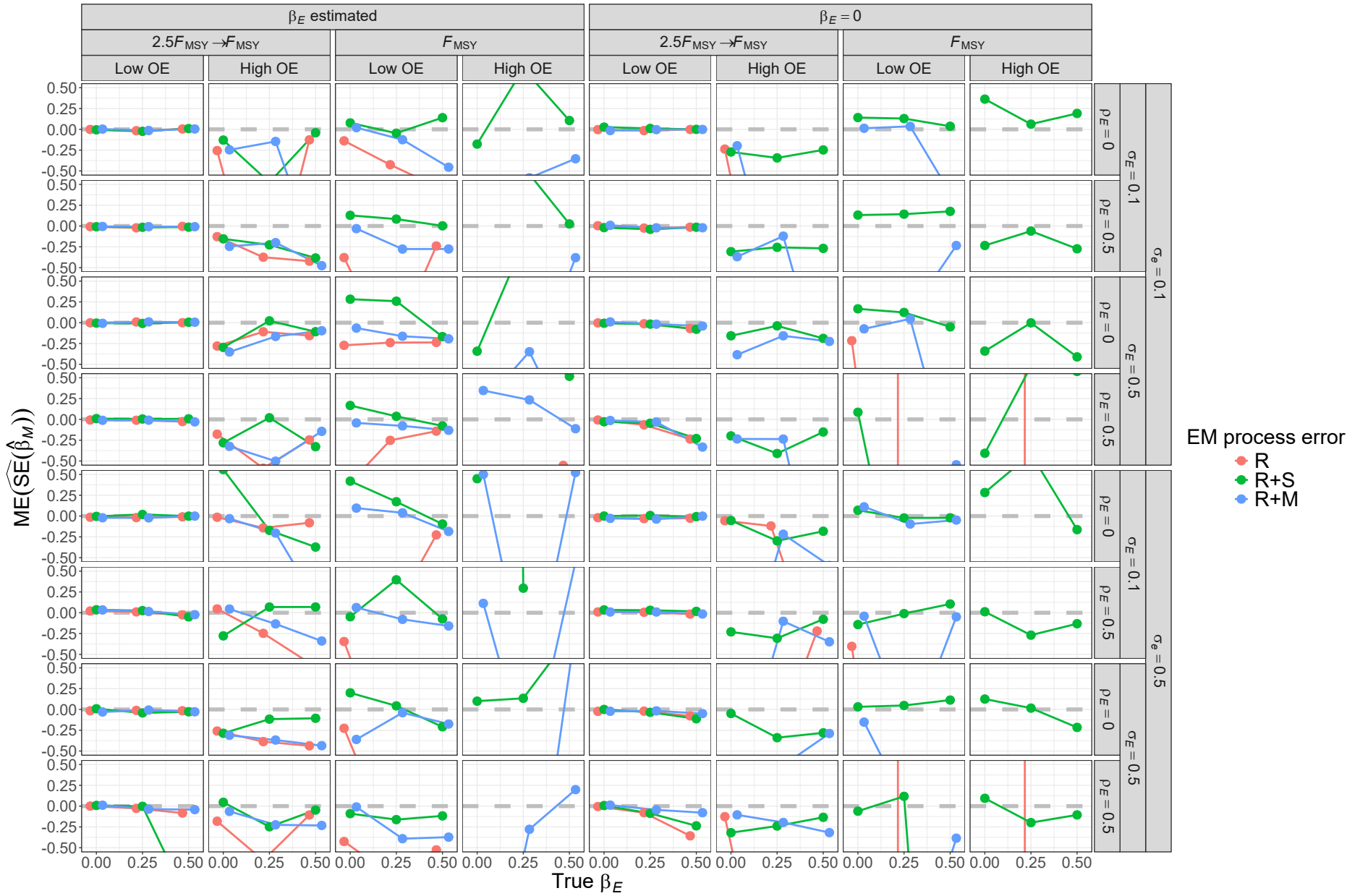


Fig. S33. For R OMs, median error (ME) of Hessian-based estimates of standard error for median M parameter (β_M) from fitting EMs with alternative process error assumptions and treatment of the covariate effect ($\beta_E = 0$ or estimated). True standard error is defined as the mean of the standard error estimates across converged fits to simulated data sets for a given OM scenario.

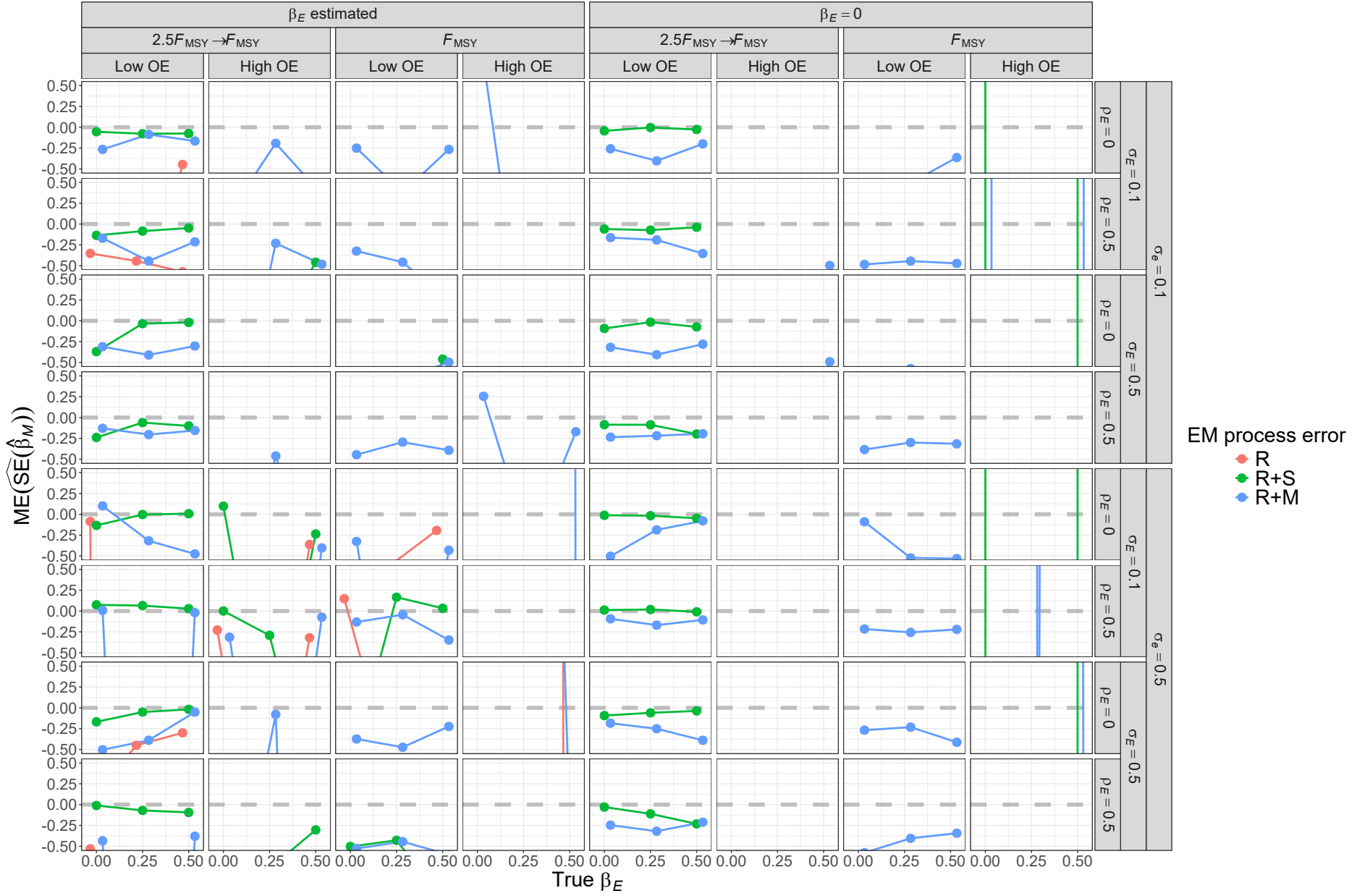


Fig. S34. For R+S OMs, median error (ME) of Hessian-based estimates of standard error for median M parameter (β_M) from fitting EMs with alternative process error assumptions and treatment of the covariate effect ($\beta_E = 0$ or estimated). True standard error is defined as the mean of the standard error estimates across converged fits to simulated data sets for a given OM scenario.

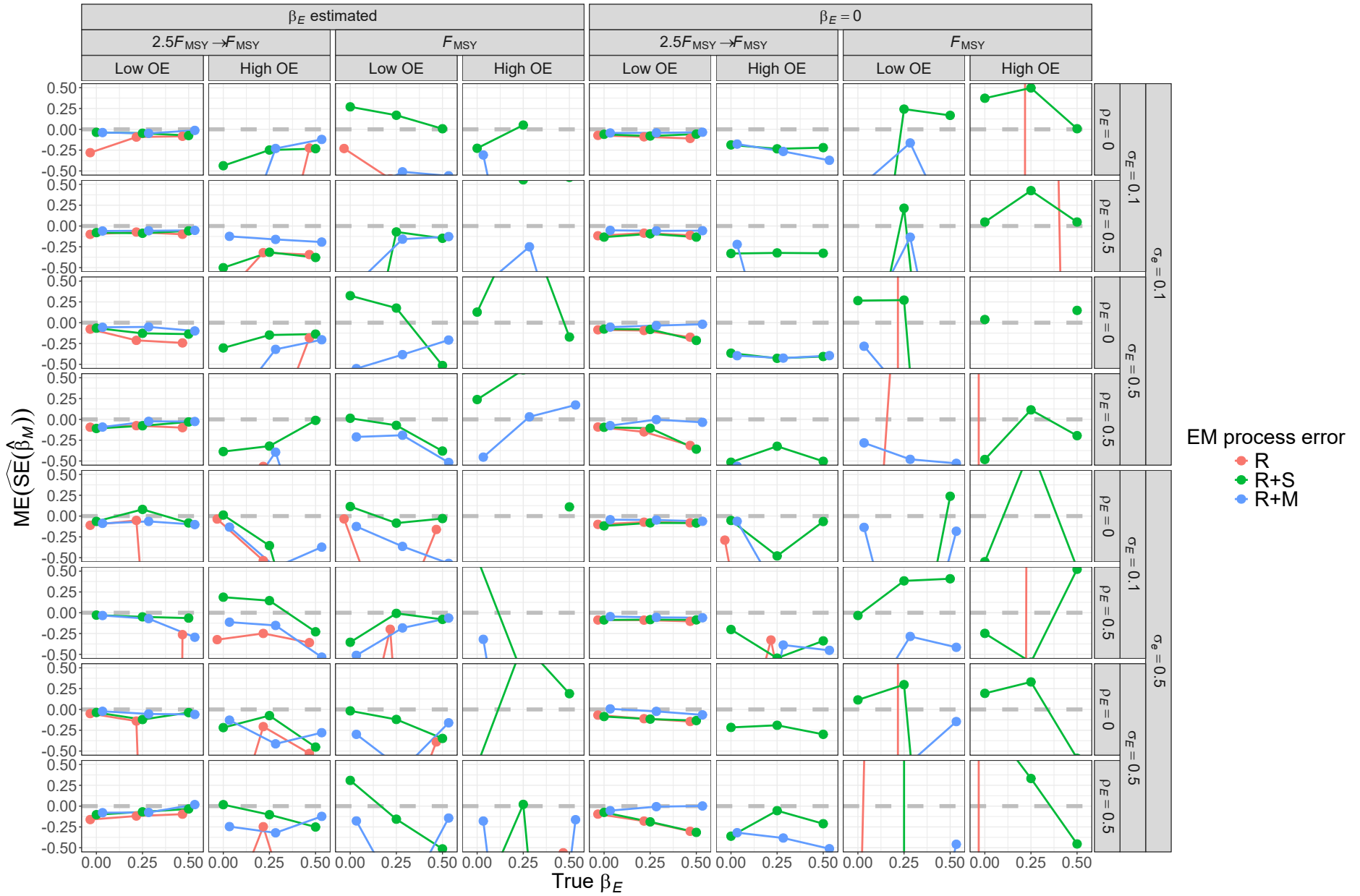


Fig. S35. For R+M OMs, median error (ME) of Hessian-based estimates of standard error for median M parameter ($\hat{\beta}_M$) from fitting EMs with alternative process error assumptions and treatment of the covariate effect ($\beta_E = 0$ or estimated). True standard error is defined as the mean of the standard error estimates across converged fits to simulated data sets for a given OM scenario.

899 **Median Natural mortality parameter confidence interval coverage**

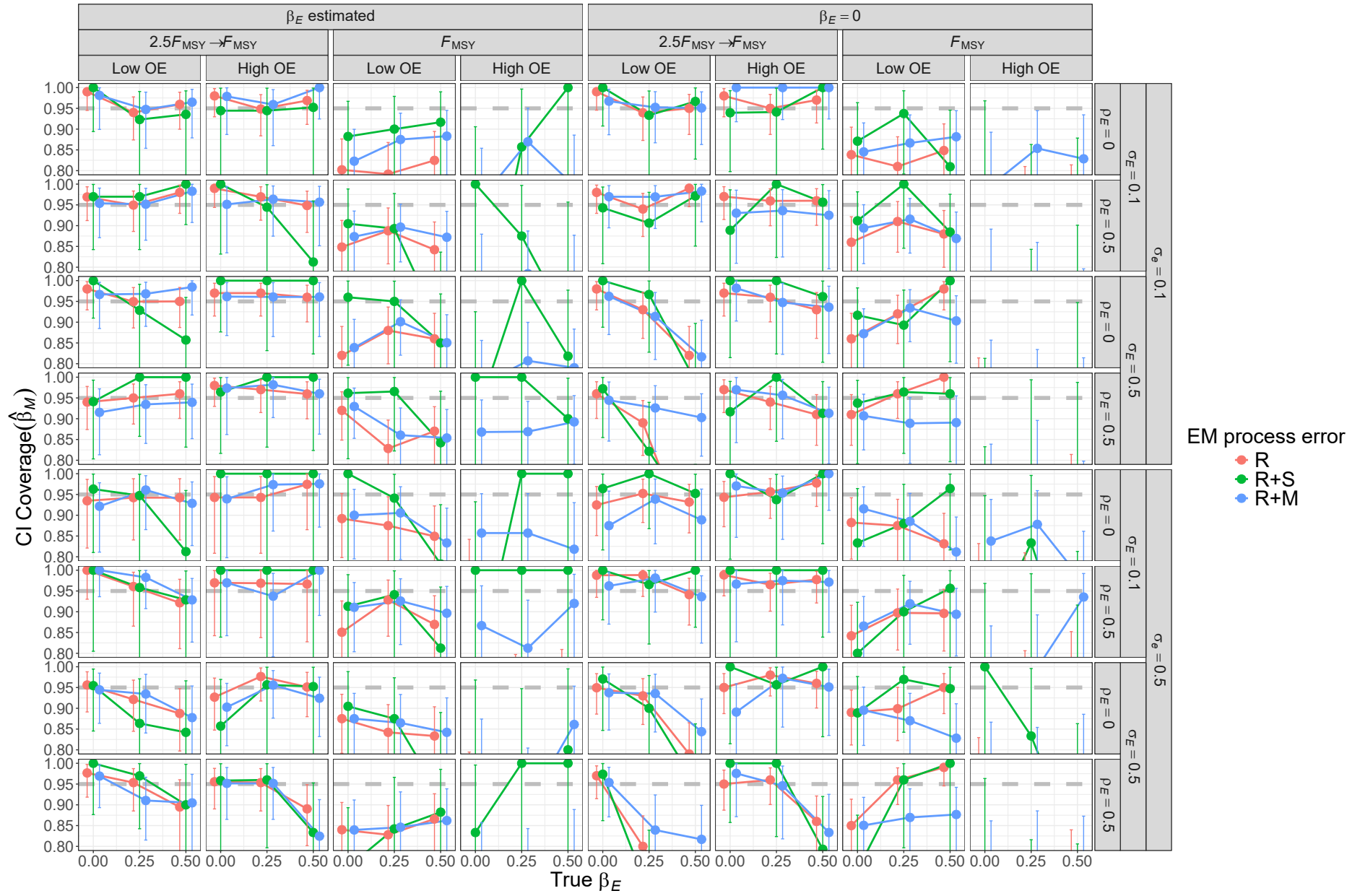


Fig. S36. For R OMs, probability of 95% confidence interval for β_M containing the true value for EMs with alternative process error assumptions and treatment of covariate effect ($\beta_E = 0$ or estimated). Vertical lines represent 95% confidence intervals.

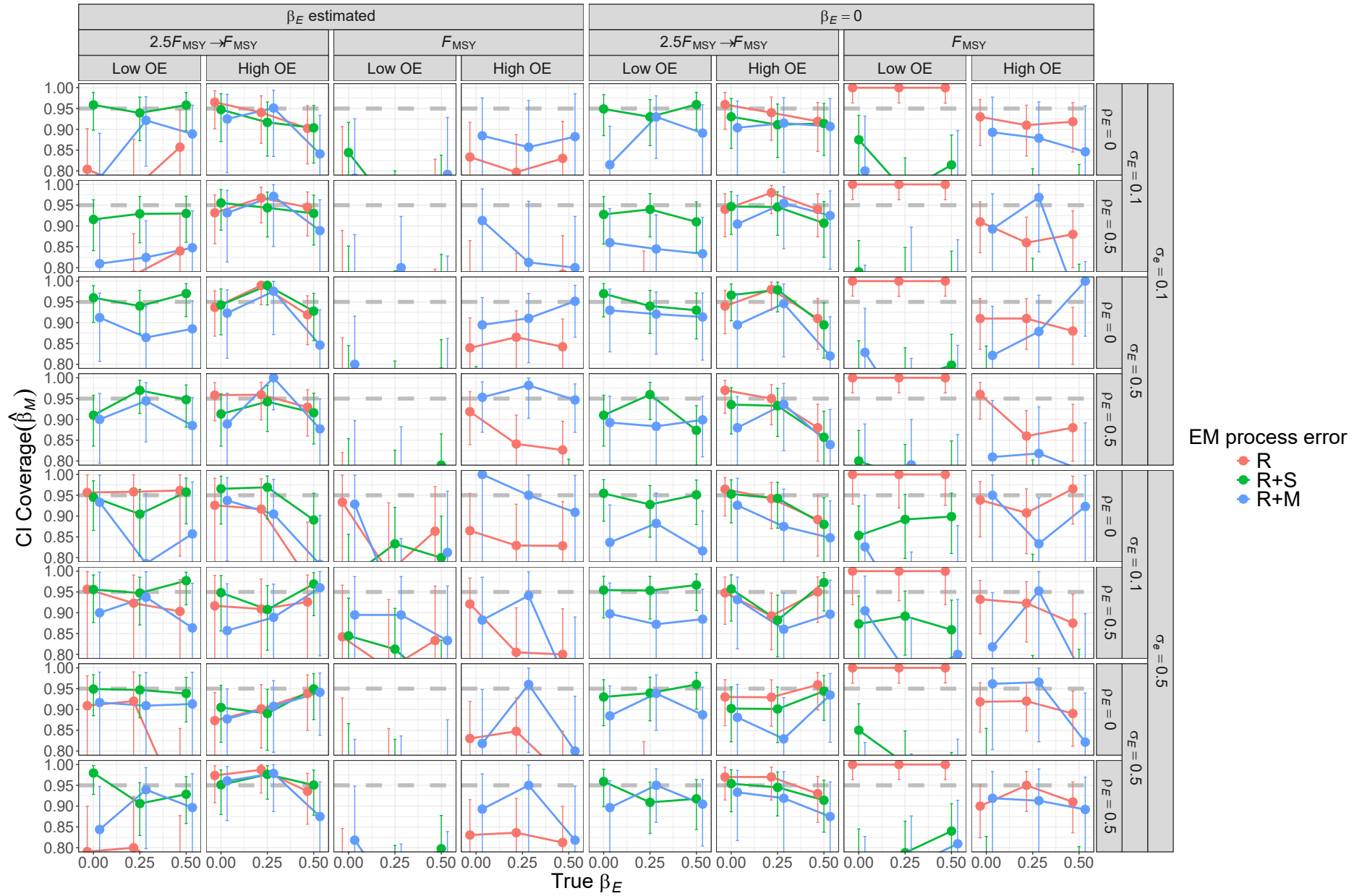


Fig. S37. For R+S OMs, probability of 95% confidence interval for β_M containing the true value for EMs with alternative process error assumptions and treatment of covariate effect ($\beta_E = 0$ or estimated). Vertical lines represent 95% confidence intervals.

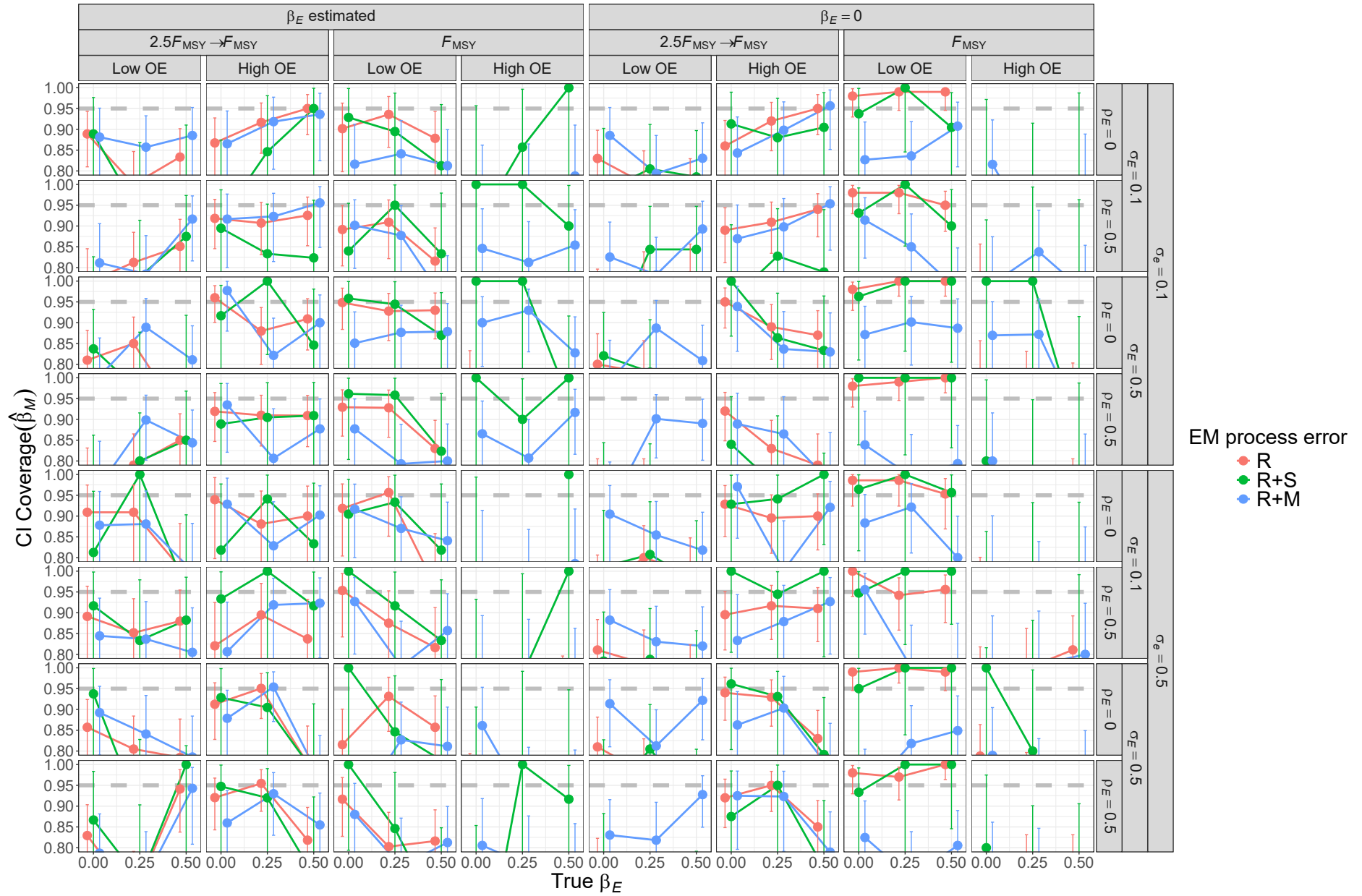


Fig. S38. For R+M OMs, probability of 95% confidence interval for β_M containing the true value for EMs with alternative process error assumptions and treatment of covariate effect ($\beta_E = 0$ or estimated). Vertical lines represent 95% confidence intervals.

900 Median natural mortality parameter estimate and standard error
901 example

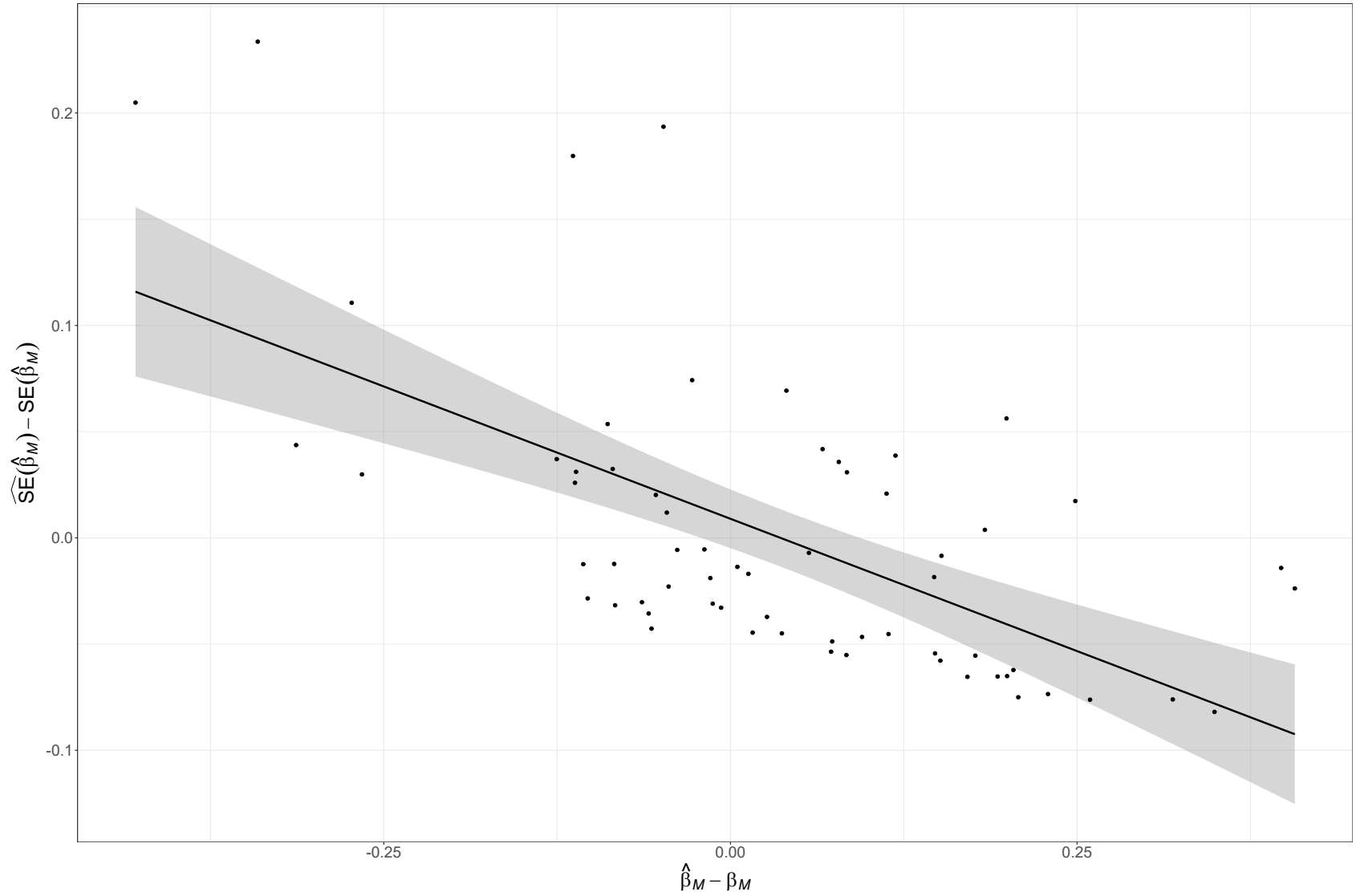


Fig. S39. Negative correlation of β_M estimates and Hessian-based standard error estimates for EM that also estimates the covariate effect and has correct R+M process error assumption fitted to simulated data from the OM with R+M process errors, temporal contrast in fishing pressure, low observation uncertainty for both population (*LowOE*) and covariate observations ($\sigma_e = 0.1$), high and uncorrelated temporal variability in the true covariate ($\sigma_E = 0.5$ and $\rho_E = 0$), and the strongest covariate effect on M ($\beta_E = 0.5$).

902 **Median Natural mortality parameter accuracy**

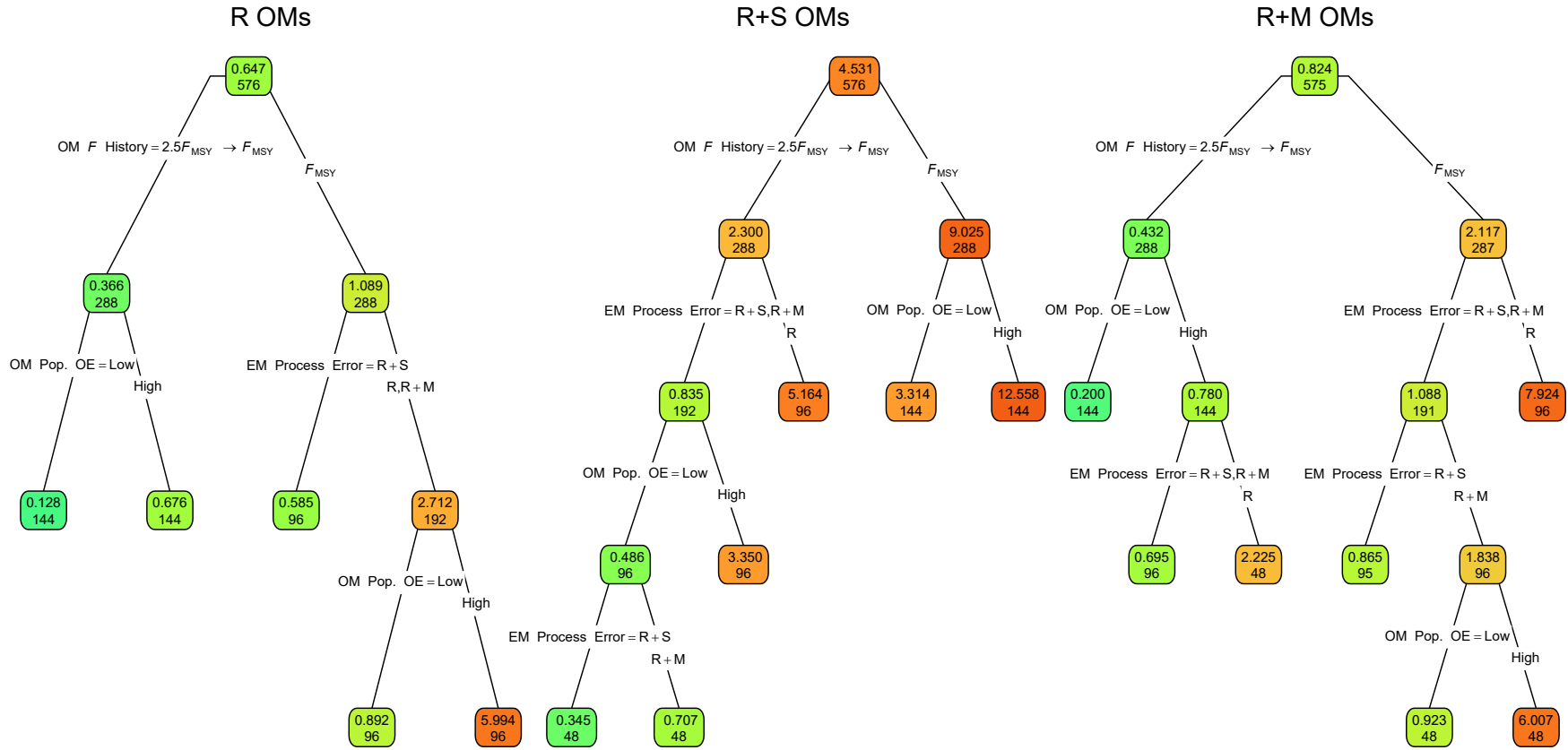


Fig. S40. Regression trees indicating primary factors determining reductions in sums of squares of errors for the log-transformed RMSE of estimates for the median M parameter ($\widehat{\beta}_M$) in EMs fitted to operating models (OMs) with process error on recruitment only (R), recruitment and apparent survival (R+S), or recruitment and natural mortality (R+M). Each node shows the median error (top) and number of observations (bottom) for the corresponding subset. Lower or higher median RMSE are indicated by more green or red polygons, respectively.

Table S11. Percent reduction in deviance for linear regression models fit to the log-transformed RMSE for estimates of the median M parameter ($\text{RMSE}(\hat{\beta}_M)$). Table rows give each operating model (OM) and estimating model (EM) factor included individually, combined, and with second and third order interactions. Table columns are operating models (OMs) with process error on recruitment only (R), recruitment and apparent survival (R+S), or recruitment and natural mortality (R+M).

Factor	R	R+S	R+M
OM F history	34.70	24.62	34.91
OM Obs. Error	25.55	17.82	12.77
$OM\sigma_e$	0.01	<0.01	<0.01
$OM\sigma_E$	0.19	0.02	0.07
$OM\rho_E$	0.05	0.26	0.03
OM β_E	0.58	0.23	0.16
EM Process Error	10.75	18.12	14.50
$EM\beta_E$ assumption	3.96	6.39	2.93
All factors	75.79	67.47	65.26
+ All Two Way	90.21	80.65	77.59
+ All Three Way	93.72	88.68	86.44

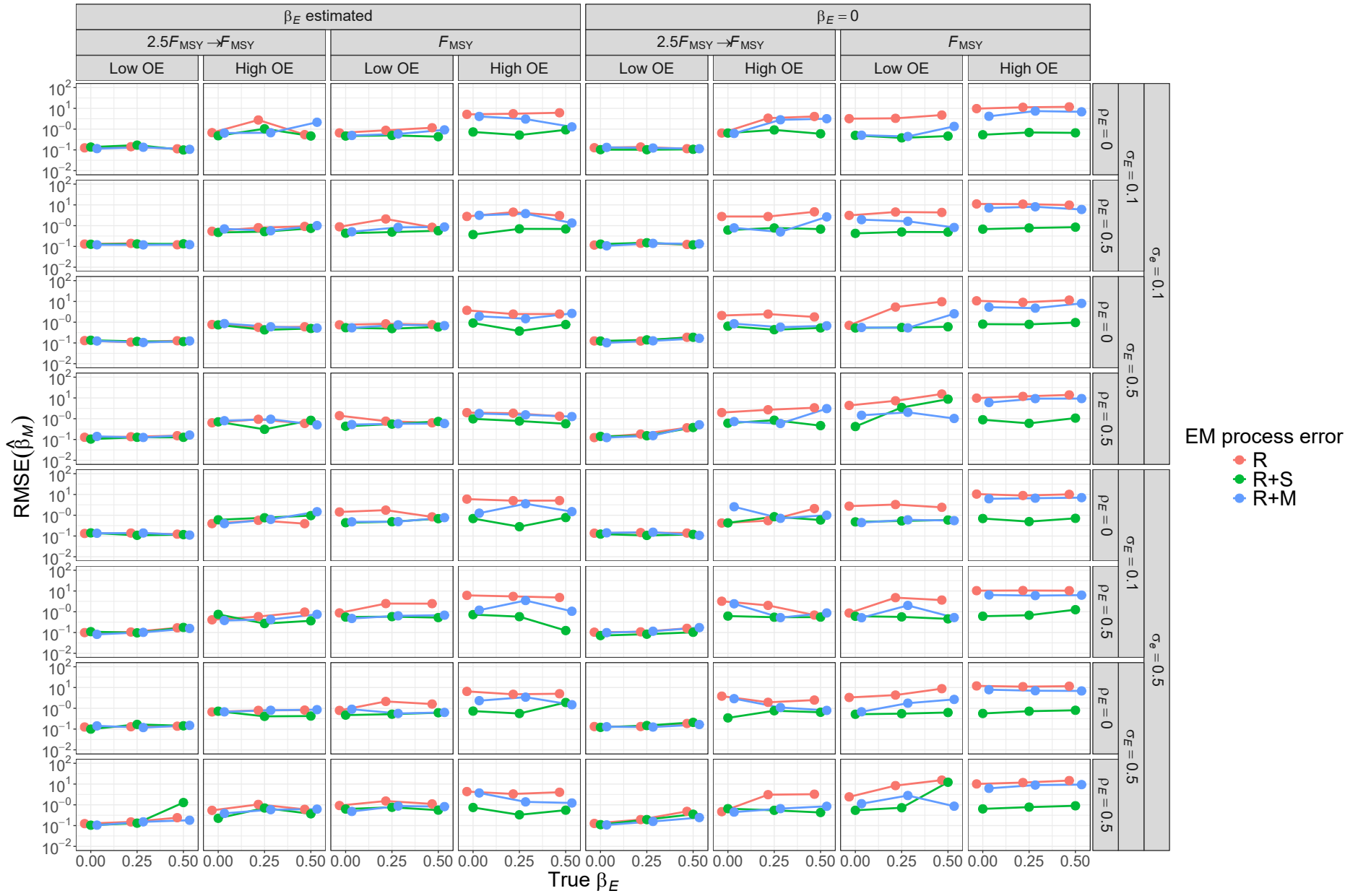


Fig. S41. For R OMs, RMSE of estimates of β_M from fitting EMs with alternative process error assumptions and treatment of covariate effect ($\beta_E = 0$ or estimated).

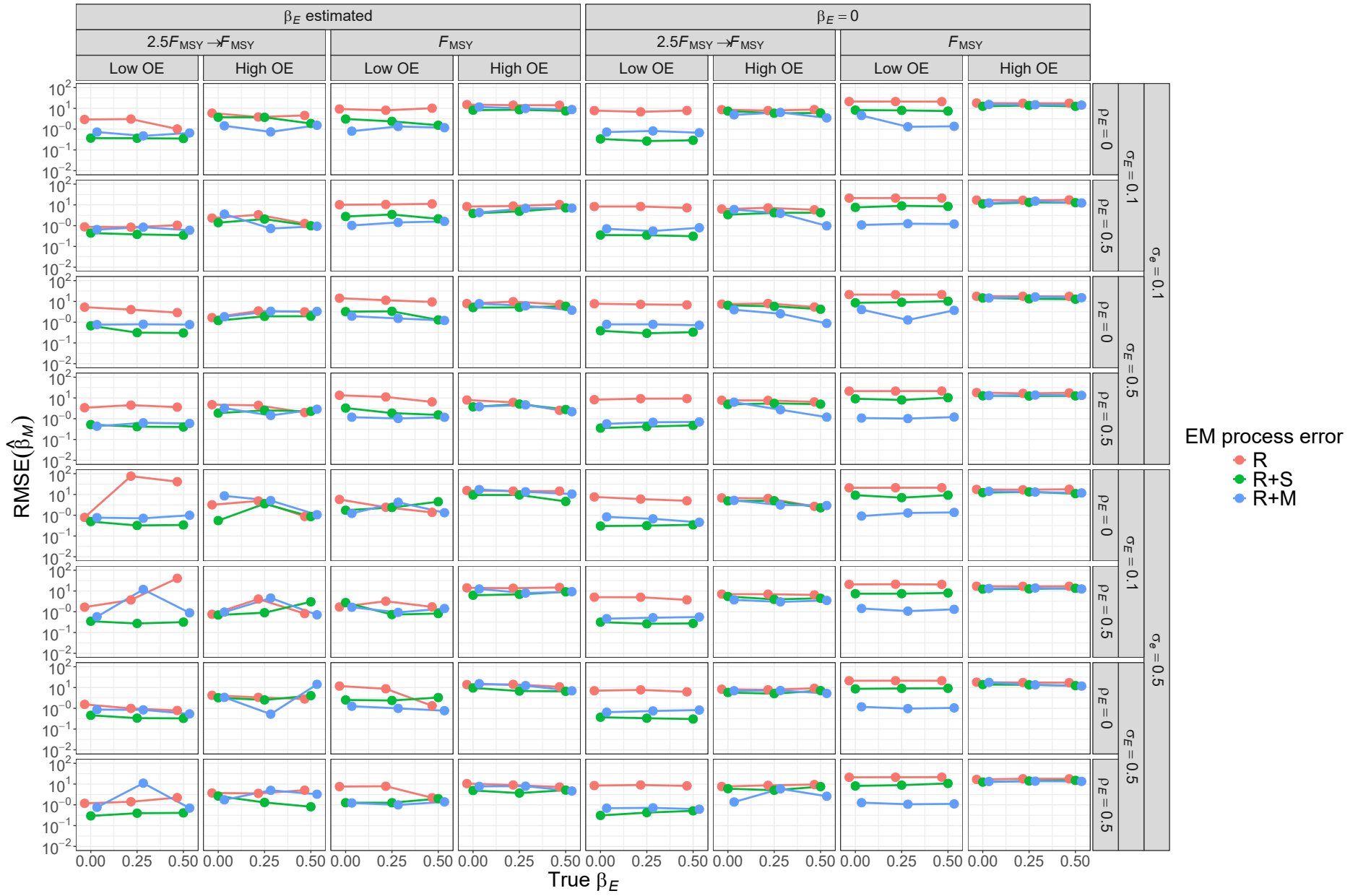


Fig. S42. For R+S OMs, RMSE of estimates of β_M from fitting EMs with alternative process error assumptions and treatment of covariate effect ($\beta_E = 0$ or estimated).

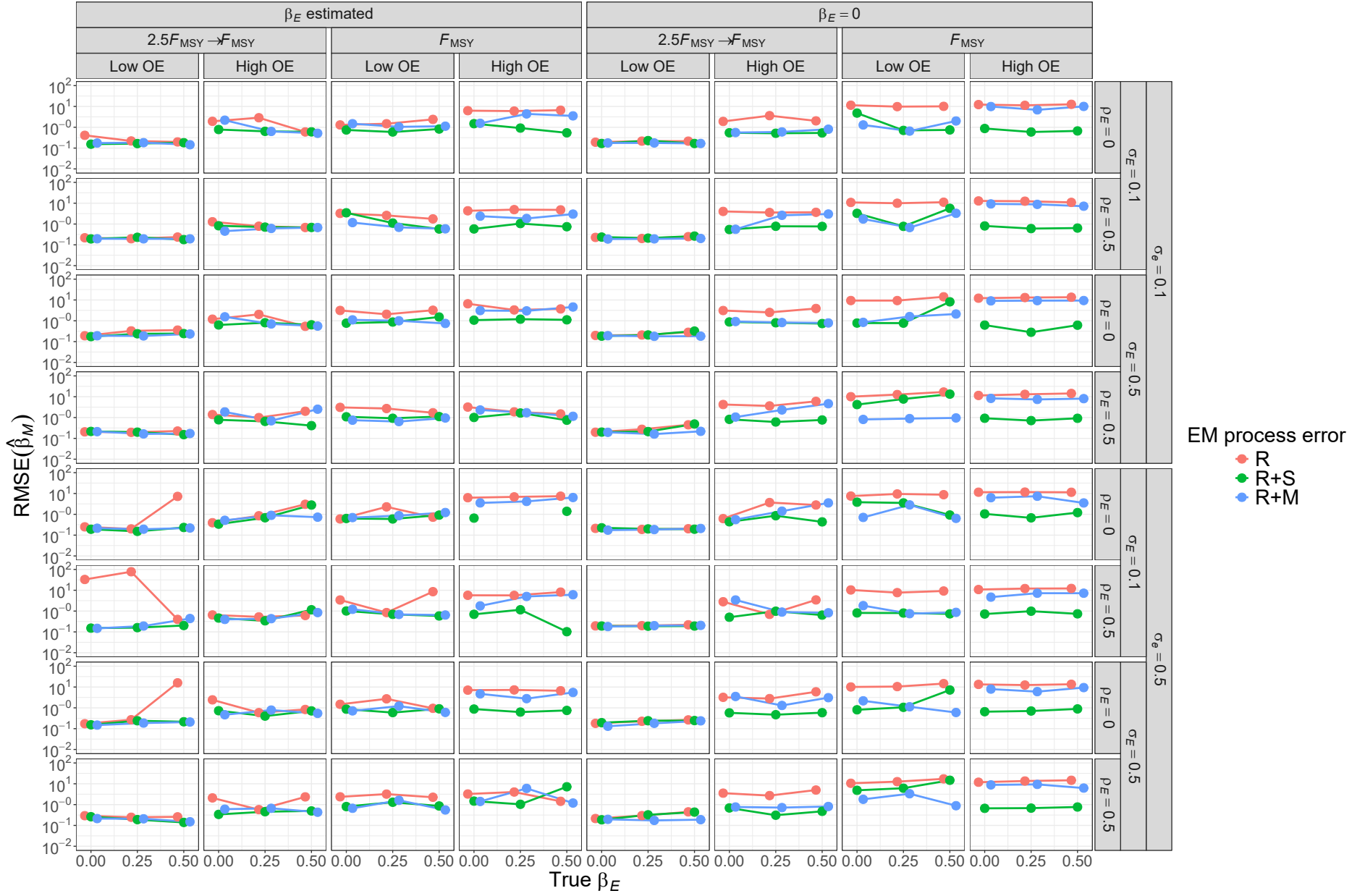


Fig. S43. For R+M OMs, RMSE of estimates of β_M from fitting EMs with alternative process error assumptions and treatment of covariate effect ($\beta_E = 0$ or estimated).

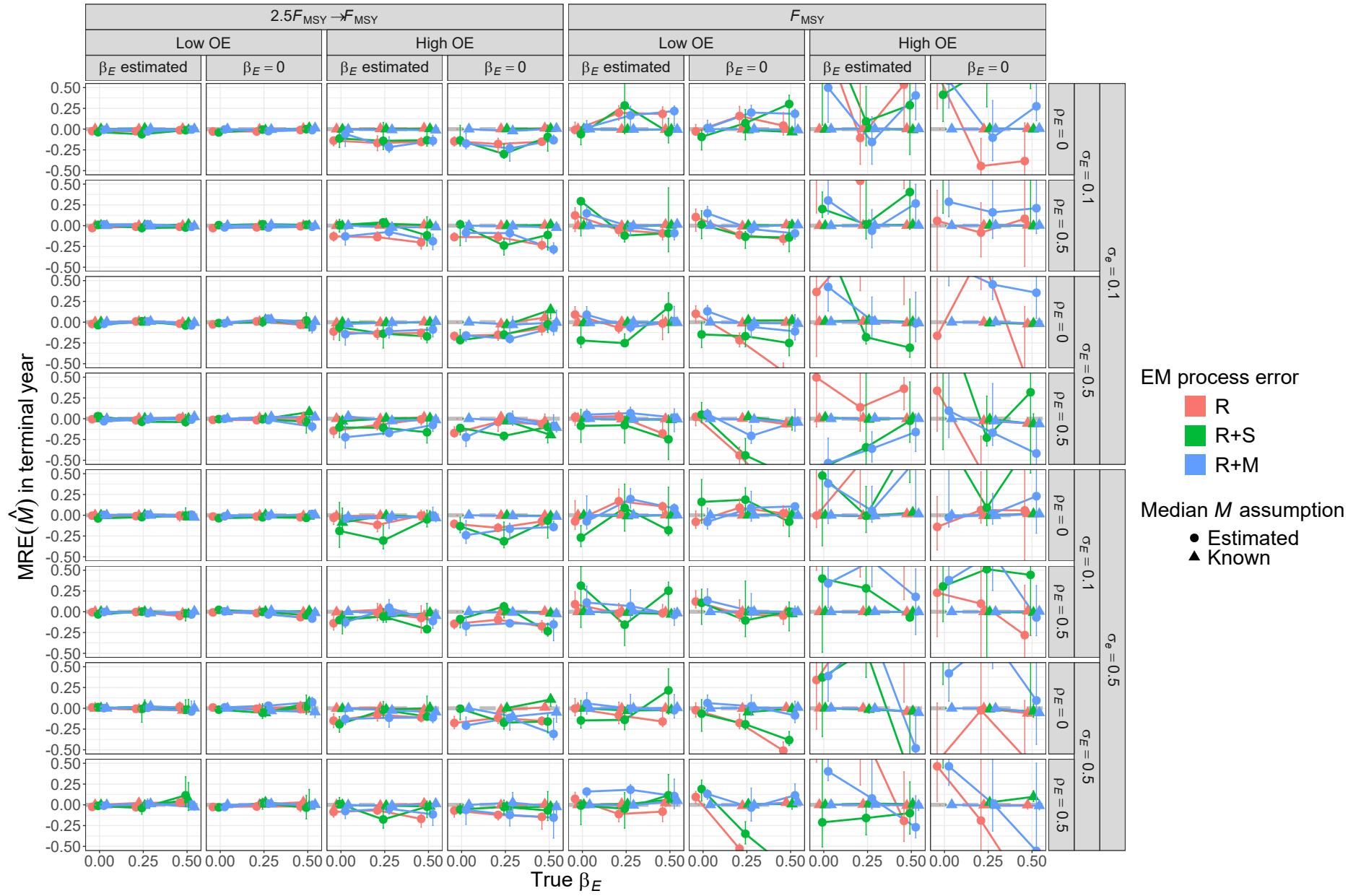


Fig. S44. For R OMs, median relative error (MRE) of estimates of terminal year M for EMs with alternative process error assumptions, treatment of covariate effect ($\beta_E = 0$ or estimated), and treatment of median M parameter (β_M estimated or known).

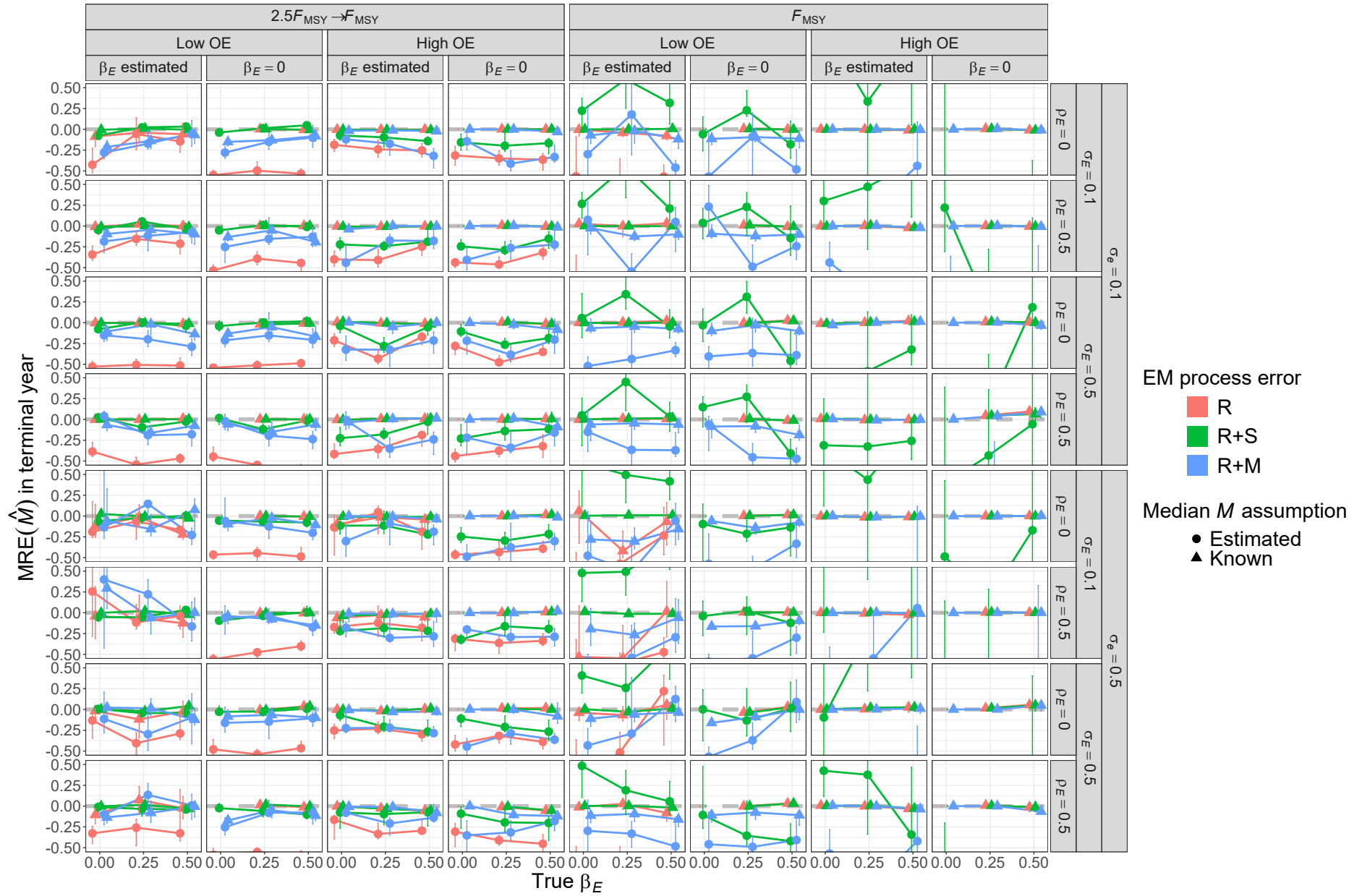


Fig. S45. For R+S OMs, median relative error (MRE) of estimates of terminal year M for EMs with alternative process error assumptions, treatment of covariate effect ($\beta_E = 0$ or estimated), and treatment of median M parameter (β_M estimated or known).

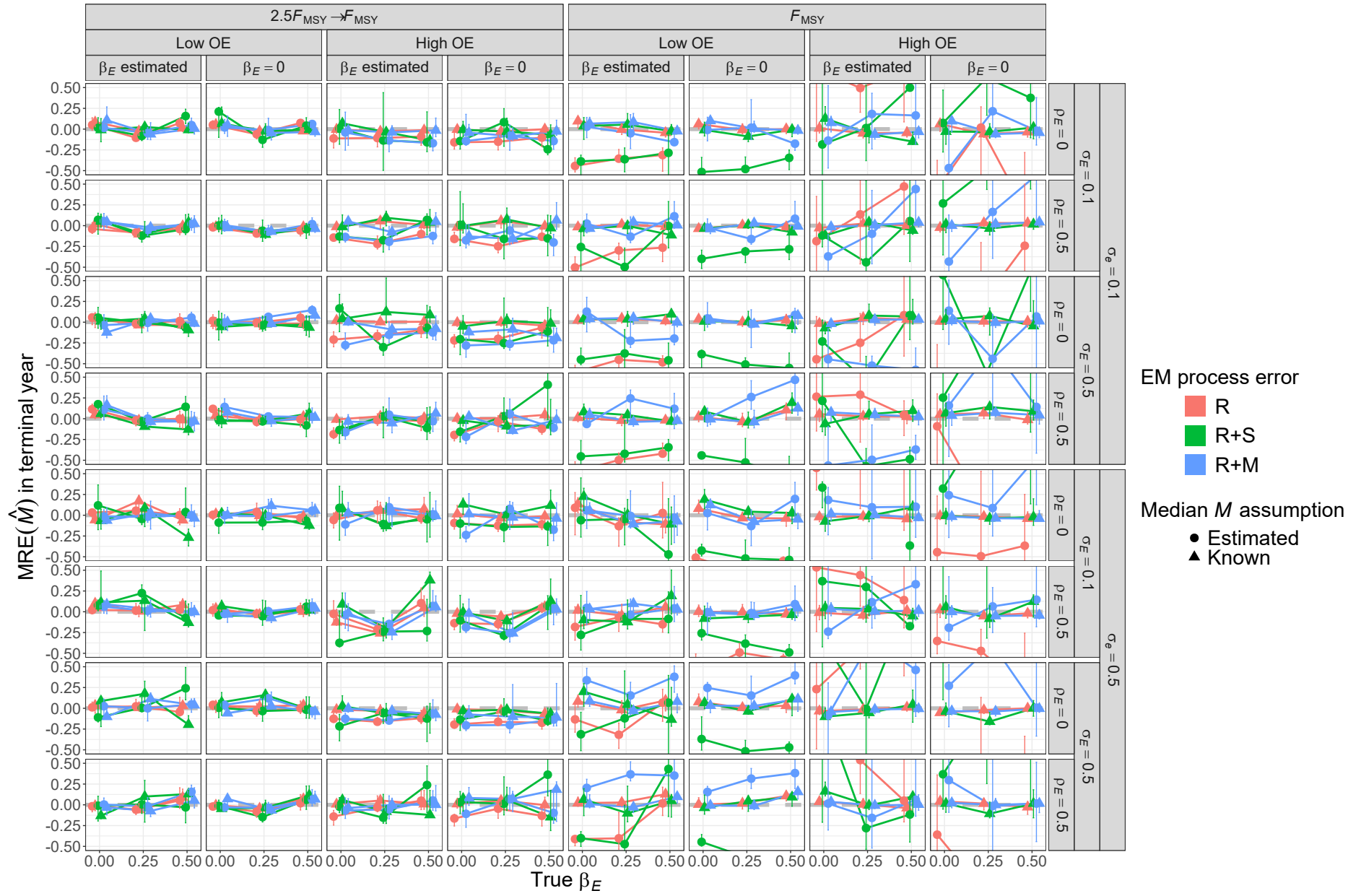


Fig. S46. For R+M OM, median relative error (MRE) of estimates of terminal year M for EMs with alternative process error assumptions, treatment of covariate effect ($\beta_E = 0$ or estimated), and treatment of median M parameter (β_M estimated or known).

904 **Terminal year natural mortality accuracy**

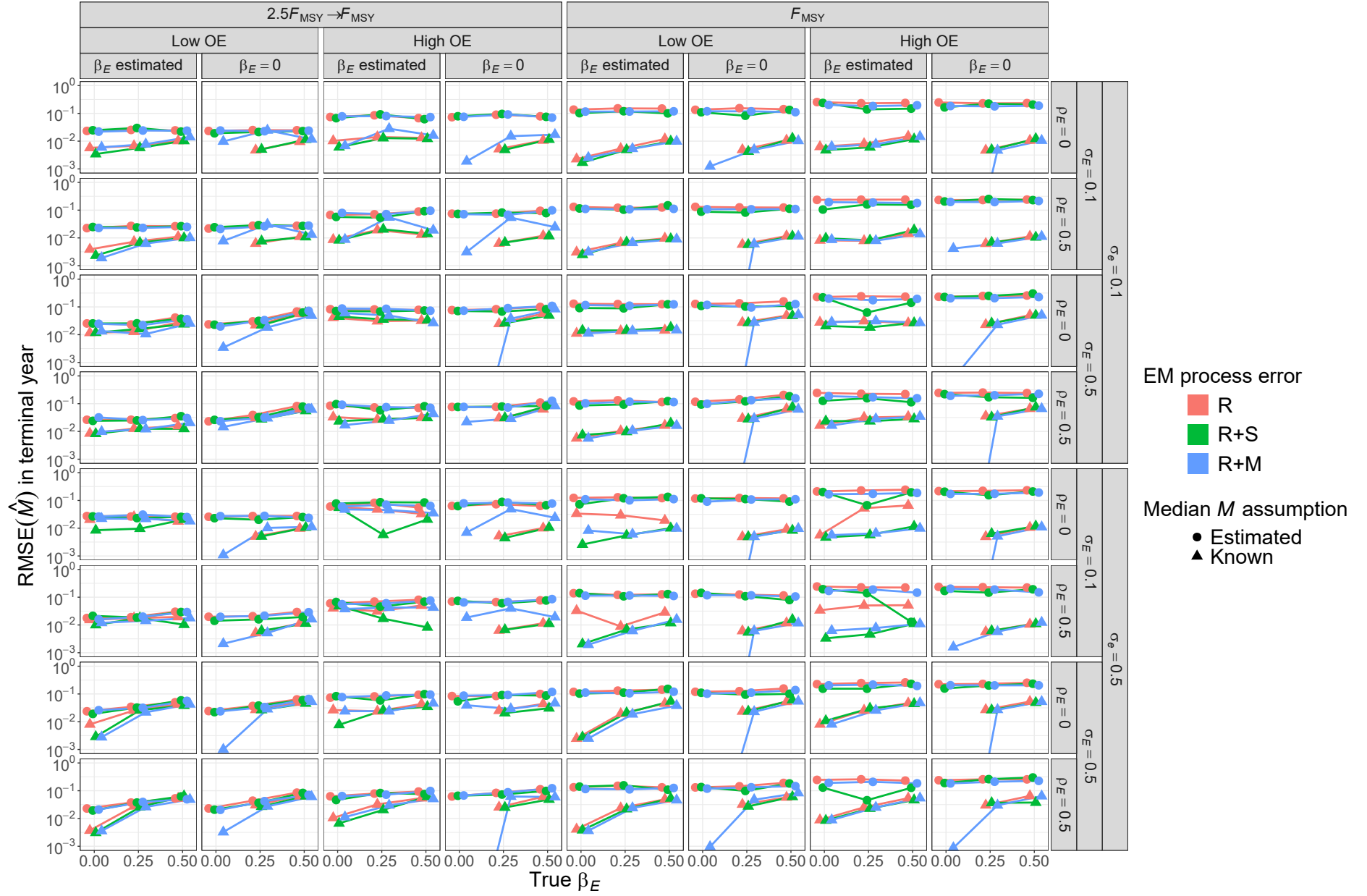


Fig. S47. For R OM, RMSE of estimates of terminal year M for EMs with alternative process error assumptions, treatment of covariate effect ($\beta_E = 0$ or estimated), and treatment of median M parameter (β_M estimated or known).

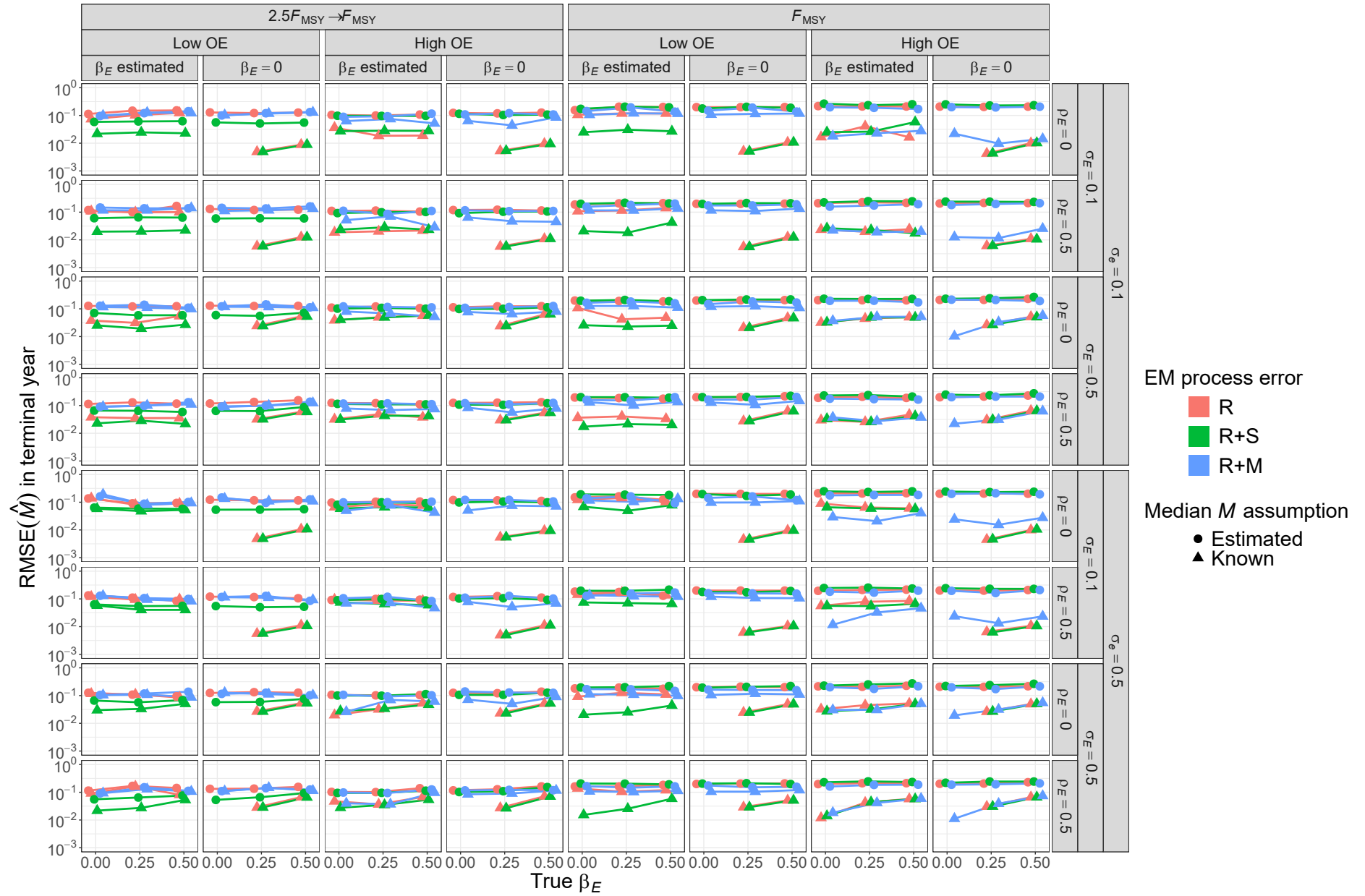


Fig. S48. For R+S OM, RMSE of estimates of terminal year M for EMs with alternative process error assumptions, treatment of covariate effect ($\beta_E = 0$ or estimated), and treatment of median M parameter (β_M estimated or known).

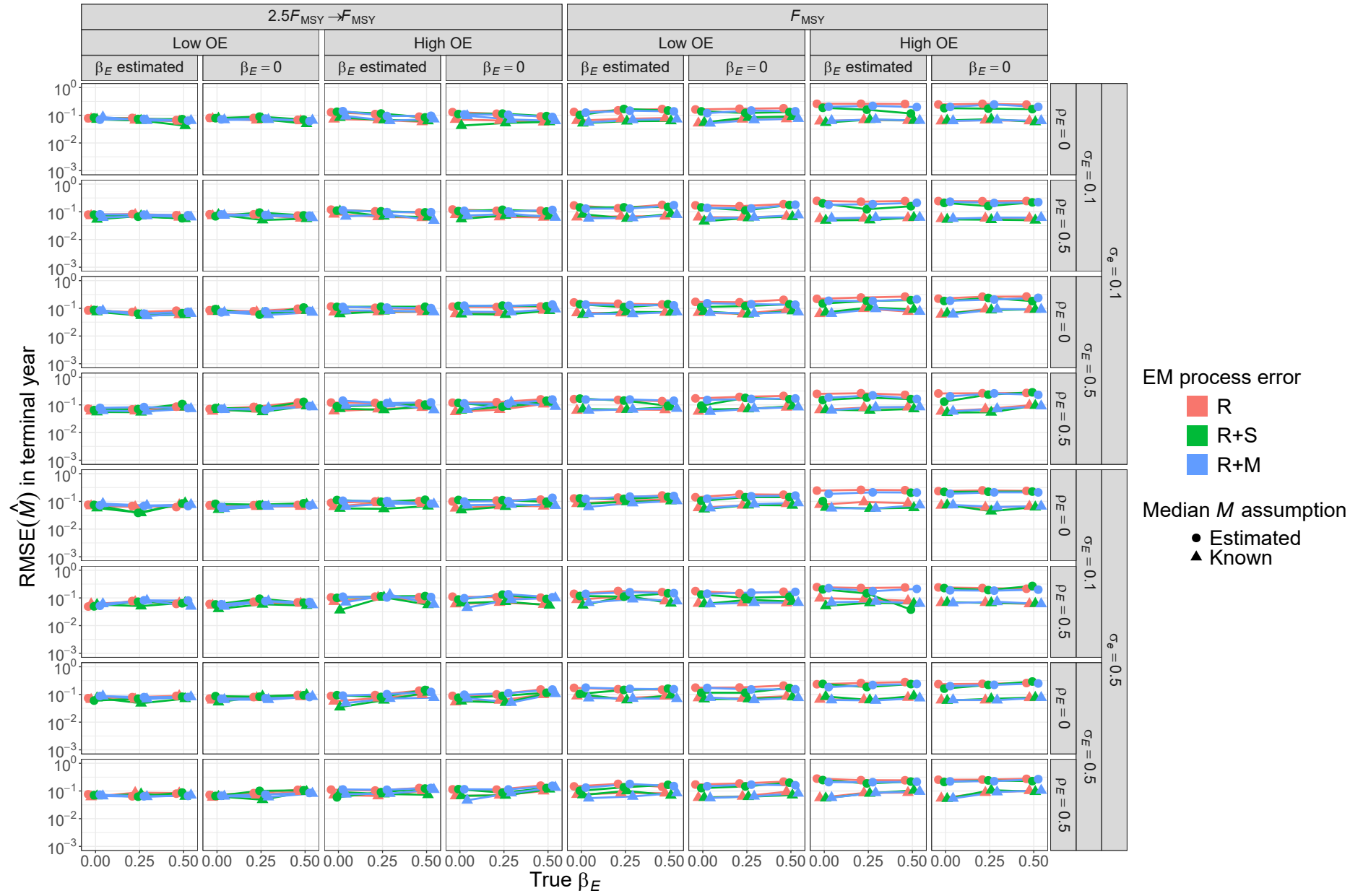


Fig. S49. For R+M OMs, RMSE of estimates of terminal year M for EMs with alternative process error assumptions, treatment of covariate effect ($\beta_E = 0$ or estimated), and treatment of median M parameter (β_M estimated or known).

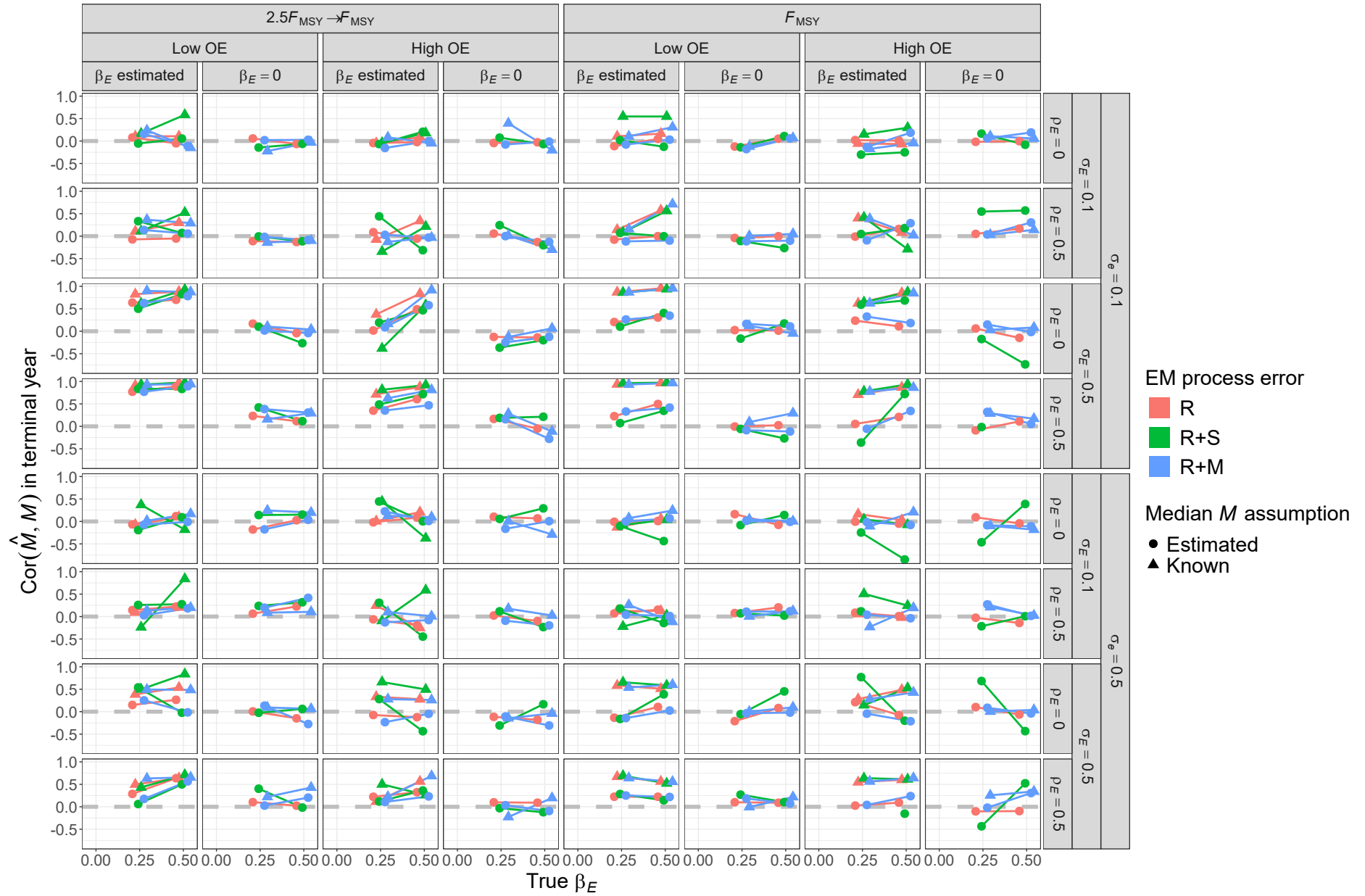


Fig. S50. For R OMs, correlation of estimates and true values of terminal year M for EMs with alternative process error assumptions, treatment of covariate effect ($\beta_E = 0$ or estimated), and treatment of median M parameter (β_M estimated or known).

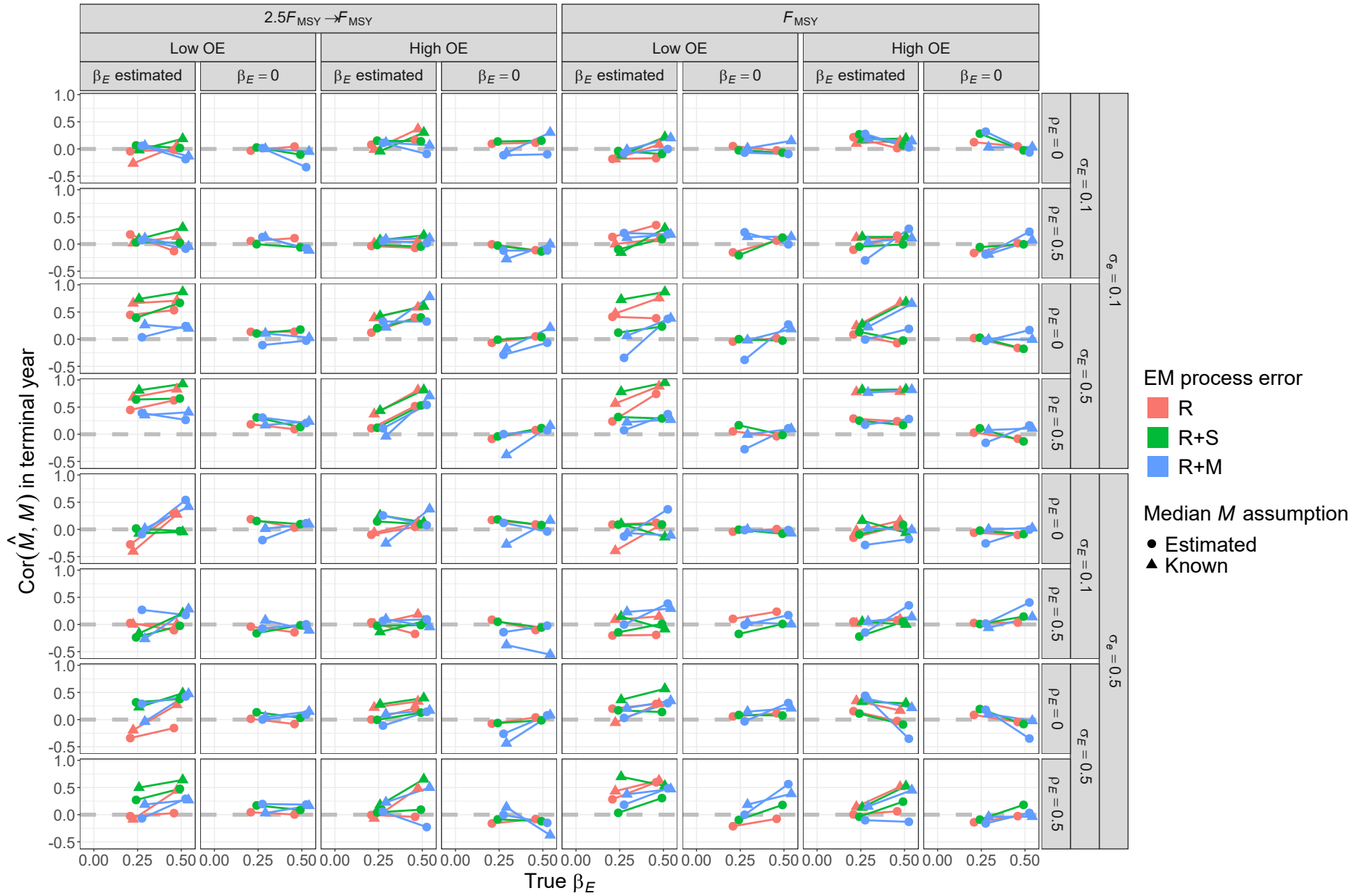


Fig. S51. For R+S OM, correlation of estimates and true values of terminal year M for EMs with alternative process error assumptions, treatment of covariate effect ($\beta_E = 0$ or estimated), and treatment of median M parameter (β_M estimated or known).

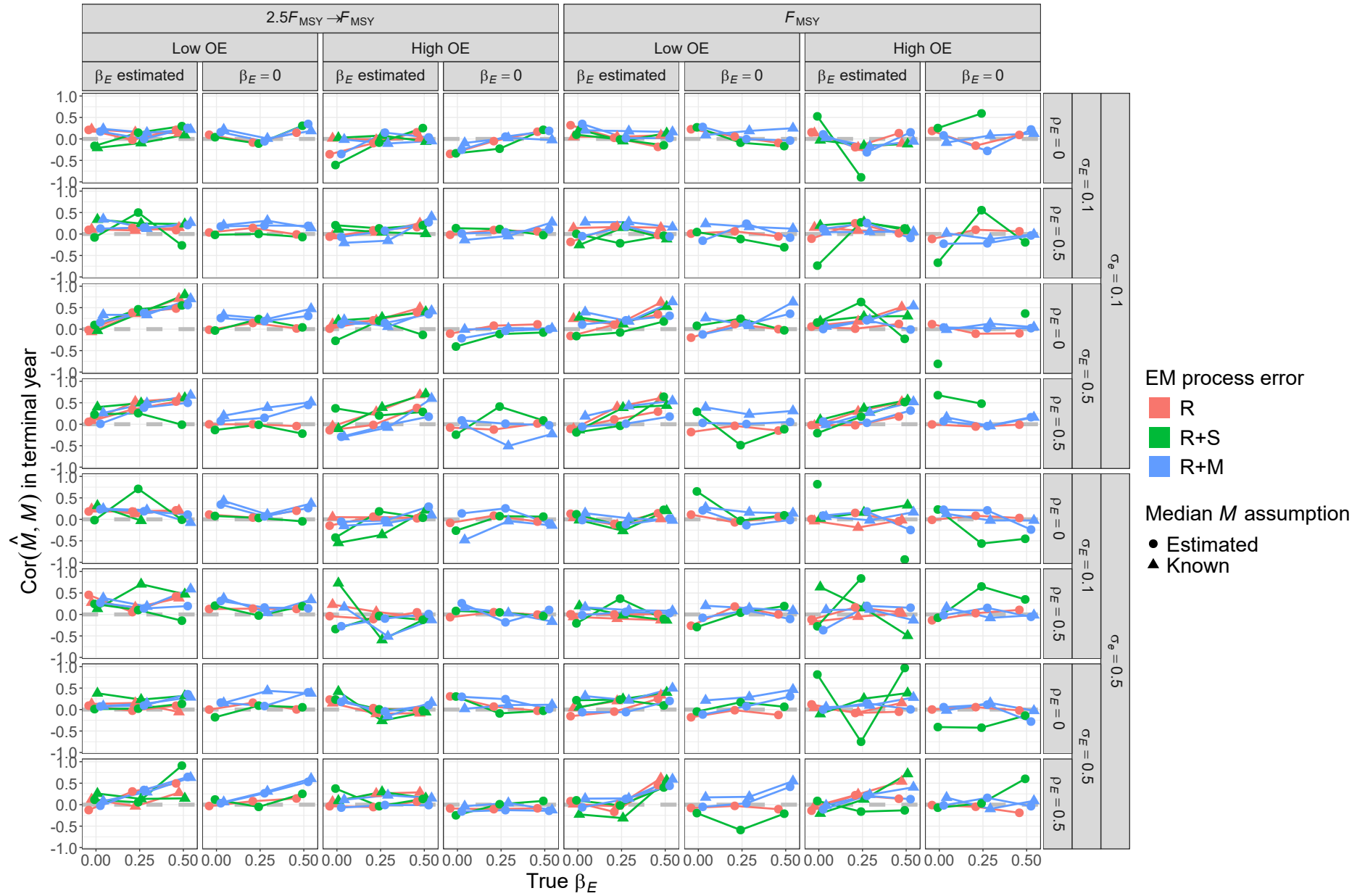


Fig. S52. For R+M OMs, correlation of estimates and true values of terminal year M for EMs with alternative process error assumptions, treatment of covariate effect ($\beta_E = 0$ or estimated), and treatment of median M parameter (β_M estimated or known).

905 **Terminal year spawning stock biomass bias**

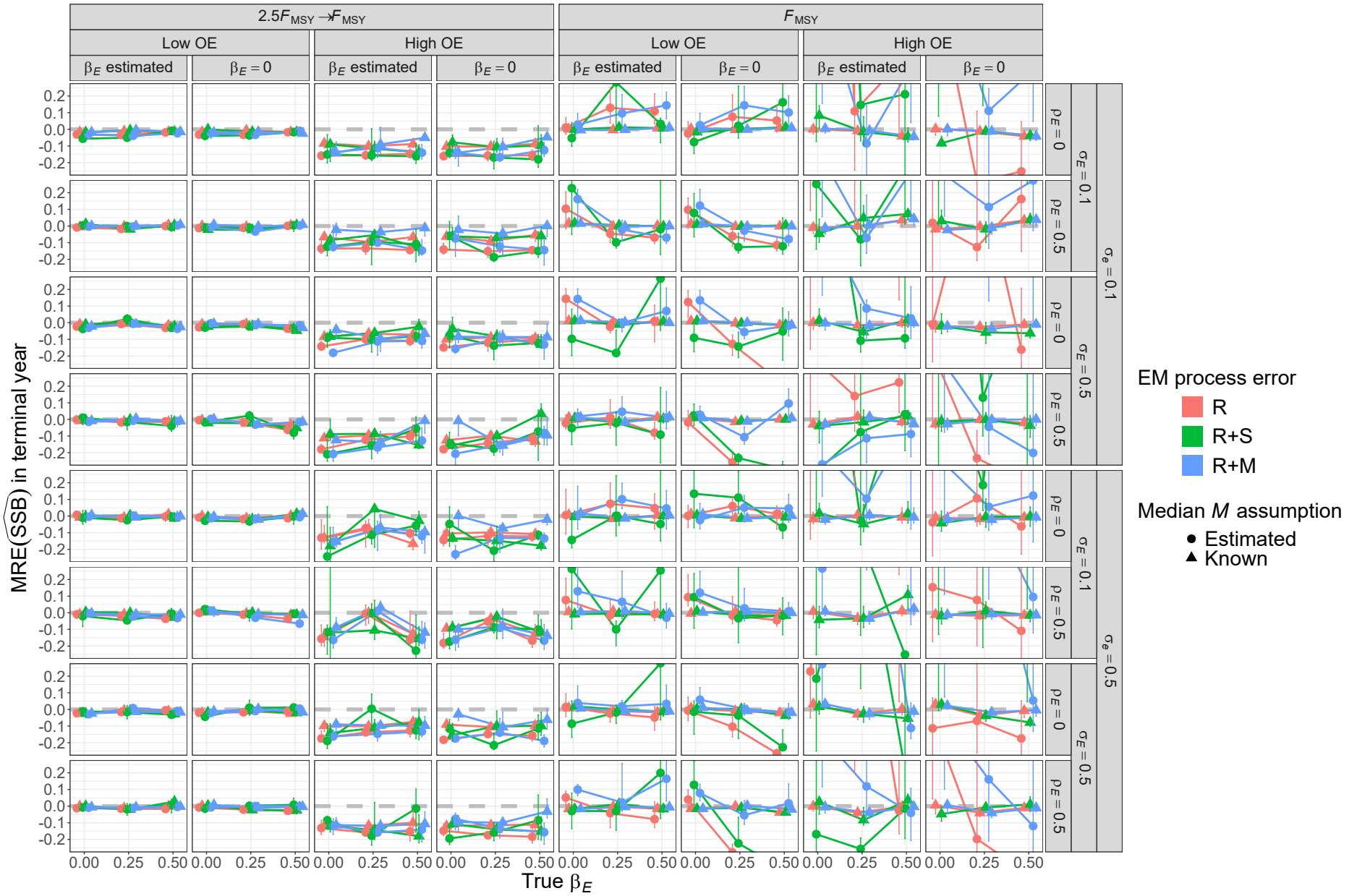


Fig. S53. For R OM, median relative error (MRE) of estimates of SSB in the terminal year for EMs with alternative process error assumptions, treatment of covariate effect ($\beta_E = 0$ or estimated), and treatment of median M parameter (β_M estimated or known).

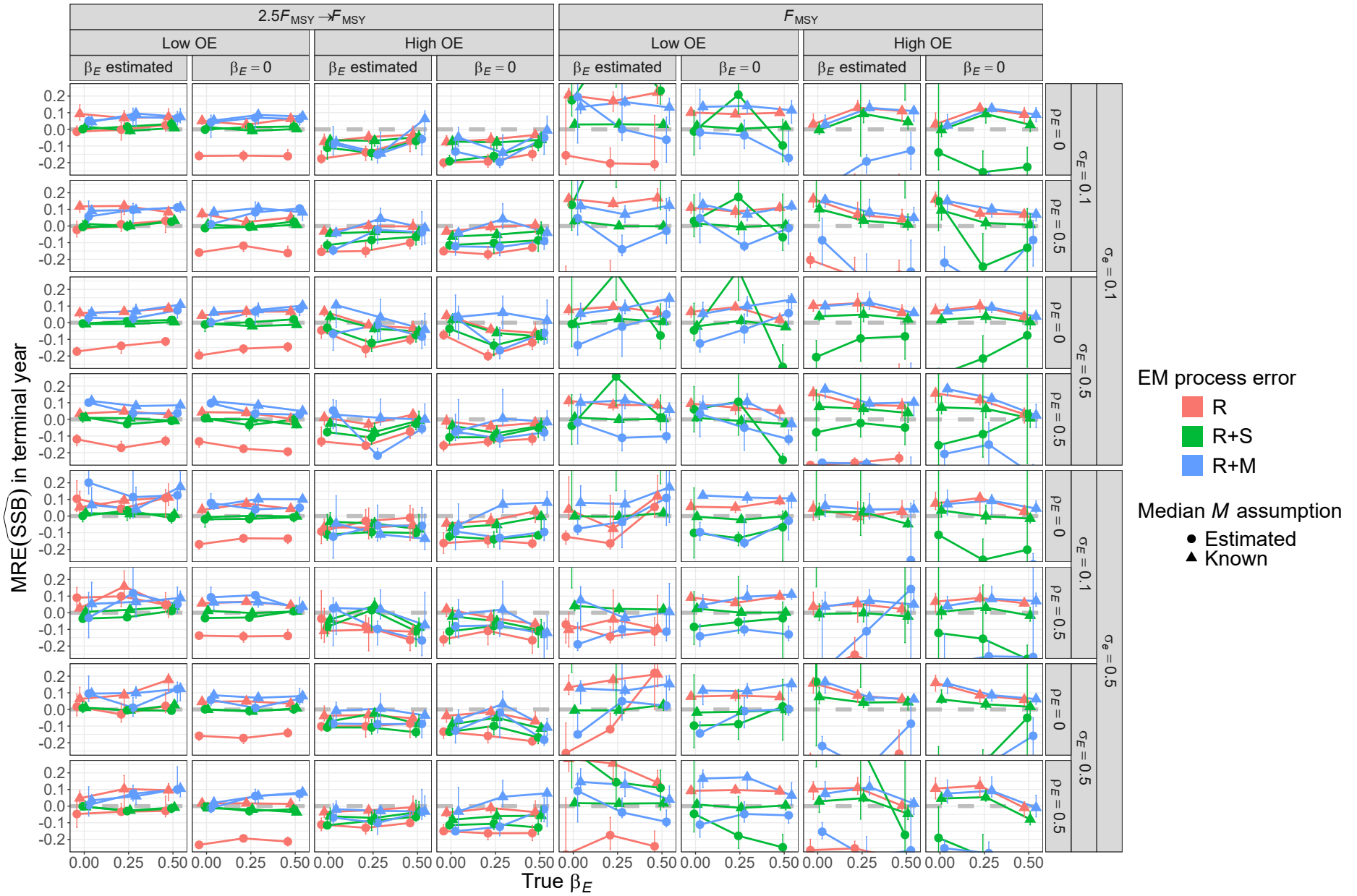


Fig. S54. For R+S OM, median relative error (MRE) of SSB in the terminal year for EMs with alternative process error assumptions, treatment of covariate effect ($\beta_E = 0$ or estimated), and treatment of median M parameter (β_M estimated or known).

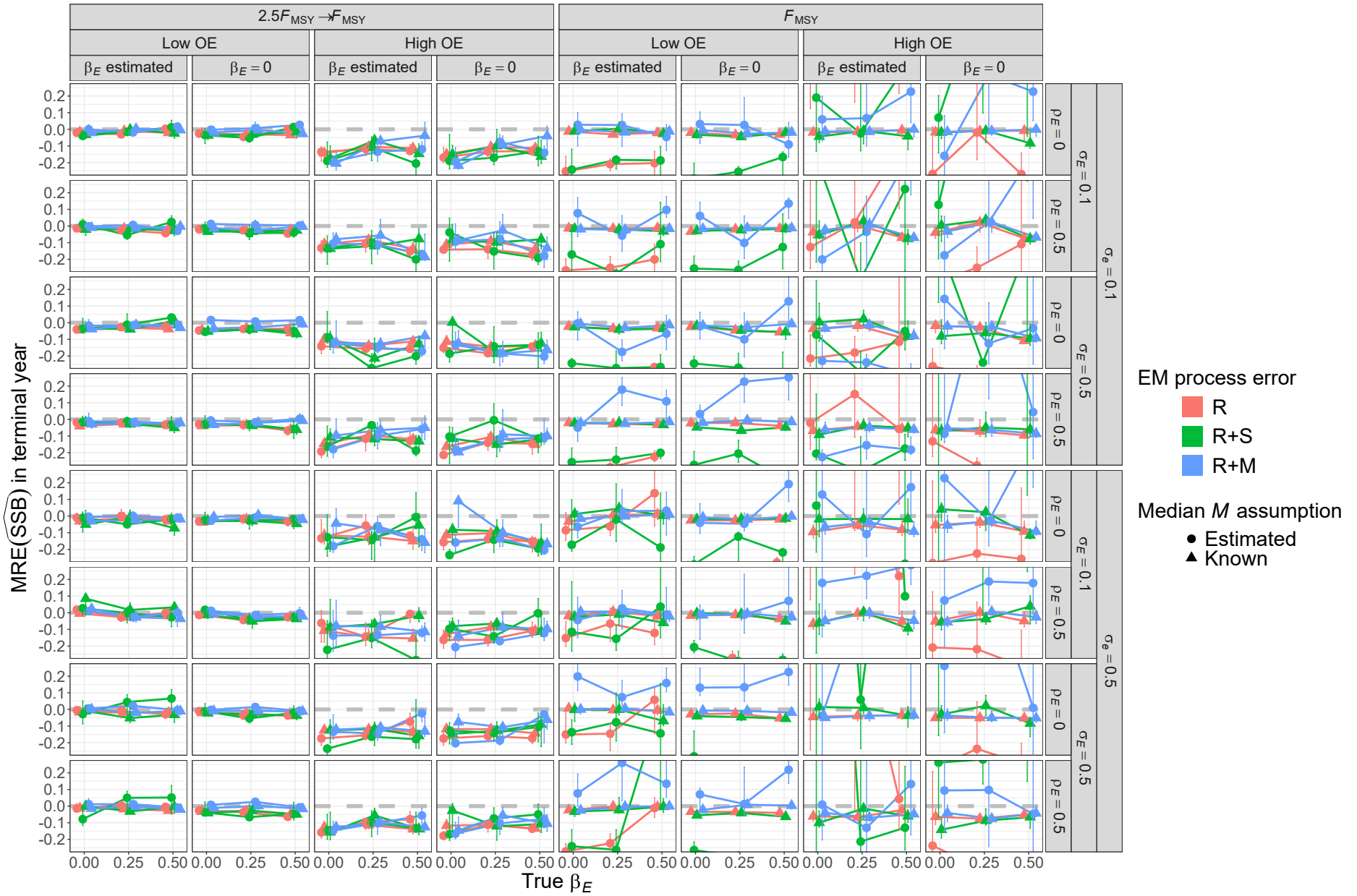


Fig. S55. For R+M OM, median relative error (MRE) of estimates of SSB in the terminal year for EMs with alternative process error assumptions, treatment of covariate effect ($\beta_E = 0$ or estimated), and treatment of median M parameter (β_M estimated or known).

906 **Terminal year spawning stock biomass accuracy**

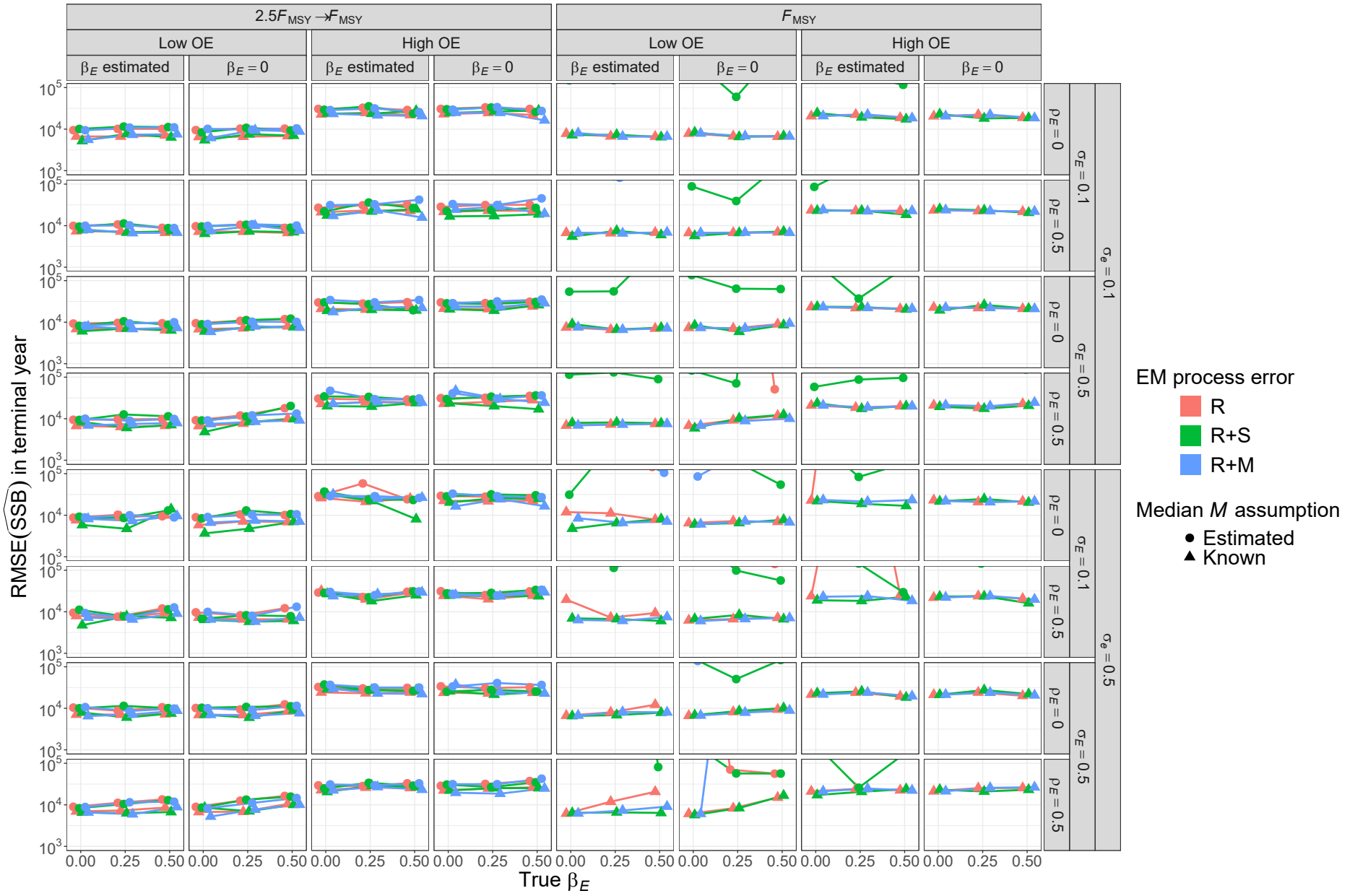


Fig. S56. For R OMs, RMSE of estimates of SSB in the terminal year for EMs with alternative process error assumptions, treatment of covariate effect ($\beta_E = 0$ or estimated), and treatment of median M parameter (β_M estimated or known).

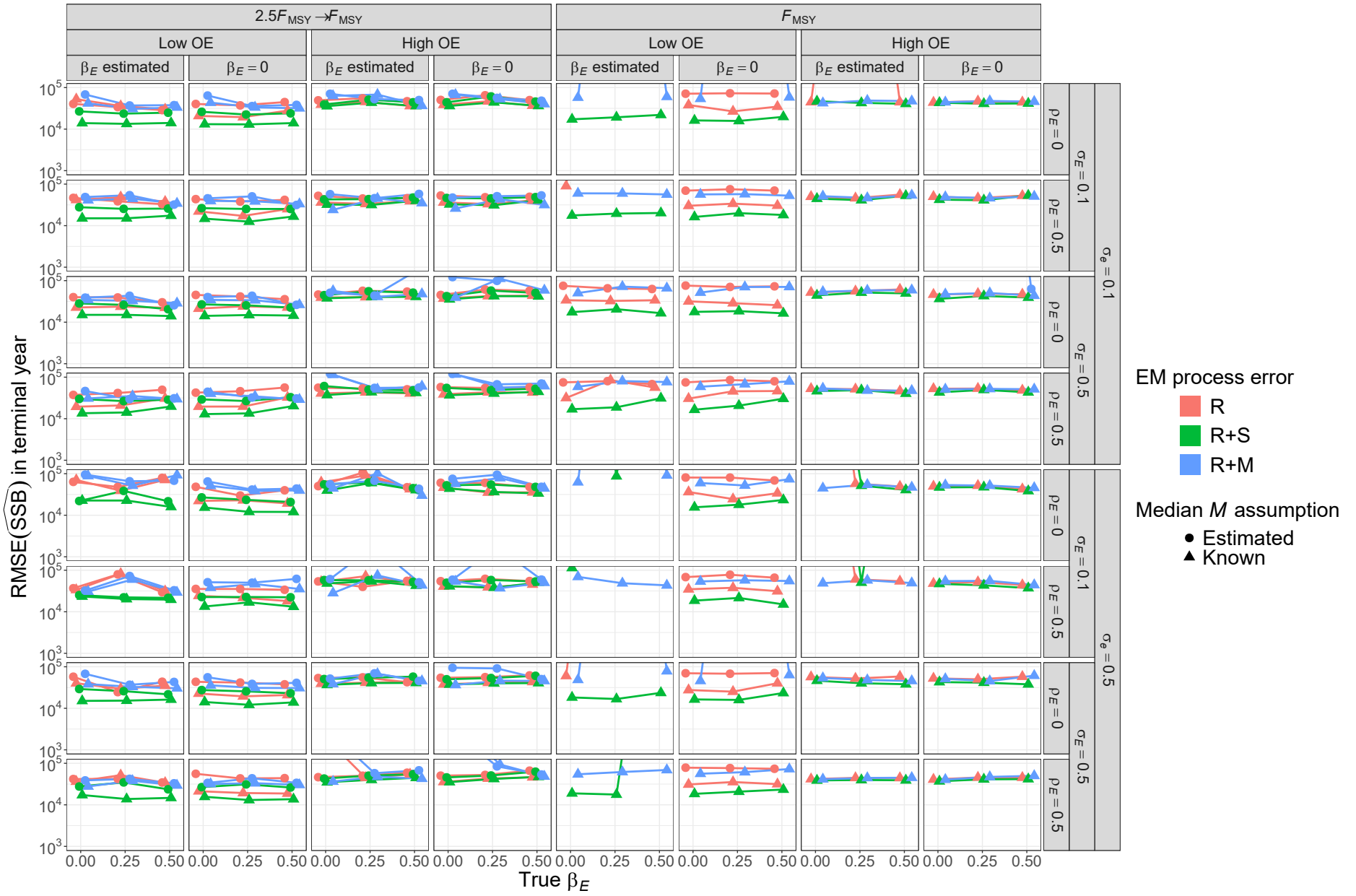


Fig. S57. For R+S OMs, RMSE of estimates of SSB in the terminal year for EMs with alternative process error assumptions, treatment of covariate effect ($\beta_E = 0$ or estimated), and treatment of median M parameter (β_M estimated or known).

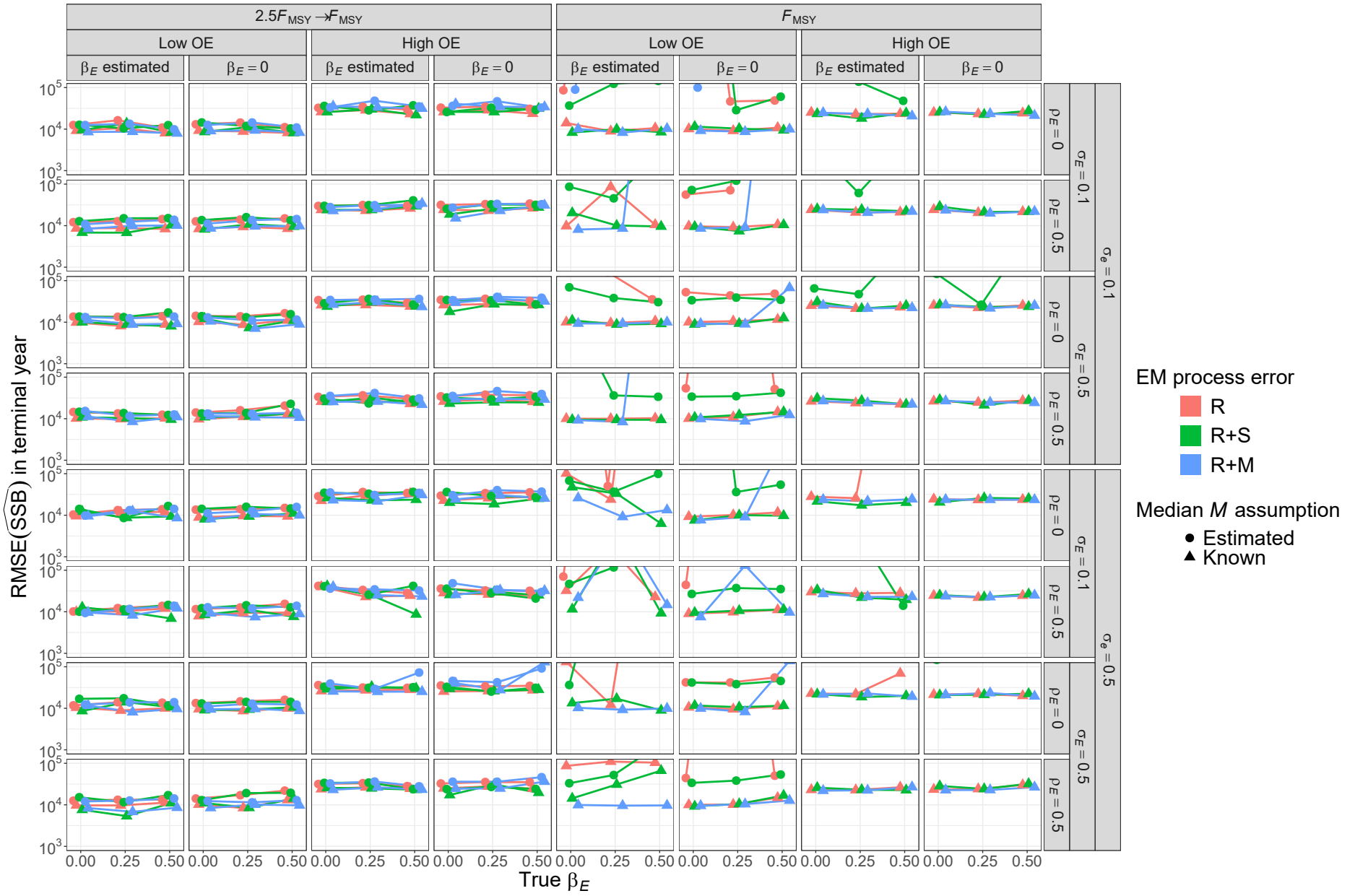


Fig. S58. For R+M OM, RMSE of estimates of SSB in the terminal year for EMs with alternative process error assumptions, treatment of covariate effect ($\beta_E = 0$ or estimated), and treatment of median M parameter (β_M estimated or known).

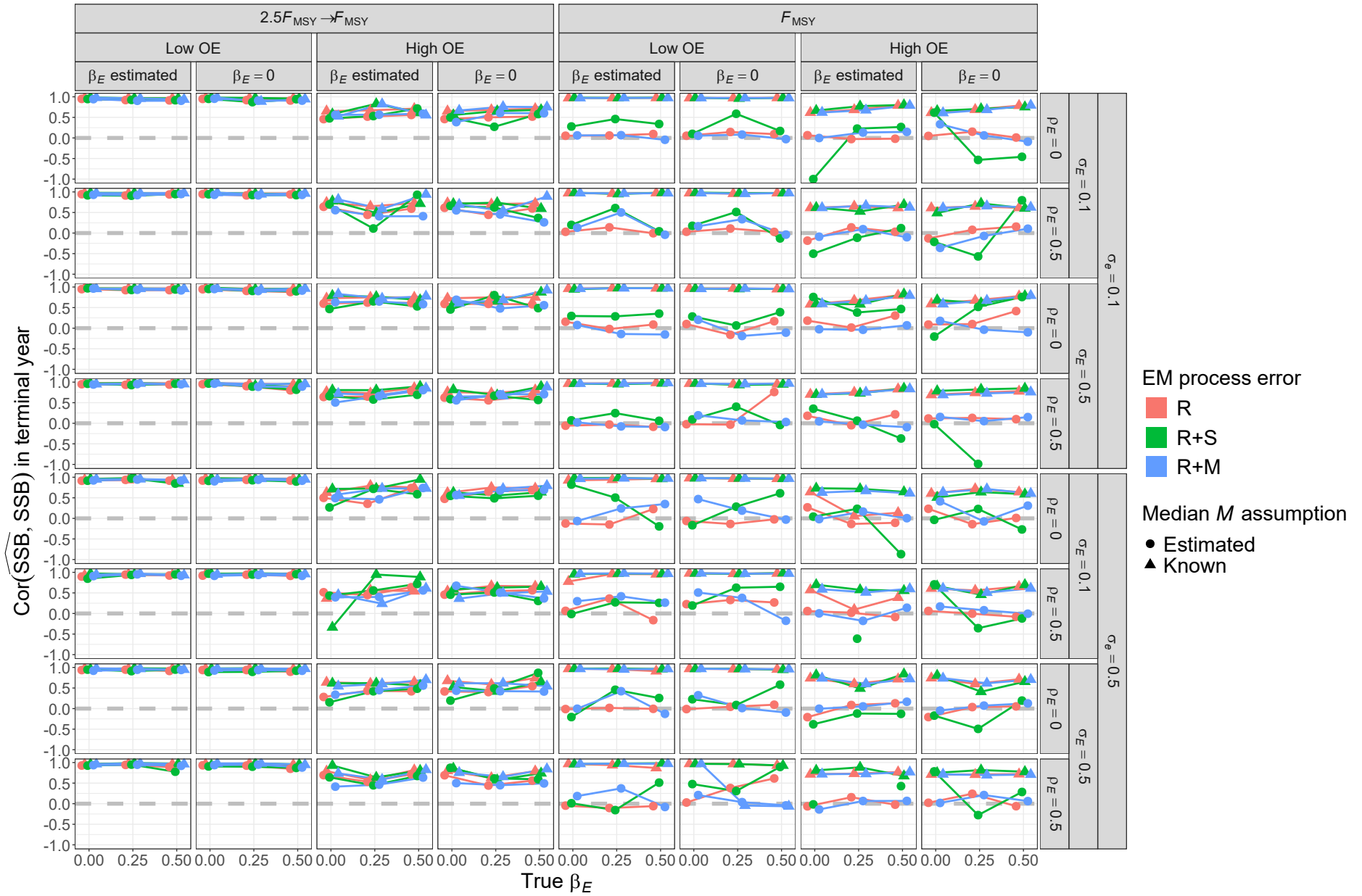


Fig. S59. For R OMs, correlation of estimates and true values of terminal year SSB for EMs with alternative process error assumptions, treatment of covariate effect ($\beta_E = 0$ or estimated), and treatment of median M parameter (β_M estimated or known).

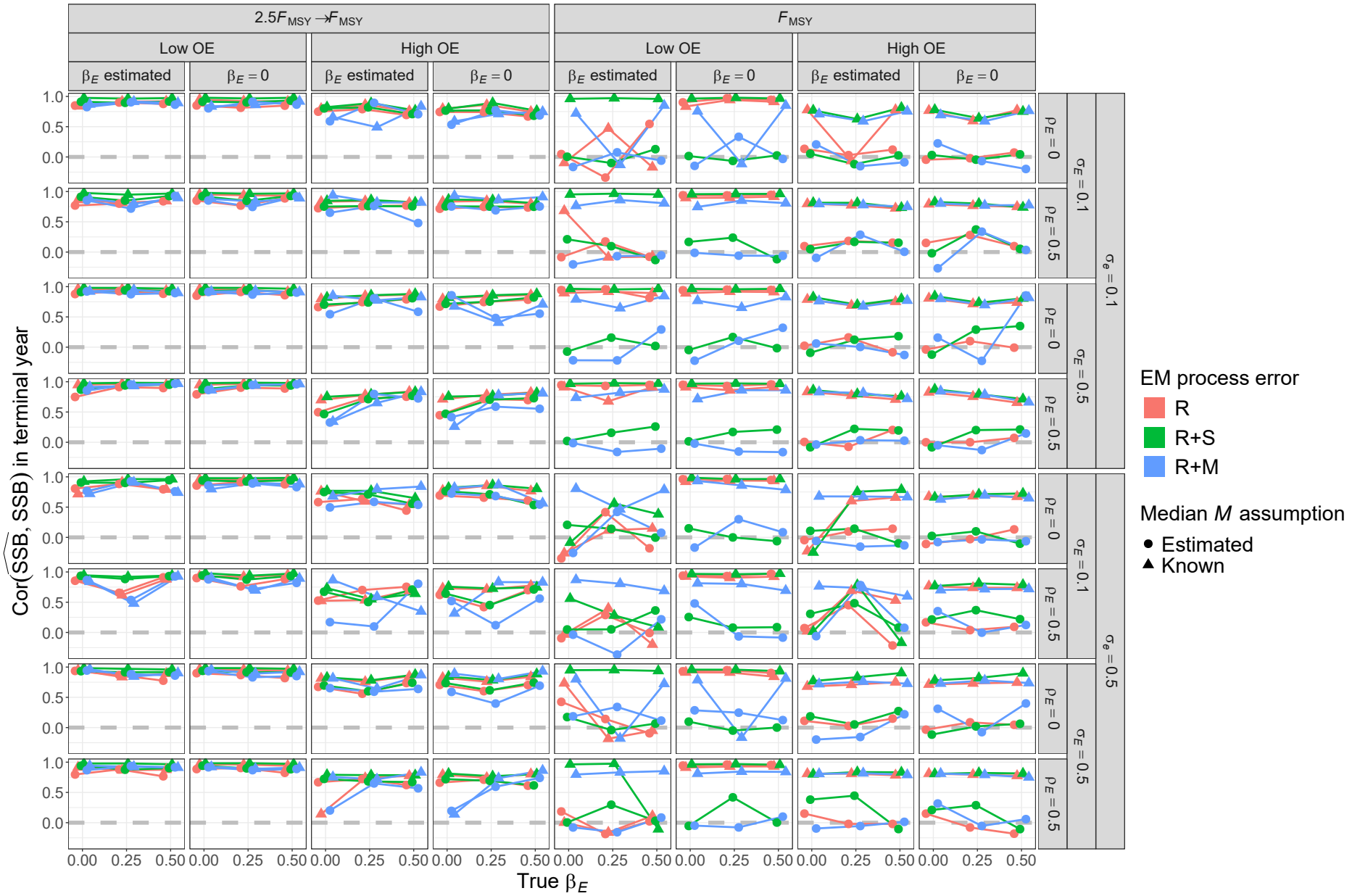


Fig. S60. For R+S OM, correlation of estimates and true values of terminal year SSB for EMs with alternative process error assumptions, treatment of covariate effect ($\beta_E = 0$ or estimated), and treatment of median M parameter (β_M estimated or known).

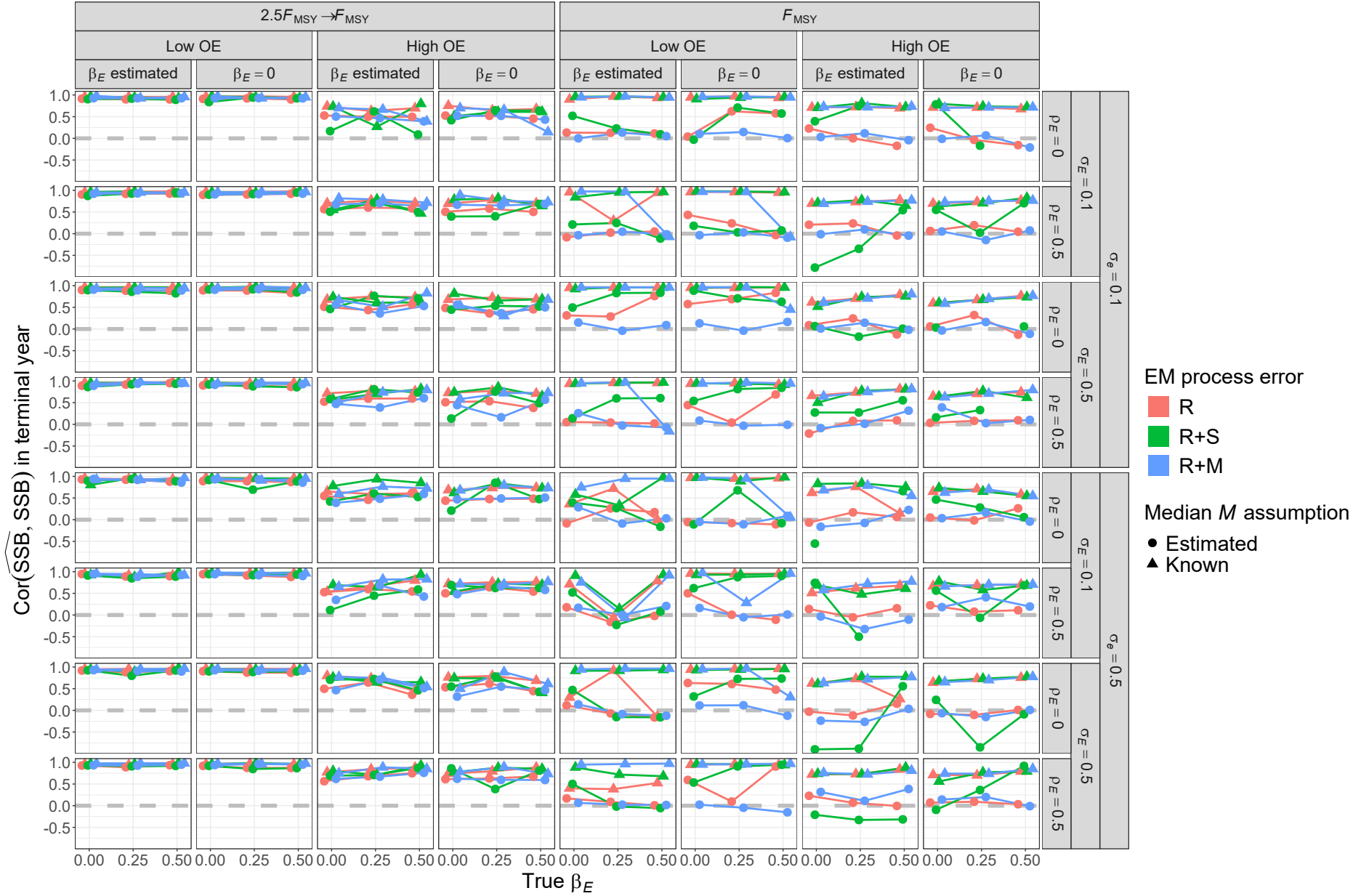


Fig. S61. For R+M OMs, correlation of estimates and true values of terminal year SSB for EMs with alternative process error assumptions, treatment of covariate effect ($\beta_E = 0$ or estimated), and treatment of median M parameter (β_M estimated or known).

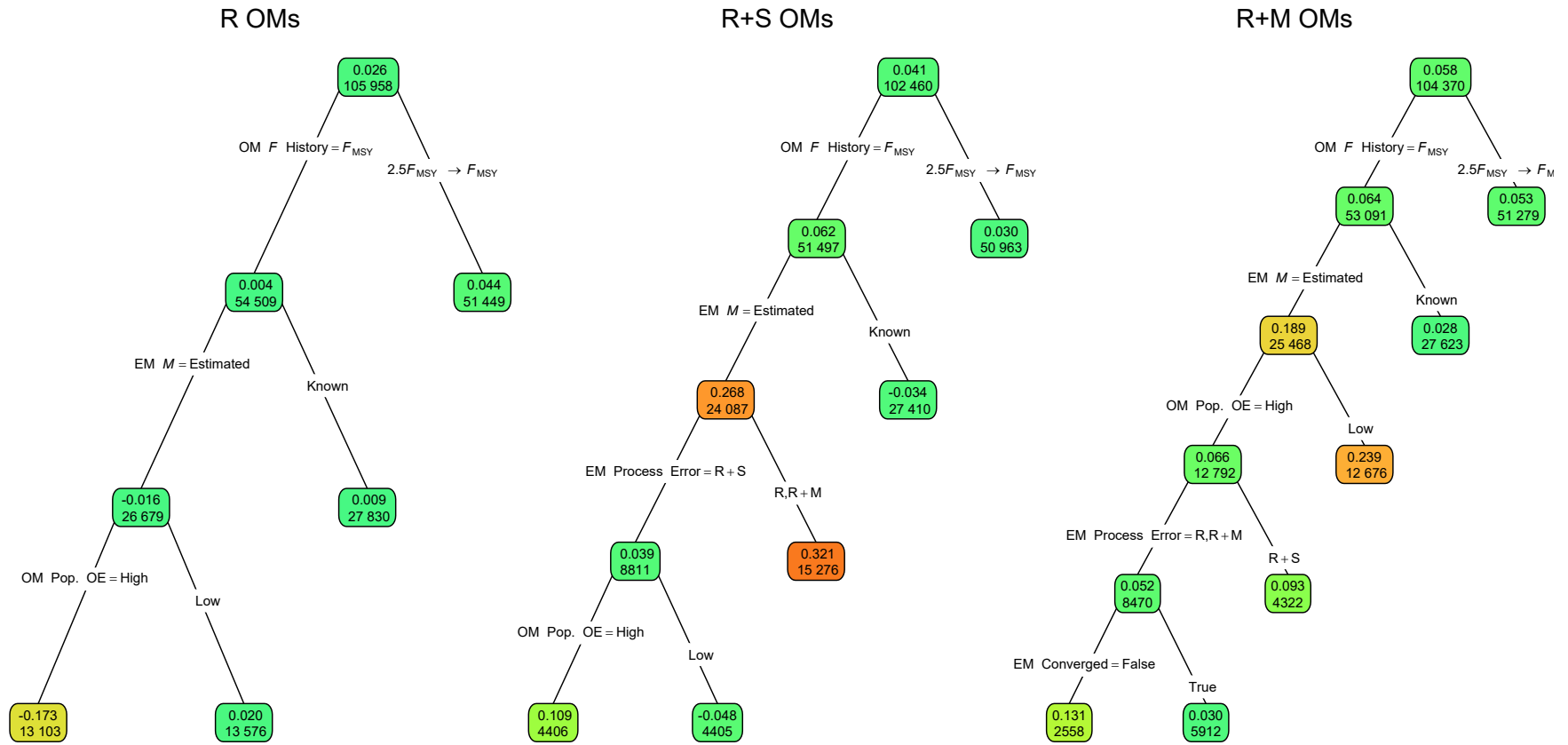


Fig. S62. Regression trees indicating primary factors determining reductions in sums of squares of errors in estimation measured by Eq. 2 for the terminal year fishing mortality rate in EMs fitted to operating models (OMs) with process error on recruitment only (R), recruitment and apparent survival (R+S), or recruitment and natural mortality (R+M). Each node shows the median error (top) and number of observations (bottom) for the corresponding subset. Lower or higher median absolute errors of the process error assumption are indicated by more green or red polygons, respectively.

Table S12. Percent reduction in deviance for linear regression models fit to errors in estimation measured by Eq. 2 for the terminal year fishing mortality rates. Table rows give each operating model (OM) and estimating model (EM) factor included individually, combined, and with second and third order interactions. Table columns are operating models (OMs) with process error on recruitment only (R), recruitment and apparent survival (R+S), or recruitment and natural mortality (R+M).

Factor	R	R+S	R+M
Convergence	<0.01	0.19	0.01
OM F history	1.92	2.42	1.94
OM Obs. Error	0.74	0.12	1.12
OM σ_e	0.01	<0.01	<0.01
OM σ_E	<0.01	<0.01	<0.01
OM ρ_E	<0.01	<0.01	<0.01
OM β_E	<0.01	0.01	<0.01
EM Process Error	0.40	0.92	0.48
EM β_E assumption	0.01	0.03	0.02
EM M assumption	1.58	1.85	1.68
All factors	4.95	5.82	5.35
+ All Two Way	10.91	11.03	12.23
+ All Three Way	14.16	13.24	16.19

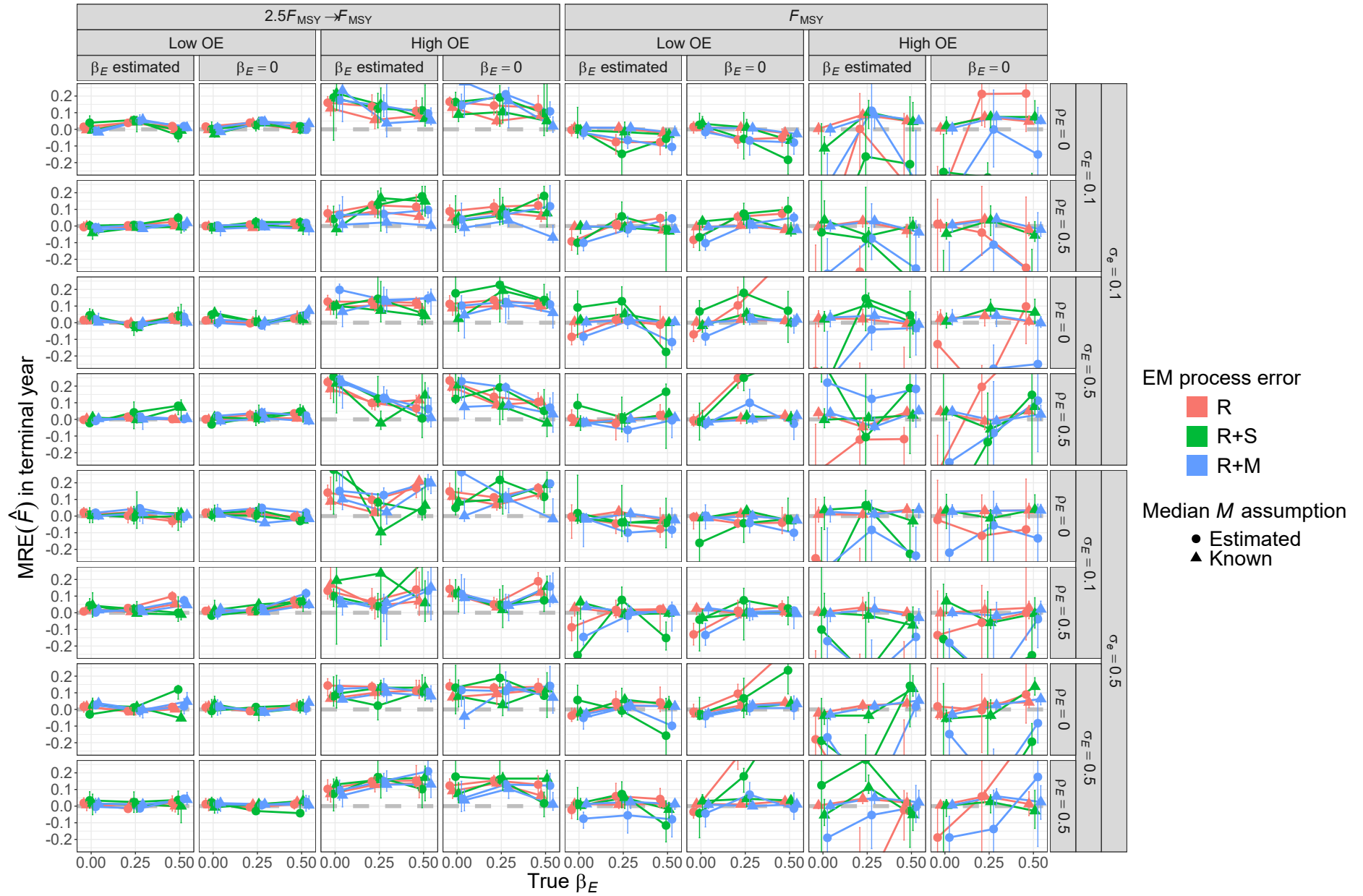


Fig. S63. For R OMs, median relative error (MRE) of estimates of fully-selected fishing mortality (F) in the terminal year for EMs with alternative process error assumptions, treatment of covariate effect ($\beta_E = 0$ or estimated), and treatment of median M parameter (β_M estimated or known). All OMs had low observation error and contrast in fishing mortality.

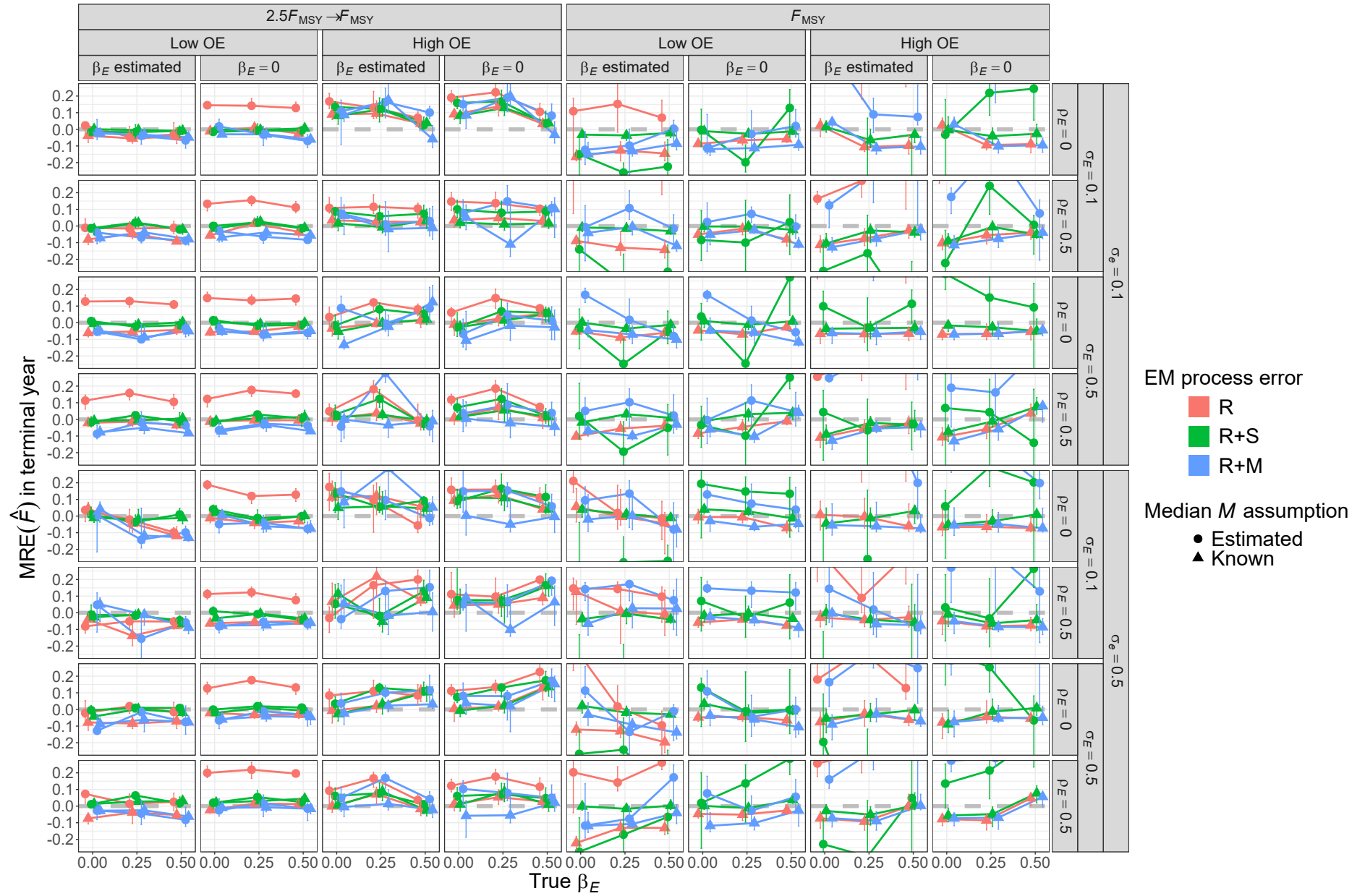


Fig. S64. For R+S OMs, median relative error (MRE) of estimates of fully-selected fishing mortality (F) in the terminal year for EMs with alternative process error assumptions, treatment of covariate effect ($\beta_E = 0$ or estimated), and treatment of median M parameter (β_M estimated or known). All OMs had low observation error and contrast in fishing mortality.

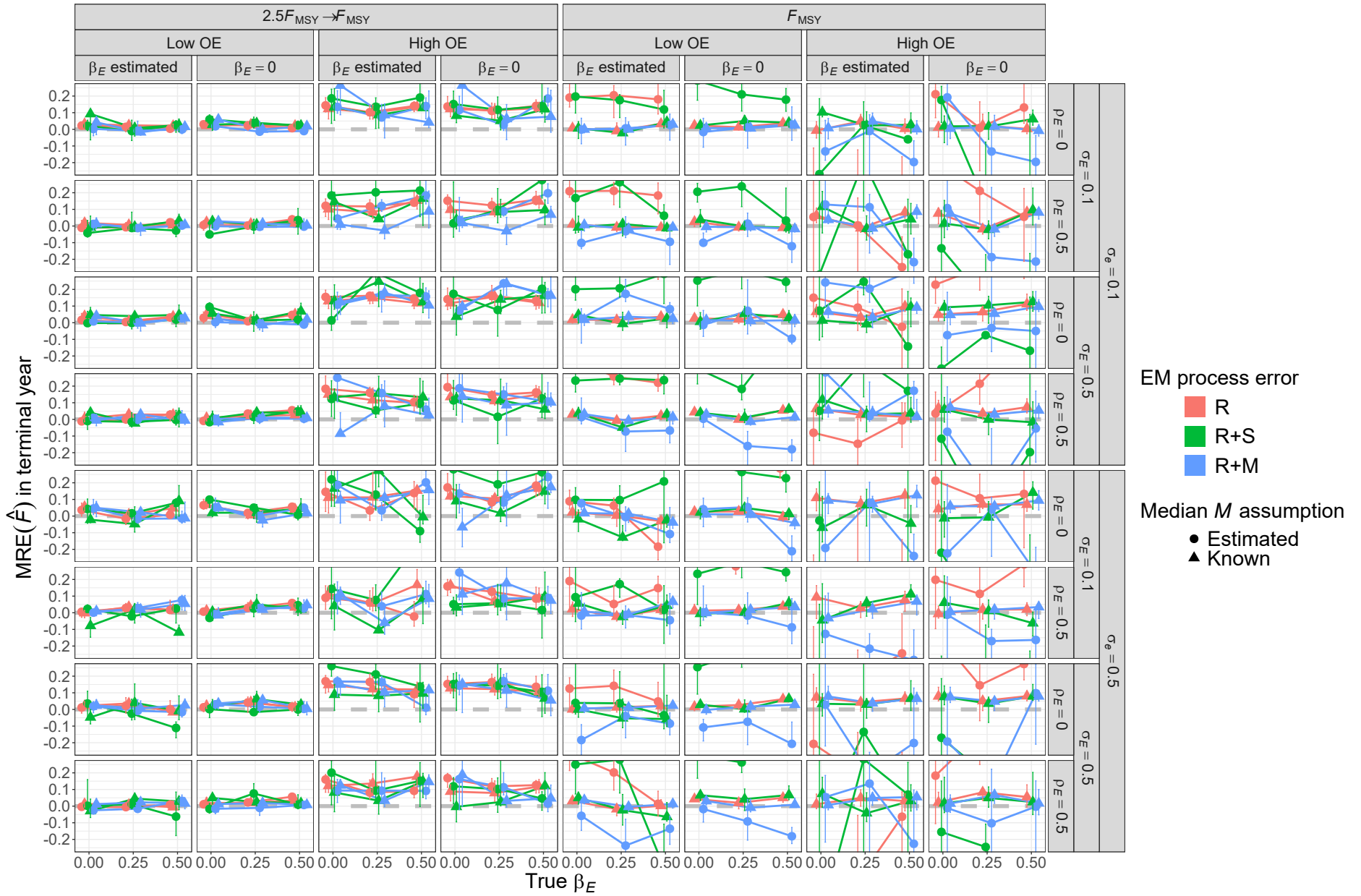


Fig. S65. For R+M OMs, median relative error (MRE) of estimates of fully-selected fishing mortality (F) in the terminal year for EMs with alternative process error assumptions, treatment of covariate effect ($\beta_E = 0$ or estimated), and treatment of median M parameter (β_M estimated or known). All OMs had low observation error and contrast in fishing mortality.

908 **Terminal year fishing mortality accuracy**

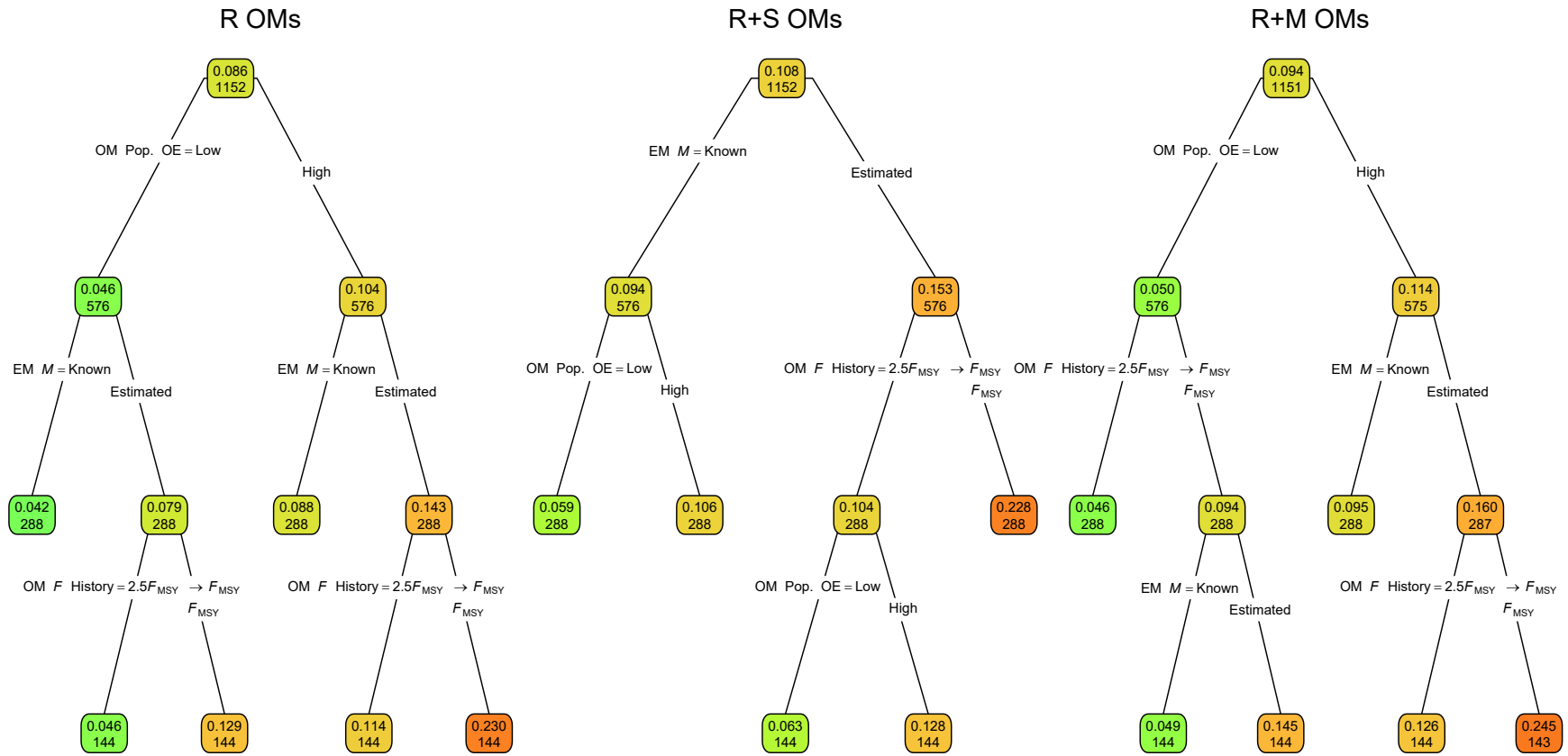


Fig. S66. Regression trees indicating primary factors determining reductions in sums of squares of errors for the log-transformed RMSE of terminal year fishing mortality rate in EMs fitted to operating models (OMs) with process error on recruitment only (R), recruitment and apparent survival (R+S), or recruitment and natural mortality (R+M). Each node shows the median error (top) and number of observations (bottom) for the corresponding subset. Lower or higher median RMSE are indicated by more green or red polygons, respectively.

Table S13. Percent reduction in deviance for linear regression models fit to log-transformed RMSE of terminal year fishing mortality rate. Table rows give each operating model (OM) and estimating model (EM) factor included individually, combined, and with second and third order interactions. Table columns are operating models (OMs) with process error on recruitment only (R), recruitment and apparent survival (R+S), or recruitment and natural mortality (R+M).

Factor	R	R+S	R+M
OM F history	11.29	25.63	13.46
OM Obs. Error	37.27	21.42	35.47
$OM\sigma_e$	<0.01	0.02	0.02
$OM\sigma_E$	0.09	0.03	0.14
$OM\rho_E$	0.02	0.01	0.04
OM β_E	0.15	0.03	0.21
EM Process Error	0.42	0.75	0.63
$EM\beta_E$ assumption	0.04	<0.01	0.04
EM M assumption	25.38	26.10	24.68
All factors	74.65	73.99	74.76
+ All Two Way	92.28	91.29	91.64
+ All Three Way	94.31	95.51	93.73

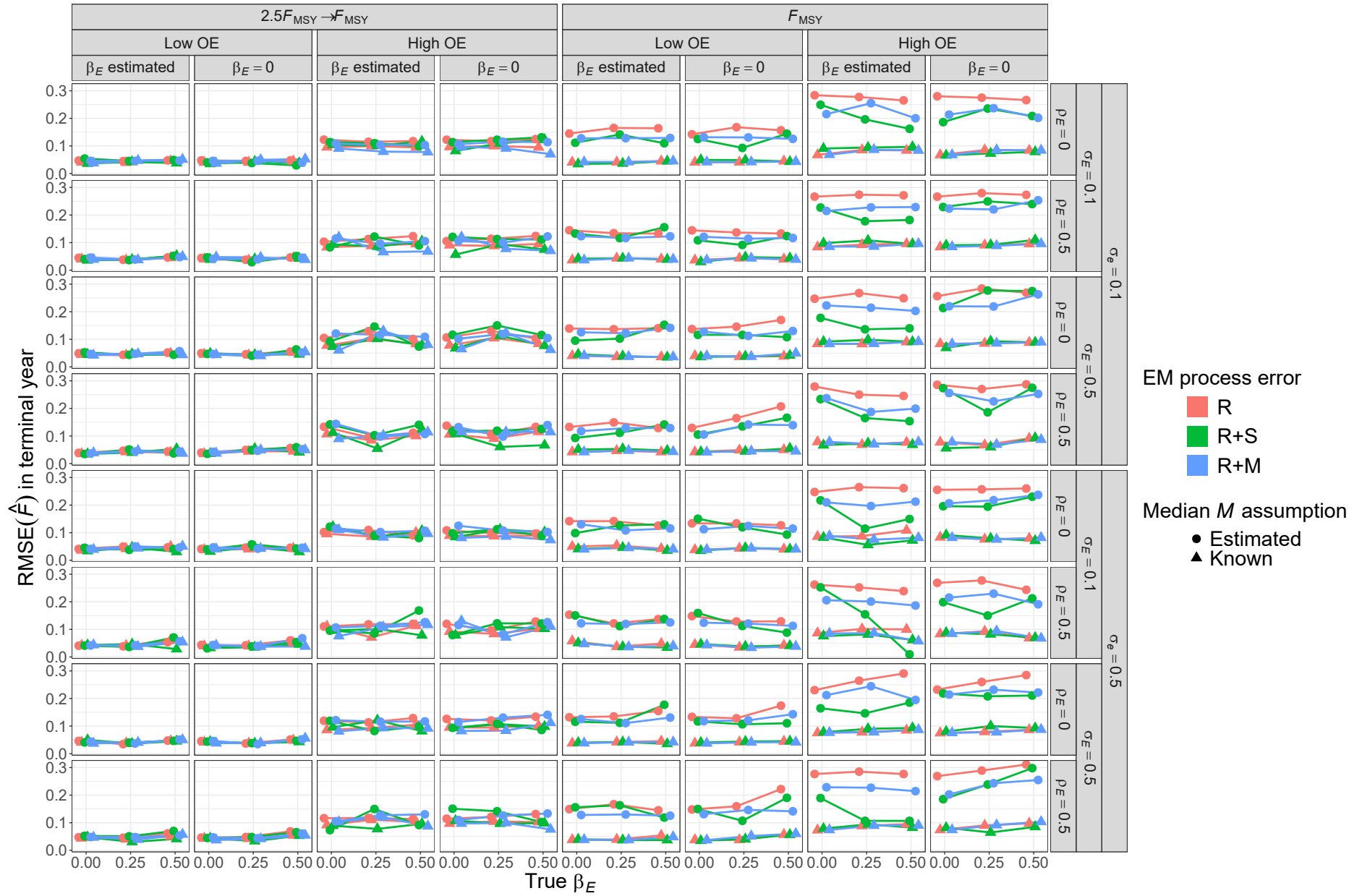


Fig. S67. For R OMs, RMSE of estimates of fully-selected fishing mortality (F) in the terminal year for EMs with alternative process error assumptions, treatment of covariate effect ($\beta_E = 0$ or estimated), and treatment of median M parameter (β_M estimated or known).

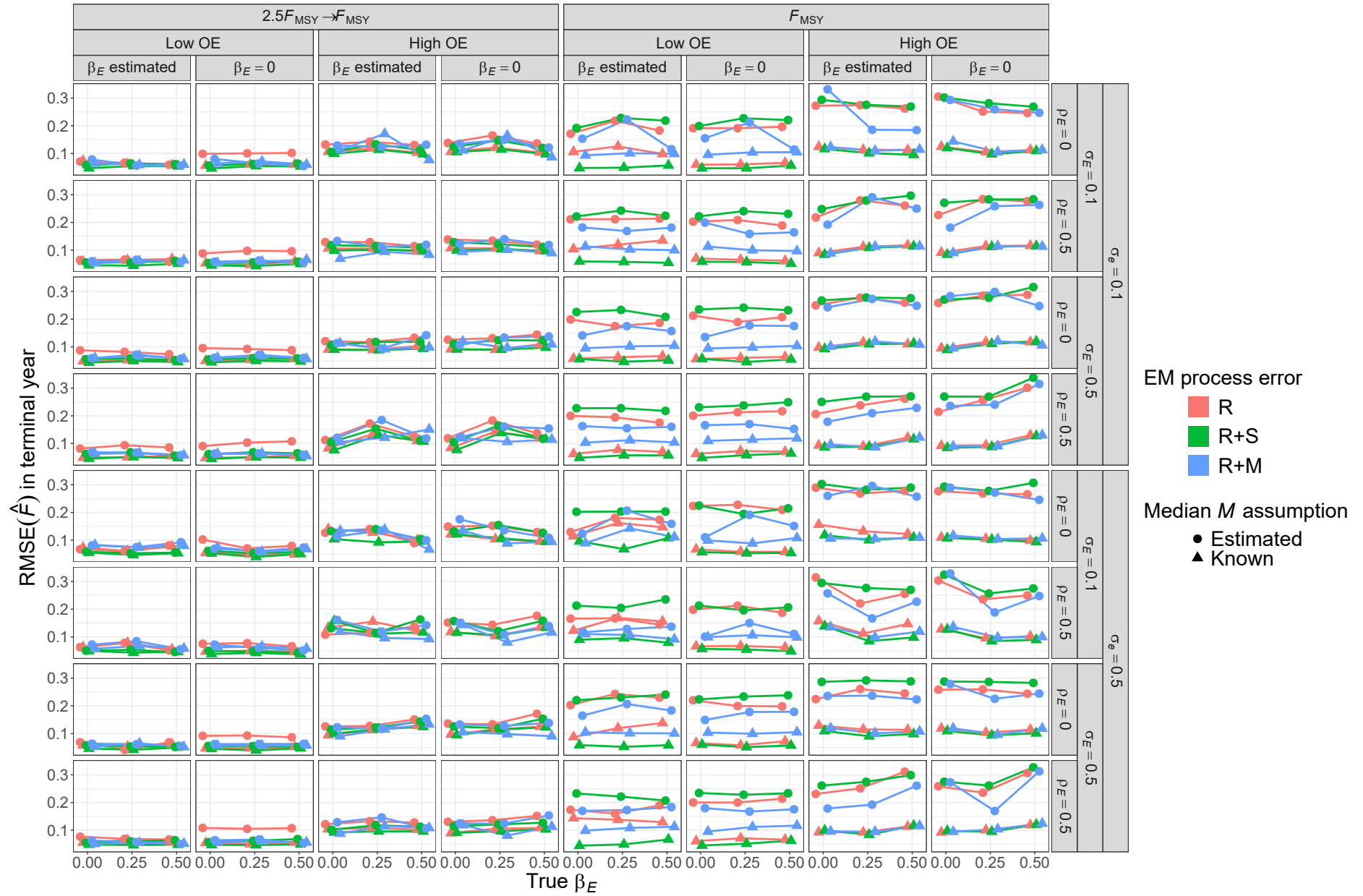


Fig. S68. For R+S OMs, RMSE of estimates of fully-selected fishing mortality (F) in the terminal year for EMs with alternative process error assumptions, treatment of covariate effect ($\beta_E = 0$ or estimated), and treatment of median M parameter (β_M estimated or known).

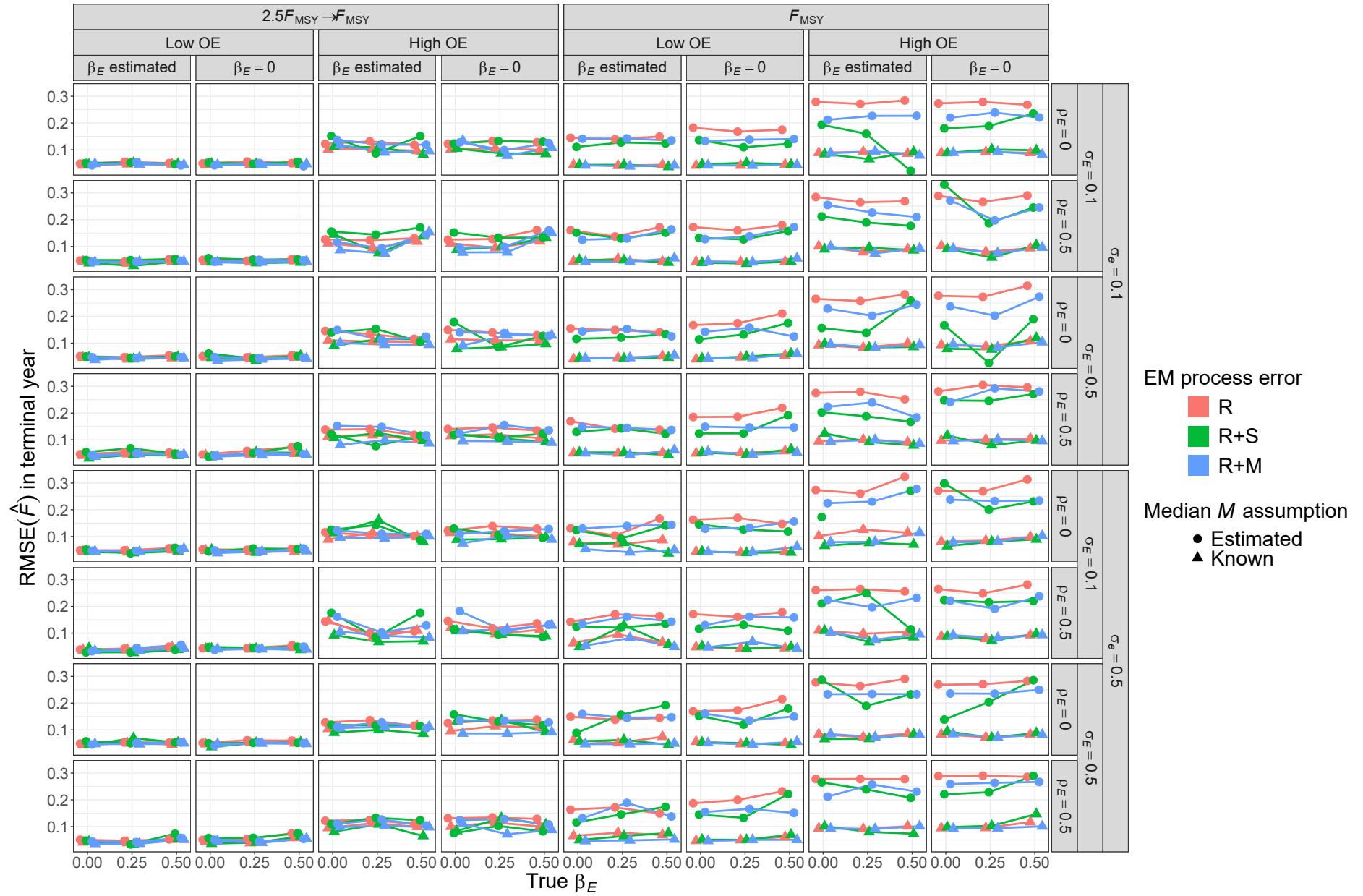


Fig. S69. For R+M OMs, RMSE of estimates of fully-selected fishing mortality (F) in the terminal year for EMs with alternative process error assumptions, treatment of covariate effect ($\beta_E = 0$ or estimated), and treatment of median M parameter (β_M estimated or known).